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सत्यमेव जयते
Government of India



Modernized Railway Better Infrastructure For Viksit Bharat



Laying of Foundation Stone for and Inauguration of Rail and Road
Infrastructure Projects worth

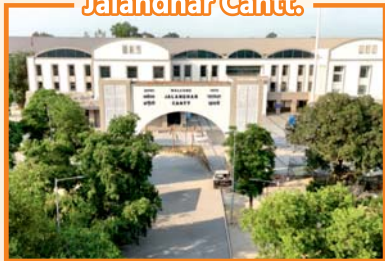
₹5,500 Crore

Inauguration of

75 Redeveloped Amrit Stations

- Stations being developed as vibrant city centres
- Boost to tourism, employment, and local trade in the region
- Equipped with modern, passenger-friendly amenities
- Building design inspired by local culture and architecture
- Enhanced parking facilities and spacious waiting areas
- Provision for water conservation, solar energy, and green spaces

Jalandhar Cantt.



Daulatpur Chowk – Kartoli Punjab Rail Line

- Improved passenger and freight connectivity
- Boost to tourism, business, and local economic development.

Muktsar



4 Lane Access Controlled Delhi - Amritsar-Katra Expressway (Package 6, NE-5) (Length - 30.91 km)

- Part of the 667-km mega corridor from Delhi to Katra (J&K).
- High speed connectivity to Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra and the Golden Temple, Amritsar
- Promotes socio-economic growth across Haryana, Punjab, and J&K
- Access-controlled design eliminates ribbon development and mixed-traffic conflicts.

Flagging off of

Amritsar (Chheharta) – Varanasi Express Kartoli Punjab – Ambala Express

Foundation Stone Laying for



6-Lane Greenfield Southern Ludhiana Bypass (Length - 25.24 km)

- Connects NH-44 to the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway and the proposed Ludhiana-Bathinda Highway - a critical three-way junction
- Shortest and fastest route from Ludhiana to Bathinda and south-western Punjab
- Lets through traffic - especially heavy commerical vehicles - avoid Ludhiana's congested urban core entirely
- Eases movement of industrial goods, agricultural produce, and freight across Ludhiana.

by

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



17th July 2026



03:30 pm



Jalandhar Cantt. Railway Station

Gulab Chand Kataria
Governor, Punjab

Bhagwant Mann
Chief Minister, Punjab

Ashwini Vaishnaw
Union Minister for Railways,
Information & Broadcasting and
Electronics & Information Technology

Ravneet Singh
Union Minister of State for Railways
and Food Processing Industries

Charanjit Singh Channi
Member of Parliament

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Government approves Delhi Start-up and Incubation Policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has approved the Delhi Start-up and Incubation Policy with the aim of giving a fresh push to innovation, research and entrepreneurship in the national capital.

Under this ambitious policy, more than ₹400 crore will be invested over the next five years. In its initial phase, it will be implemented in 11 state universities, 13 government-aided colleges, polytechnic institutions,

Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) and Government schools. The policy has received the Cabinet's approval. The Government will provide one-time financial assistance to eligible institutions for setting up and strengthening incubation centres. In addition, these centres will receive annual operational support for mentoring, networking, innovation activities and the overall development of the start-up ecosystem.

Sharing details about the new policy, Chief Minister

Rekha Gupta said the policy is designed to develop Delhi into one of the country's leading hubs for innovation and entrepreneurship while ensuring that young people receive every possible support to turn their ideas into successful start-ups.

She said the initiative is not just about helping people launch start-ups but about transforming Delhi's youth from job seekers into job creators.

The Chief Minister said the government wants to ensure that students, researchers,

teachers, alumni and aspiring entrepreneurs with promising ideas never face a shortage of resources, mentor-

ship or financial assistance to take those ideas forward.

According to the chief minister, start-ups associated

with these incubation centres will receive milestone-based financial assistance at different stages of their growth.

The support will cover various phases, including prototype development, proof of concept, product development, market validation and commercialisation, enabling promising ideas to grow into successful enterprises.

She added that the incubation centres will provide young entrepreneurs with modern infrastructure, expert mentoring, business adviso-

ry services, intellectual property support, access to laboratories and testing facilities, as well as opportunities to connect with investors and industry. This will ensure step-by-step support for students and young innovators from ideation to incubation and commercialisation.

She said the Annual Delhi Start-up Youth Festival will be one of the policy's flagship initiatives and will be developed as a premier platform for innovation in the capital. The festival will bring together young innovators, education-

al institutions, start-ups, investors, industry representatives and policymakers. It will serve as a venue to showcase new ideas, foster new partnerships and encourage young entrepreneurs to take their ventures forward.

The Chief Minister said the State Incubation Policy Monitoring Committee (SIPMC) will oversee the implementation of the policy. The committee will comprise representatives from the government, educational institutions, industry and the start-up ecosystem.

Atal Canteen, 50 U-Special buses announced for Delhi University

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday announced that an Atal Canteen will be inaugurated at the Delhi University campus on August 16, where students will receive nutritious meals for ₹5. In addition, CM said that 50 new U-Special bus routes will soon be introduced for the university while attending the Diamond Jubilee celebrations of Shaheed Bhagat Singh College as the chief guest.

Delhi University Vice-Chancellor Prof Yogesh Singh, College Principal Prof Arun Kumar Atri, and several eminent members of the academic community attended the event. A virtual tour showcasing the college's 60-year journey was presented, and the Chief Minister unveiled the year-long Diamond Jubilee events calendar and a QR code for the college's digital archives.



Congratulating the college on completing six decades, the Chief Minister said Shaheed Bhagat Singh College has nurtured students with quality education, discipline, and the values of nation-building while instilling the spirit of Nation First. She said the progress of any nation depends on the strength of its youth and the quality of its education system, and institutions like this college play a vital role in shaping the country's future.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi Government is strengthening schools and educational institutions

across the capital with better infrastructure, smart classrooms, modern laboratories, and advanced technological facilities, in line with the National Education Policy's historic reforms.

On new announcements, the Chief Minister said the government is also considering developing hostel facilities for Delhi University students at the proposed new campus of Indira Gandhi University.

She said the Government is giving special attention to improving educational infrastructure and hostel facilities to develop Delhi as a global education hub.



ment project.

The firm will design, develop and carry out a survey of all the shelters across

Delhi. "The work on the ground is expected to start from September this year; we have put the condition of a 20-year maintenance plan," the senior officer said.

The Delhi Transport Infrastructure Development Corporation (DTIDC) has around 3,575 bus shelters for which the consultant firm is

being hired. The estimated cost of the project, including maintenance for 20 years, is Rs 650 crore.

According to the plan, the redeveloped bus shelters will have several facilities, including a panic alarm system, weather display, provision for solar panels and a digital advertising system.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the general public that the Partnership Deed of M/s Health Way Remedies, a Registered Partnership Firm, has been amended w.e.f. 01/04/26 to include new partner Ms Manya Goel and outgoing partner Mr Ramender Sain. General public is hereby requested to give their objections (if any) to the said amendment and to take note of the said amendment for future transactions.
For M/s Health Way Remedies
Monika Goel (Partner)

PUBLIC NOTICE
My clients Sushil Kumar and his wife Anita Devi both R/o 1537/13, 2nd Floor, Govindpuri, Kalkaji, PO Kalkaji, Dist. South, Delhi, Delhi-110019 have severed all relations and disowned their son Aakash Singhal, his wife Rakhi Aggarwal and grandson Kiaan Singhal from their all movable and immovable properties due to their disobedience. My clients shall not be responsible for their any acts and deeds in future.
Manoj Kumar Khandelwal (Advocate) Ch. No. 449, Saket Court, New Delhi-17

PUBLIC NOTICE
My client Sushila Devi, wife of Rajendra Singh, resident of House No., Street No. 3/24, Village Gokalpur, North East, Delhi, Delhi-110094, my son Sumit and Kajal have married of their own free will, due to which I have disinherited them from all my movable and immovable properties and severed all my relations with them. My client will not be responsible for any of their actions/transactions.
PREETI Advocate Ch.No.E-416, Karkardooma Court Shahdara Delhi-32

AXIS BANK
Retail Assets Centre, Axis Bank Lt. Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301. Axis Bank Ltd. Retail Asset Centre at 1st Floor, Vipul Square, Shushant Lok-1, Gurgaon-122009. Axis Bank Limited, Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor and first floor, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001 Corporate Office Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400 025 Registered Office: Trishul, 3rd floor, opposite Samartheswar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006

DEMAND NOTICE
Whereas the borrowers/co-borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors mentioned hereunder had availed the financial assistance from Axis Bank Ltd. We state that despite having availed the financial assistance, the borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors have committed various defaults in repayment of interest and principal amounts as per due dates. The account has been classified as Non Performing Asset on the respective dates mentioned hereunder in accordance with the directives/guidelines issued by Reserve Bank of India, consequent to the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice on respective dates mentioned herein below under Section 13(2) of SARFAESI Act, 2002, calling upon the following borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors to repay the amount mentioned in the notices together with further interest at the contractual rate on the amount mentioned in the notices and incidental expenses, cost, charges etc until the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of notices. The notices issued to them on their last known addresses have remained un-served and as such they are hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.

Name of the Borrower / Address/ Co-borrower and Guarantor Name:	NPA Date / Date of Demand Notice / Outstanding Amt (Rs.) as on Date of Notice / Loan Amount (Rs.)
1. Mr. Pankaj Gulati S/o Mr. Yas Gulati Ae-33, Ground Floor, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi 110088 Also At: Mr. Pankaj Gulati S/o Mr. Yas Gulati Pal Radia Shop 451-452 Old Laganai Rai Market Delhi 110036 (Borrower) 2. Mrs. Priyanka Gulati W/o Mr. Pankaj Gulati Ae-33, Ground Floor, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi 110088 (Co-borrower) 3. Mrs. Neena Gulati W/o Mr. Yas Gulati Ae-33 Ground Floor, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi 110088 (Co-borrower) Property Address of Secured Assets: Jindal S/o Mr. Rajender Jindal R/o H.No. 530, W/o Mr. Jindal, 2nd Floor, Residential Buitup Plot Bearing No. 33 In Block-Ae, Situated In The Layout Plan Shalimar Bagh Residential Scheme Presently Known As Shalimar Bagh, Delhi And Bounded As Under - East : Plot No.34, West: Plot No.32, North: Road 24 M/Rw, South: Service Lane	29.06.2026 / 03.07.2026 Rs. 4,91,92,636.67/- (Rupees Four Crore Ninety One Lakh Nine Twenty Six Hundred Thirty Six and Paise Sixty Seven Only) Rs. 4,50,000,000/- & Rs. 1,00,00,000/-
2. Ms Jindal Sales Company Through Its Prop. Mrs. Shikha Jindal W/o Mr. Anil Jindal Running At: Ooo Rohatk Road, Distt- Sonapat- 131001 Haryana (Borrower) 2. Mrs. Shikha Jindal W/o Mr. Anil Jindal R/o H.No- 530, Post Office Waili Gali, Gur Mandi, Aggarshar Nagar, Distt- Sonapat, Haryana -131001 (Promotor) 3. M. R. Jindal S/o Mr. Rajender Jindal R/o H.No. 530, W/o Mr. Jindal, 2nd Floor, Residential Buitup Plot Bearing No. 33 In Block-Ae, Situated In The Layout Plan Shalimar Bagh Residential Scheme Presently Known As Shalimar Bagh, Delhi And Bounded As Under - East : Plot No.34, West: Plot No.32, North: Road 24 M/Rw, South: Service Lane	05-07-2026 / 09.07.2026 Rs. 1,54,31,322.27/- (Rupees One Crore Fifty Four Lakhs Thirty One Thousand Three Hundred Sixty Seven Paise Only) Rs. 1,50,00,000/-
3. Mr. Ujjwal Kumar (Borrower) N-71, Ground Floor, Sector-12, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301 Also At: Mr. Ujjwal Kumar (Borrower) Village- Rattanpur, Post-kateshwar, Mujaffarpur, Bihar Also At: Mr. Ujjwal Kumar (Borrower) 866 FG Sector-5 Near Ram Leela Ground Vaishali 1 E Sahibabad Uttar Pradesh-201010 Mrs. Beauty (Co-borrower) N-71, Ground Floor, Sector-12, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301 Property Address of Secured Assets : Unit No. A-1/1207, Eco-village-3, Gh-06, Sector-16-B, Greater Noida 201303 Bounded as under: East : as per site plan, North : as per site plan, South : as per site plan	08-Jan-26 / 02.07.2026 Rs. 8,59,52,21/- (Rupees Eight Lakh Fifty Nine Thousand Five Hundred Twenty One Only) Rs. 1,28,69,89/-
4. Mr. G. Sathesh Kurup C9-9420, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070 (Borrower) Mrs. Ritur Kurup Behind Ground Floor, Sector-12, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301 (Co-borrower) Property Address of Secured Assets : Plot No 370, Block-S, 1st Floor, Radiance Residency, Sector-48-49, Gurgaon, Haryana And Bounded As Under - East : As Per Title Deed, West: As Per Title Deed, North : As Per Title Deed, South : As Per Title Deed	03-Jun-26 / 02.07.2026 / Rs. 15,25,187/- (Rupees Fifteen Lakhs Twenty Five Thousand One Eighty Seven Only) /Rs. 33,83,000/-
5. Ms. Moushumi Bhattacharya (Borrower) H.No. K-2143, 3rd Floor, Chittaranjan Park, Delhi-110018 Mr. Indira Bahadur (Co-borrower) H.No.-174-D, Ghoronda, Neem Ka Banger, Palpar Ganj Village, Delhi-110091 Property Address of Secured Assets : Flat No.-2002, 20th Floor, Tower-B, Ekdant FNG HRA-12/B, Sarajpur Site-C, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh Bounded As Under: East : As Per Site Plan, West: As Per Site Plan, North : As Per Site Plan, South : As Per Site Plan	08-Jun-26 / 02.07.2026 Rs. 14,37,638/- (Rupees Fourteen Lakh Thirty Seven Thousand Six Hundred Thirty Eight Only) /Rs. 30,00,00,00/-
6. Mr. Yusuf Ahmed Khan (Borrower) House No X-128, Camp-1, Block-X JJ Colony, Nangloi, West Delhi-110041 Mrs. Farida Bano (Co-borrower) House No X-128, Camp-1, Block-X JJ Colony, Nangloi, West Delhi-110041 Property Address of Secured Assets : Flat No 78, 13th Floor, Pocket 1A, Block A 13, Sector A1-4, Narela, New Delhi-110040 And Bounded As Under - East : As Per Title Deed, West: As Per Title Deed, North : As Per Title Deed, South : As Per Title Deed	10-May-26 / 02.07.2026 Rs. 9,34,491/- (Rupees Nine Lakh Thirty Four Thousand Four Hundred Ninety One Only) /Rs. 9,75,585/-

In the circumstances as aforesaid, the notice is hereby given to the above borrowers, co-borrowers and/or their guarantors (wherever applicable) to pay the outstanding dues as mentioned above along with future interest and applicable charges within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 60 days of the date of this notice against the secured assets including taking possession of the secured assets of the borrowers and the mortgagors under Section 13(4) of Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and the applicable rules thereunder. Kind attention is invited to provisions of sub-Section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act where under you can tender the entire amount of outstanding dues together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank only till the date of publication of the notice for sale of the secured asset(s) by public auction, by inviting quotations, tender from public or by private treaty. Please also note that if the entire amount of outstanding dues together with the costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank is not tendered before publication of notice for sale of the secured assets by public auction, by inviting quotations, tender from public or by private treaty, you may not be entitled to redeem the secured asset(s) Please note that under Section 13 (13) of the said Act, no Borrower shall, transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of his secured assets referred to in the notice, without prior written consent of the secured creditor.

Place: Noida U.P. Date: 17.07.2026

-SD/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

**आईआरएल (इंडिया) लिमिटेड/IREL (India) Limited**
Formerly Indian Rare Earths Limited.
(भारत सरकार का उपक्रम) (A Government of India Undertaking)
CIN : U15100MH1950GOI008187 Website : www.irel.co.in
ISO 9001: 2015, ISO 14001: 2015 & ISO 45001 : 2018 Company

Ref: ADVT.No. 26-27/08
निविदा सूचना / TENDER NOTICE
Date: 13.07.2026

आईआरएल, ऑस्कॉम निम्नलिखित मदों / जांब विवरण को लिए प्रस्ताव हेतु अनुरोध आमंत्रित करता है
IREL, OSCOM invites request for proposal for the following items / job descriptions.

बिड सं/Bid No.	जांब/मद विवरण / Job / Item Description
2026_IREL_282285_1	EOI for the Empanelment of a Structural Design Agency at IREL OSCOM.
GEM/2026/B/7730353	Procurement of 1 Ton Jumbo PP bags.
GEM/2026/B/7730353	Design, Fabrication, Supply and Commissioning of 11kV / 433V Unitized Substation.

बोलीदाता निविदा वसूलेबज <http://irel.co.in>, <http://gem.gov.in> या <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app> से डाउनलोड कर सकते हैं। उपरोक्त निविदाओं का कोई भी शुद्धि/परिवर्तन केवल उपरोक्त वेबसाइटों पर ही होना चाहिए।
Bidder may download tender document from <http://irel.co.in>, <http://gem.gov.in>, <https://etenders.gov.in> and <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>. A corrigendum / Extension to above tenders shall be hosted in above websites only.

CBC 48146/11/0009/2627

ह./Sd/-
महप्रबंधक एवं प्रधान, ऑस्कॉम/GM & HEAD, OSCOM

**STATE BANK OF INDIA**

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59
Community Centre, Naraina Industrial Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

DEMAND NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (No. 3 of 2002).

A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower	Details of Properties / Address of Secured Assets to be Enforced	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on date of notice)
1.	VIKAS S/O NARESH H. No. B-51, Ground Floor, Sainik Nagar, Uttam Nagar, D.K. Mohan Garden, West Delhi, Delhi-110059. Also At: C-18 Phase 3, Om Vihar, Near Lion Sir School, Uttam Nagar, S.O. Uttam Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi-110059. Also At: C-10/160, Sector 5, Rohini, West Delhi, Hanuman Mandir, Delhi-85. Car Loan A/c. No.44724539805	Make & Model: MAHINDRA SCORPIO-N D MT 2WD 26 75 Vehicle No.: DL7CY5085 Engine No.: YDS4L88030 Chassis No.: MA1T2YD6S6L65621	09/07/2026 Date of N.P.A. 08/07/2026	Rs.17,98,762/- (Rupees Seventeen Lakh Ninety Eight Thousand Seven Hundred Sixty Two Only) as on 09/07/2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs and charges etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

"This notice is without prejudice to the Bank's right to initiate such other actions or legal proceedings, as it deems necessary under any other applicable provisions of Law".

DATE: 16.07.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

Sd/- Authorized Officer & (Chief Manager)
State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina New Delhi

**STATE BANK OF INDIA**

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59
Community Centre, Naraina Industrial Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

DEMAND NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (No. 3 of 2002).

A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower	Details of Properties / Address of Secured Assets to be Enforced	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on date of notice)
1.	MS. SANJANA D/O MR. SANJO KUMAR B-19A, DDA Flats, Shivaji Enclave, Raghubir Nagar, Tagore Garden, New Delhi-110027. Also At: Cuts Point Hair Saloon, B-71 A, DDA Flats, Shivaji Enclave, New Delhi-110027 Car Loan A/c. No.44410421765	Make & Model: MARUTI G VITARA SMTHYBRID DELTA AT Vehicle No.: DL 9CBK 8932 Engine No.: K15CN7735841 Chassis No.: MBJTYKL1SSE326878	04/07/2026 Date of N.P.A. 25/06/2026	Rs.12,54,973/- (Rupees Twelve Lakh Fifty Four Thousand Nine Hundred Seventy Three Only) as on 04/07/2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs and charges etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

"This notice is without prejudice to the Bank's right to initiate such other actions or legal proceedings, as it deems necessary under any other applicable provisions of Law".

DATE: 16.07.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

Sd/- Authorized Officer & (Chief Manager)
State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina New Delhi

**VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD**
Unit 203 & 204, 2nd Floor, "A" Wing, Navbharat Estate, Zakaria Bunder Road, Sewri (West), Mumbai 400015. Maharashtra.
CIN No.: U65922MH2005PLC272501

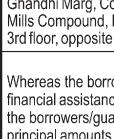
POSSESSION NOTICE

Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorised Officer of Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred to him under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued a Demand Notice calling upon the borrowers mentioned herein below to repay the amount mentioned in the respective notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers having failed to repay the amount, undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the date mentioned below. The borrower and guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited Branch for an amount mentioned as below and interest thereon, costs etc.

S/N	Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower and LAN No.	Date & Amount of Demand Notice	Description of Property	Date & Type of Possession
1	Darshan Singh (Borrower), Soniya Soniya (Co Borrower) LP0000000190335 LP0000000206258	20/Apr/26 Rs.748578/- & Rs.342049/- as on 16/Apr/26	All that part and parcel of property bearing No. 222 Nayabas Nayabas Thane Shankar Tiwari Agra Uttar Pradesh 283125 admeasuring 2375 sq.ft bounded by Boundaries as follows: North - House of Pappu South - Road 8 ft wide East - House of Pappu West - Plot of Kharanja	Symbolic Possession Taken 10/07/2026
2	Seema . (Borrower), Mahesh Chand (Co Borrower), Jay Singh (Guarantor) MHL000000152029	18/Apr/26 Rs.716091/- as on 16/Apr/26	Measuring area 235.64 sqm. Khasra No. 245/1 Mauza Paigona Tehsil Chhata Dist. Maheshwari-281401 Boundaries as follows: North - Plot of Jeetram South - Road 20 feet above East - Plot of Yadram West - Plot of Bhagwan Singh	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
3	Pink . (Borrower), Ramesh .(Co Borrower), Rakesh (Guarantor) MLP000000180229	18/Apr/26 Rs.808862/- as on 16/Apr/26	All that part and parcel of property bearing No. Part of Khasra No 746, Mauza Paigona Tehsil Chhata District Mathura Uttar Pradesh, 281401, Admeasuring 155.42 Sq.ft Boundaries as follows: North - Road 15 feet wide South - House of Bhajo others East - House of Bacchu West - Plot of Shen Dr	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
4	Maya (Borrower), Ravi (Co Borrower), Radha .(Co Borrower) LP0000000210482	20/Apr/26 Rs.1069224/- as on 16/Apr/26	All that part and parcel of property bearing no Plot Bearing Baraka, Baraka, Khasra No. 213 Mathura, Mathura, Chhata Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, 281403 Area of Property: 747 Sq.Meter Boundaries as follows: North - House of Pappu South - Road 8 ft wide East - House of Pappu West - Plot of Kharanja	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
5	Begraj (Borrower), Sanju (Co Borrower), Rambharshi (Guarantor) MLP000000229198	18/Apr/26 Rs.1094463/- as on 16/Apr/26	Residential House Of Land Area Measuring 160.54 Sq. Meters, Part Of Khasra No. 563, Situated At Mauza Jatwari, Tehsil Chhata District Mathura Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries as follows: North - Rasta 5 Feet Wide South - Rasta 6 Feet Wide East - Rasta 7 Feet Wide West - House of Dal Chand Property of Donor	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
6	Prathvi Raj (borrower), Neha (Co Borrower), Meena Kumari (Co Borrower), Dale Singh (Co Borrower), Karan Singh (Co Borrower), Shashi Pal (Guarantor) MLP000000250809	17/Apr/26 Rs.615905/- as on 16/Apr/26	Residential House Of Land Area Measuring 260.77 Sq. Yards i.e. 218.03 Sq. Meters, Khasra No. 167a, Situated At Mauza Jhatwari, Tehsil Chhata District Mathura Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries as follows: North - Rasta 5 Feet Wide South - Rasta 6 Feet Wide East - Rasta 7 Feet Wide West - House of Dal Chand Property of Donor	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
7	Shashi (borrower), Mitunjai Raaj Bhati (Co Applicant) HL0000000019715	19/Apr/22 Rs.2045379/- as on 5/Apr/22	All that part and parcel of the Immovable property situated at Flat No.301 3rd Floor,Block C Khasra No. 1019,Mahendra enclave Hadbast Rajapur,Hospital,Pragana Dasna Tehsil And Jila Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201001 North - Road South - Entry East -Other Flat West -Other Property	Physical Possession Taken 13/07/2026

Date : 17.07.2026
Place : Ghaziabad, Mathura, Agra

Authorised officer
Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd

**VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD**
Unit 203 & 204, 2nd Floor, "A" Wing, Navbharat Estate, Zakaria Bunder Road, Sewri (West), Mumbai 400015. Maharashtra.
CIN No.: U65922MH2005PLC272501

POSSESSION NOTICE

Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorised Officer of Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred to him under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued a Demand Notice calling upon the borrowers mentioned herein below to repay the amount mentioned in the respective notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers having failed to repay the amount, undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the date mentioned below. The borrower and guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited Branch for an amount mentioned as below and interest thereon, costs etc.

S/N	Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower and LAN No.	Date & Amount of Demand Notice	Description of Property	Date & Type of Possession
1	Darshan Singh (Borrower), Soniya Soniya (Co Borrower) LP0000000190335 LP0000000206258	20/Apr/26 Rs.748578/- & Rs.342049/- as on 16/Apr/26	All that part and parcel of property bearing No. 222 Nayabas Nayabas Thane Shankar Tiwari Agra Uttar Pradesh 283125 admeasuring 2375 sq.ft bounded by Boundaries as follows: North - House of Pappu South - Road 8 ft wide East - House of Pappu West - Plot of Kharanja	Symbolic Possession Taken 10/07/2026
2	Seema . (Borrower), Mahesh Chand (Co Borrower), Jay Singh (Guarantor) MHL000000152029	18/Apr/26 Rs.716091/- as on 16/Apr/26	Measuring area 235.64 sqm. Khasra No. 245/1 Mauza Paigona Tehsil Chhata Dist. Maheshwari-281401 Boundaries as follows: North - Plot of Jeetram South - Road 20 feet above East - Plot of Yadram West - Plot of Bhagwan Singh	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
3	Pink . (Borrower), Ramesh .(Co Borrower), Rakesh (Guarantor) MLP000000180229	18/Apr/26 Rs.808862/- as on 16/Apr/26	All that part and parcel of property bearing No. Part of Khasra No 746, Mauza Paigona Tehsil Chhata District Mathura Uttar Pradesh, 281401, Admeasuring 155.42 Sq.ft Boundaries as follows: North - Road 15 feet wide South - House of Bhajo others East - House of Bacchu West - Plot of Shen Dr	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
4	Maya (Borrower), Ravi (Co Borrower), Radha .(Co Borrower) LP0000000210482	20/Apr/26 Rs.1069224/- as on 16/Apr/26	All that part and parcel of property bearing no Plot Bearing Baraka, Baraka, Khasra No. 213 Mathura, Mathura, Chhata Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, 281403 Area of Property: 747 Sq.Meter Boundaries as follows: North - House of Pappu South - Road 8 ft wide East - House of Pappu West - Plot of Kharanja	Symbolic Possession Taken 13/07/2026
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7	Shashi (borrower), Mitunjai Raaj Bhati (Co Applicant) HL0000000019715	19/Apr/22 Rs.2045379/- as on 5/Apr/22	All that part and parcel of the Immovable property situated at Flat No.301 3rd Floor,Block C Khasra No. 1019,Mahendra enclave Hadbast Rajapur,Hospital,Pragana Dasna Tehsil And Jila Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201001 North - Road South - Entry East -Other Flat West -Other Property	Physical Possession Taken 13/07/2026

Date : 17.07.2026
Place : Ghaziabad, Mathura, Agra

Authorised officer
Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd

IN FOCUS



Jharkhand Governor Santosh Gangwar with Union MoS Defence Sanjay Seth and State Chief Minister Hemant Soren take part in a procession of Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra and Goddess Subadhra as the annual Rath Yatra commences in Ranchi

PM Modi to flag off India’s first hydrogen-powered train from Jind

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

India's first hydrogen-powered train, to be flagged off by Prime Minister Narendra Modi from Haryana's Jind railway station on Friday, is equipped with multi-layer safety systems capable of detecting hydrogen leaks, heat, flames and smoke.

The train will run between the Jind and Sonipat railway stations.

Unlike conventional electric trains that draw power from overhead lines, the Hydrogen Fuel Cell Trainset generates electricity on board through a chemical reaction between hydrogen and oxygen, with water vapour and heat as its only by-product. "In a sense, the



India's first hydrogen-powered train, developed by Indian Railways, during trials ahead of its rollout.

PTI

train once again carries its own source of power, as steam and diesel locomotives once did.

But instead of burning traditional fuels, such as coal or diesel, hydrogen generates electricity inside the train using oxygen from the atmosphere, eliminating combustion

and dependence on an external power supply," according to an official statement issued on Thursday. As electricity is generated on board through clean-hydrogen technology, the train represents the greenest form of rail propulsion, powering the future of sustain-

able mobility. "To complement this advanced propulsion system, India has equipped the train with multi-layer safety systems capable of detecting hydrogen leaks, heat, flames and smoke," the statement said.

With an operational speed of 75 kmph and a design speed of 110 kmph, the train is not only safer but also faster on the 89-km Jind-Sonipat section.

Hydrogen-powered trains are still at a nascent stage globally. Germany was the first country to introduce commercial hydrogen passenger trains, while France, Italy, China, Japan and a few other countries are pursuing pilot projects or limited deployments.

Create lasting impact on tourists visiting India, says Shekhawat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Tourism Minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat on Thursday said the time has come to contemplate measures to create a meaningful impact on tourists visiting India by improving their experience here.

Addressing the FAITH Conclave here, Shekhawat stressed on transforming global visitors into "civilisational ambassadors" by elevating the tourist's experience while in India.

"The time has come when apart from worrying about how to increase our (tourist) footfalls, we must also contemplate upon how to create meaningful impact," he said.

He stressed the need to improve a tourist's experience while in India and deepen their connection to



Gajendra Singh Shekhawat

India's cultural heritage.

"A tourist who comes to India must become the civilisational ambassador of our country," the minister said, highlighting India's rich cultural heritage and civilisation.

Teacher dies after falling from a bike taxi and being run over by a truck in Rohini

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 46-year-old MCD school teacher was killed after she allegedly fell from a bike taxi and was run over by a truck on Kanjhawala Road in Delhi's Rohini on Thursday morning, police said.

The deceased was identified as Priyanka, a resident of Rama Vihar and a teacher at the MCD School in K-Block, Mangolpuri. She was on her way to school when the accident occurred.

According to police, they received a PCR call reporting the incident on Thursday morning. A police team rushed to the scene and found a truck loaded with bajri (sand) parked on the road, with the woman trapped beneath its left rear wheel. Police stated Priyanka had succumbed to her injuries by the time officers

arrived. Preliminary investigations suggest she fell from the bike taxi before being crushed by the truck. However, the exact sequence of events remains under verification.

The body was transferred to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital, where it has been preserved following medico-legal formalities. The crime team inspected the crime scene, evidence was documented, and a case was registered under Sections 281 (rash or negligent driving) and 106 (causing death by negligence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Police said the owner of the truck involved has been contacted, and efforts are ongoing to trace and arrest the absconding driver.

Investigators are also examining the role of the bike taxi rider, if any, in the incident as part of the ongoing investigation

Delhi hits 39.2C, records highest July temperature since 2024

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi recorded its hottest July day in nearly two years on Thursday, with the maximum temperature touching 39.2 degrees Celsius, amid hot and humid conditions and elusive rainfall.

The maximum temperature at Safdarjung, the city's primary weather station, settled at 39.2 degrees Celsius, 4.0 notches above normal, while the minimum temperature was recorded at 30.2 degrees Celsius, 3.2 notches above normal.

The maximum temperature was the highest recorded in July since July 30, 2024, when it had reached 39.3 degrees Celsius. The minimum temperature was also the highest since July 2, 2024, when it had settled at 30.7 degrees Celsius.



The maximum temperature at Palam stood at 39.0 degrees Celsius, 3.8 notches above normal. Lodhi

Road recorded 38.9 degrees Celsius, 4.9 notches above normal, Ridge registered 38.0 degrees Celsius, 3.2 notches above normal, and Ayanagar logged 38.7 degrees Celsius, 3.4 notches above normal. The minimum temperature at Palam settled at 27.6 degrees Celsius, 2.4 notches above normal. Lodhi Road recorded 29.2 degrees Celsius, 4.3 notches above normal, Ridge registered 27.2 degrees Celsius, 2.8 notches above normal, and Ayanagar logged 29.4 degrees Celsius, 2.1 notches above normal. According to weather experts, humid southwesterly winds from the Arabian Sea are leading to cloud formation over Delhi, but the moisture content in these winds is getting depleted over Gujarat, preventing sufficient moisture from

reaching the national capital.

Clouds are forming without producing rainfall as there is no triggering weather system to initiate precipitation, Mahesh Palawat, vice president (Meteorology and Climate Change), Skymet Weather, said.

He said similar conditions are likely to persist over the next three days, with the maximum temperature expected to hover between 39 and 40 degrees Celsius.

The India Meteorological Department has forecast isolated to scattered rainfall over Delhi between July 16 and July 19, and fairly widespread to widespread rainfall from July 20 to July 22. Hot and humid weather conditions are likely to prevail over Delhi and adjoining areas between July 16 and July 18, it said.

Channi, Randhawa meet Venugopal, say will abide by high command’s decision, Rahul their leader

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Amid infighting in the Punjab Congress, former state chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi and former deputy chief minister Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa met party leaders here on Thursday, professing adherence to the high command's decision.

The two leaders, part of a faction challenging the party's decision to retain Amrinder Singh Warring as the Punjab unit chief, met AICC general secretary, Organisation, KC Venugopal for talks.

The two also paid a courtesy visit to party general secretary Randeep



Surjewala, saying they share a personal relationship with him. The meeting with Venugopal, which was also attended by MLAs Pargat Singh and Rana Gurjeet Singh, lasted around three hours.

Channi's meeting with Rahul Gandhi, however, could not happen on Thursday.

Channi and Randhawa have raised a banner of revolt against Warring, who has been asked by the high command to continue as party chief ahead of assembly election in the state early next year. "Several leaders were called here today and we presented our point of view. I want to make one thing absolutely clear and that is that we stand with the party. We respect the party high command and Rahul Gandhi is our leader and we love him and will stand by him. Kharge ji is our party president and all our workers and

leaders stand firmly with the party and will continue to do so," Channi told reporters after meeting Venugopal. He also dismissed murmurs of widening rift in the party ranks in Punjab.

"This is an unnecessary media trial which was uncalled for. We have no intention of embarrassing anyone or belittling anyone. We simply want to take the party forward in Punjab, and we have presented our case. The high command heard us and the final decision has always been with the high command. Whatever decision it takes, we will accept it and move forward accordingly," he said.

FROM PAGE - 3

Yatra. "I pray for the eternal peace of the souls of the devotees who have lost their lives and for the swift recovery of the more than a hundred injured devotees," the former chief minister said in a social media post. Patnaik, the leader of the Opposition, also asked his party men to extend full cooperation to provide assistance to everyone.

"I hope that the State Government will ensure the convenience and safety of the devotees by properly managing the crowds," the BJD president said.

Three people were killed, and several others were injured in a stampede near the Gundicha temple, considered the birthplace of the sibling deities, during last year's Rath Yatra.

US-Iran strikes intensify overnight

Col Ebrahim Zolfaghari, a spokesperson for the Iranian military's Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters, threatened that Iran could launch widespread attacks on regional infrastructure if the US acts on President Donald Trump's repeated warnings that America could hit Iranian bridges and power plants. "All the infrastructure in the region will be crushed under the steel blows of the powerful armed forces of the Islamic Republic of Iran" should Trump's threat be carried out, Zolfaghari said. "Under no circumstances and in no way will we allow America, as a foreign and extra-regional country, to interfere in the Strait of Hormuz," he added. "This is Iran's invincible red line."

Meanwhile, the US military said it opened fire on the Curacao-flagged oil tanker Belma sailing toward Kharg Island, Iran's main oil export terminal in the Persian Gulf.

After the ship "ignored multiple warnings," a US aircraft disabled the merchant vessel by firing a missile into the ship's smokestack.

Another US strike Wednesday targeted a barracks for Iran's 388th Mechanised Infantry Brigade, which operates tanks and armoured vehicles, in Sistan and Baluchestan province, Iranian State television reported. The report said US fired at least 13 missiles in the attack and the seven dead included conscripts and career soldiers. A number of troops were wounded.

Iran retaliated Thursday morning with missile and drone attacks on Bahrain, Jordan and Kuwait, authorities in those countries home to US forces said. There was no immediate

acknowledgment of damage or casualties from the attacks. Kuwait reported a new round of incoming fire on Thursday afternoon.

The latest round of fighting is focused on the Strait of Hormuz, as Iran attacks ships using a US-controlled route through the vital waterway. The US has threatened to reopen the strait by force, but experts say that would require a much bigger armada if not tens of thousands of ground troops.

Trump again insisted Iran was ready to strike a peace deal, but he didn't elaborate.

"They don't like what we're doing, and they do want to settle. We'll find out whether or not we settle with them, or we just finish it off," he said Wednesday at the US Army War College in Pennsylvania.

Mediators have sought to calm the tensions, but so far have been unsuccessful. Pakistan's Foreign Ministry on Thursday said it was still trying to bring the US and Tehran to the table, while acknowledging that mediation was becoming increasingly difficult.

Trump separately said on social media that Tehran made a goodwill gesture by releasing an American citizen wrongly detained in Iran since 2024. He didn't release further details. Human rights lawyer Jared Genser released a statement identifying the detainee as his client Dena Karari, a US-Iranian citizen who runs a nonprofit and was charged with espionage.

Iran did not immediately acknowledge the release and her case was not publicly known, as is sometimes the case with detentions in the Islamic Republic.

ED cracks alleged terror trail across five States

The case originates from a 2024 FIR registered by the Uttar Pradesh Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS). The FIR pertains to an organised syndicate allegedly involved in facilitating the illegal infiltration of Rohingya and Bangladeshi nationals into India, arranging forged Indian identity documents, including Aadhaar, PAN, and passports, and aiding their rehabilitation and settlement in various parts of the country.

According to officials, the ATS probe and subsequent ED investigation uncovered a deep-rooted financial network involving certain charitable trusts and entities. Some of these entities are registered under the

Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) and allegedly received substantial foreign contributions, including from UK-based sources. "By targeting the financial trails, the ED aims to disrupt networks that allegedly exploit charitable fronts and complex layering techniques to obscure the origin and use of funds", a senior official said. This operation underscores India's multi-agency approach to national security challenges, he added.

Funds were reportedly diverted through multiple bank accounts, mule accounts, layered transactions, cash withdrawals, and small-value transfers in tranches to suspected beneficiaries and to support infiltration-related activities. Among the locations searched were premises linked to entities such as Sun Shine Health and Social Welfare Society, Kabirbag Millat Academy, and other institutions. Searches focused on the recovery of digital devices, incriminating documents, and statements from key persons. Further investigation is underway.

Illegal infiltration networks have long been a concern due to potential links with radicalisation, document fraud, and cross-border funding channels. Central security agencies, including the ED and state ATS units, have intensified efforts in recent years to dismantle such syndicates through parallel financial and predicate investigations. Officials described the financial architecture as sophisticated, designed to facilitate both illegal settlement support and alleged terror-related funding.

Family fortune turns fatal in Ghaziabad

Police said that in 2018, he had allegedly opened fire on his younger brother, injuring him. Investigators are examining the earlier incident as part of the probe into Wednesday night's murder.

Police have registered a case on the complaint of the family and sent the body for post-mortem. Four police teams have been formed to track down the accused, with raids being conducted at multiple locations.

ACP Verma said preliminary investigation points towards a combination of a long-running land dispute and alcohol abuse as the motive behind the killing. Police said further investigation is underway.

Man shoots girlfriend before killing self in Burari rented room

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A man identified as Nikhil shot his girlfriend, Shubhangi, dead and then turned the weapon on himself in a rented room in Delhi's Burari area on Thursday. The police discovered the bodies when Shubhangi's younger sister returned from work at around 3:30 pm to find both lying on the floor in a pool of blood, and the investigation so far points toward a possible suicide pact.

The couple had been living together in the rented accommodation in the Kamalpur area of Burari for approximately one month. Shubhangi was a native of Uttar Pradesh, while Nikhil was from Haryana and had separately been residing in north Delhi before the two began sharing the rented room.

Police said the two had been in a relationship for the past few months. A senior police officer told reporters



that the preliminary investigation suggests the deaths may have occurred under mutual understanding.

"Prima facie, it seems that this was a suicide pact and was done under mutual understanding. We are waiting for the crime and forensic teams for further details," the officer said.

No suicide note was recovered from the room. However, Nikhil had reportedly sent messages to members of his family shortly before the incident. Police are waiting for both families to arrive in Delhi

mortem, and further legal proceedings have been initiated.

Investigators are currently working to ascertain the exact sequence of events: whether Nikhil shot Shubhangi first and then took his own life, or whether the two had made prior arrangements for what happened in that room. The absence of a note complicates the reconstruction, though the messages Nikhil sent to his family in the period immediately before the deaths are being examined as part of the investigation.

Reports indicate that Nikhil was unemployed at the time of the incident. The question of what drove the two to this point, whether it was financial strain, pressures on the relationship, family opposition, or a combination of these, is a central part of what investigators will try to establish through interviews with both families and examination of the couple's phone records and communications.

Govt begins process to empanel third party auditors for issuing fire safety certificates

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has started the process for registering third-party auditors for issuing fire safety certificates to the owners and occupiers of buildings and premises at rates ranging from ₹10,000 to ₹5 lakh.

The Delhi Fire Service (DFS) of the government, in a notice issued on Thursday, invited applications for registration and empanelment of fire safety auditors (third party) with the DFS principal director. According to the DFS Amendment Rules, 2025, notified by the Home Department last month, there will be three levels (L-1, L-2, L-3) of fire safety auditors based on their qualification and experience.

Presently, the DFS issues fire safety certificates in the city. However, the third-party auditors are being brought in the backdrop of three major fire tragedies in recent months, including the hotel inferno in the Hauz Rani area in South Delhi that claimed 22 lives in June.



The professional qualifications required for registration include BE or BTech (Fire Safety), sub-officer course from National Fire Service College, Nagpur, BE, BTech or B Arch in Civil, Mechanical or Electronics or Architecture, PG Diploma in Fire and Life Safety Audit among others.

Experience in fire prevention and safety ranging from 1-10 years will also be a mandatory qualification. The L-1 and L-2 level auditors will be authorised to issue fire safety certificates to buildings or occupancies lower than 15 metres in height.

The highest level of auditors (L-3) will be authorised for all buildings and occupancies, say the rules.

The registration and empanelment of fire safety auditors will be valid for a period of three years. The fee for registration will be ₹10,000 (L-1), ₹20,000 (L-2) and ₹30,000 for L-3.

If any non-compliance or deviation from the required fire prevention and fire safety measures or any falsification by the auditor is reported by the fire officers after inspection, they will be issued show-cause notices.

The penalty amount will be ₹2 lakh (L-1), ₹5 lakh (L-2) and ₹10 lakh (L-3) in case of violation by the auditors. They will also be liable to be blacklisted and deregistered from the DFS panel without issuance of any further notice, if penalty remains unpaid.

According to the DFS Amendment Rules, 2025, the owner or occupier of a building or premises will engage a fire safety auditor from the empanelled list on the DFS portal. The engaged auditor will conduct a thorough inspection of the premises or building or occupancy, including fire prevention and fire safety measures, and submit a detailed inspection report and issue a fire safety certificate and declaration to the owner or occupier.

The auditors will be permitted to charge the owner or occupier of a building or premises for the services provided by them. The fees will range from ₹10,000-₹50,000 in the case of L-1 auditors, ₹35,000-₹90,000 L-2 auditors, and ₹63,000-₹5 lakh L-3 auditors.

Female BLO alleges abuse during SIR exercise; police arrest four

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Four persons have been arrested for allegedly abusing and obstructing a booth-level officer (BLO) while she was conducting the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in Delhi's Chandni Mahal area earlier this month, police said on Thursday.

According to police, the incident took place on July 5 at Fatak Telian in the Chandni Mahal area when the complainant, a postgraduate teacher (special education) deployed as a BLO, was conducting SIR-related work.

In her complaint, the teacher alleged that one of the accused placed the BLO register on her lap and signed it despite her objection. She further alleged that several persons present at the spot abused her, refused to accept SIR forms and behaved in a manner that humiliated her and prevented her from carrying out her official duties.

The matter came to the notice of police on July 15



after the complainant approached the Additional District Magistrate (ADM), Old Delhi. Police said the complainant informed them that the delay in reporting the incident was due to consultations with her senior officers regarding the appropriate course of action.

"On the complaint of a PGT (special education teacher) and Booth Level Officer (BLO), a case has been registered at the Chandni Mahal Police Station regarding an incident that allegedly occurred on July 5 during the SIR exercise at Fatak Telian. After verification of the complaint and examination of the available material, a prima facie case was found to be made out. Accordingly, an FIR was registered, and all the

accused persons named in the complaint have been arrested in accordance with the law," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central) Rohit Rajbir Singh said.

An FIR has been registered under Sections 221 (obstructing a public servant), 132 (assault or criminal force to deter a public servant), 79, 74 and 3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

The arrested accused have been identified as Mohammad Sabreen (44), Ateeq ur Rehman (58), Mohammad Asif (50) and Mohammad Aftab (44), all residents of the Turkman Gate area.

The arrests come amid growing concerns over the working conditions of officials engaged in the SIR exercise. Previously, The Pioneer had reported on the strenuous and prolonged work hours being put in by booth-level officers (BLOs) deployed for the SIR drive, with many flagging the demanding nature of the assignment. Police said further investigation is underway.

CM Rekha performs Chhera Pahara at Rohini Jagannath Rath Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday participated in the 21st Annual Lord Jagannath Rath Yatra at the Lord Jagannath Temple in Rohini. On the occasion, she offered prayers to Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra, and Goddess Subhadra and performed the traditional Chhera Pahara ritual by ceremonially sweeping the path in front of the chariot before also attending a second Rath Yatra celebration organised by the Shiv Mandir Jagannath Darbar, Saini Dharamshala Samiti, in Shalimar Bagh. North West Delhi MP Yogendra Chandolia, Delhi Cabinet Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh, representatives of social organisations, and a large number of devotees attended the Rohini event.

Speaking at the Rohini ceremony, the Chief Minister said the Rath Yatra is not merely a religious celebration but a symbol of the great tradition of service, devotion, and public welfare. She said the custom



of sweeping in front of the chariot carries the message that public service and humility are the true hallmarks of leadership.

She said it was a matter of immense joy and privilege to participate in the grand Rath Yatra and, as the representative of the state, to have the opportunity to serve by performing the ceremonial sweeping before the Lord's chariot.

She prayed that with the blessings of Lord Jagannath, Delhi continues to move on the path of development and that every resident of the capital is blessed with happiness, prosperity, and well-being.

She said such religious and cultural events not only

keep India's rich traditions alive but also strengthen social unity and mutual harmony.

At the Shalimar Bagh event, the Chief Minister joined devotees in offering prayers at the Shri Jagannath Rath Yatra organised by the Saini Dharamshala Samiti.

The Chhera Pahara is one of the most significant rituals associated with the Jagannath Rath Yatra tradition. It involves the sweeping of the chariot's path with a golden broom by the most senior dignitary present, symbolising the equality of all before the divine and the idea that even those in the highest positions of power are servants before the Lord.

Centre clears PARIVARTAN guidelines to replace old trucks, buses in NCR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs has approved the operational guidelines for the PARIVARTAN scheme, clearing the way for the replacement of old and highly polluting trucks and buses across the National Capital Region with cleaner Bharat Stage VI-compliant and electric vehicles.

The scheme, officially titled Programme for Accelerated Renewal and Incentivization of Vehicle Assets for

Reducing Transport Air Pollution and Network Emissions, is aimed at reducing vehicular emissions and improving air quality in Delhi and the surrounding NCR region. The Union Cabinet had approved the scheme on June 3 with a total financial outlay of ₹9,585 crore, including ₹5,041 crore as Central Government support.

With the guidelines now in place, the programme is ready for implementation. The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways will execute the scheme, while



funding will be routed through the National Capital Region Planning Board. The

government said this reflects a coordinated regional strategy to tackle air pollution

caused by commercial vehicles. The scheme offers multiple financial incentives to encourage owners to replace ageing commercial vehicles. These include concessions on motor vehicle tax, waiver of registration fees, a five per cent interest subsidy on vehicle loans, and a minimum eight per cent discount from vehicle manufacturers on eligible new vehicles.

Owners replacing diesel and CNG vehicles will also receive monthly fuel voucher support, while

those opting for electric vehicles will be eligible for one-time financial assistance. The scheme also provides incentives linked to Certificate of Deposit trading.

To support early implementation, the governments of Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan have issued notifications granting motor vehicle tax concessions for ten years and waiving registration fees for eligible replacement vehicles purchased under the scheme.

DDA generates ₹1,020 cr through housing sales

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) generated a revenue of ₹1,020 crore through housing sales in the first quarter of the current financial year. The DDA revenue marked a steep rise from the previous financial year, when the sales were recorded at ₹462 crore, according to a statement issued by the authority.

"Driven by robust demand for housing across all categories, DDA sold 1,284 flats during the quarter while generating Rs. 1,020 crore in revenue. Sub-city Narela emerged as the biggest contributor to this success, with 1,153 flats sold during the quarter, accounting for nearly 90 per cent of the total sales, which shows the increasing attractiveness of Narela as a preferred residential destination," the DDA said. In 2025-26, the DDA generated ₹462 crore in revenue.

The rise in revenue is the result of continuous focus on reimagining the subsidies developed by the DDA, on the part of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, which has resulted in the Authority recording strong housing sales in the first quarter of the financial year 2026-27.



"Narela has emerged as the biggest contributor to this success, with 1,153 flats sold during the quarter, accounting for nearly 90 per cent of the total sales, which shows the increasing attractiveness of Narela as a preferred residential destination," the DDA said. This growth is being supported by DDA's continuous infrastructure development efforts, including key projects such as the Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) and the

upcoming Rithala-Narela-Kundli Metro corridor, which are significantly improving connectivity.

The sales were achieved through DDA's ongoing housing schemes, namely DDA Karmayogi Awaas Yojana, DDA Nagrik Awaas Yojana, and DDA Towering Heights, East Delhi Hub, Karkardooma (FCFS), offering housing options across different income groups. These schemes have been extended till July 31, 2026, on first come first serve basis, and since the schemes are completely online, buyers can purchase flats sitting at their homes.

"These schemes have been extended till July 31, 2026, on a first come, first served basis, and since the schemes are completely online, buyers can purchase flats sitting at their home. During this quarter, 336 economically weaker section, 322 low-income group, 435 middle-income group and 191 high-income group flats were sold. The middle-income group category accounted for the highest share at 34 per cent.

The EWS category in Narela witnessed an almost complete sell-out, underscoring the strong trust of people in DDA-constructed homes and demand for affordable housing in the area.

Delhi zoo plans modern reptile house

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi zoo will upgrade its existing Reptile House into a modern, immersive facility with advanced temperature regulation systems, improved environmental controls and enhanced visitor interpretation facilities as part of its forthcoming modernisation plan.

The proposed upgrade also includes the acquisition of additional reptile species, with a focus on animal welfare, conservation breeding, research, education and improving the visitor experience. Zoo Director Sanjeet Kumar said on World Snake Day.

The zoo currently houses six species of snakes, comprising 26 adult snakes and three hatchlings, in scientifically managed enclosures, he said. The zoo has introduced several measures over the past year to improve



snake husbandry and welfare, including the installation of UV lighting systems, temperature and humidity monitoring equipment, environmental enrichment inside the Reptile House, coco peat bedding and artificial incubation of snake eggs using scientific protocols, the director said.

These efforts have resulted in the successful hatching of three Indian cobra hatchlings. Eggs of rat snakes are currently under artificial incubation, he said.

As part of the forthcoming modernisation plan of the National Zoological Park, the existing Reptile House is proposed to be upgraded into a modern, immersive facility equipped with advanced thermoregulatory systems, improved environmental controls and enhanced visitor interpretation facilities, he said.

The plan also envisages the acquisition of additional reptile species with a continued focus on animal welfare, conservation

breeding, research, education and an enriched visitor experience.

As part of the World Snake Day celebrations, the zoo organised an expert lecture on snake biology, conservation and safe handling for its permanent staff, followed by a hands-on reptile management training programme for assistant keepers, multi-tasking staff and reptile care personnel.

The training was conducted in collaboration with Wildlife SOS, whose experts demonstrated scientific methods of reptile care, husbandry and safe handling practices, according to the official. He said that to raise awareness among visitors, the zoo also organised a snake-themed doodle activity for children and a quiz competition highlighting the ecological importance of snakes and their role in maintaining ecosystem balance.



Another TMC Rajya Sabha MP resigns, quits Mamata camp

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

In yet another jolt to the Mamata Banerjee camp of the Trinamool Congress noted Bengali actress and MP Rukmini (Koel) Mullick on Thursday resigned from the Rajya Sabha.

She was elected to the Upper House little more than four months ago — just before the Bengal Assembly elections along with singer-politician Babul Supriyo, former Bengal DGP Rajeev Kumar, and senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy.

Her resignation comes barely a day after senior leader and one of the founding members and sitting MLA of the party Madan Mitra quit left Banerjee to join the rebel group of MLAs led by Opposition Leader Ritabrata Bhattacharya.

Firing speculations was Mullick’s brief meeting with senior Union Minister Bhupendra Yadav in whose residence former TMC MPs led by Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar had met during when they broke away from the parent party to join the



MP Rukmini (Koel) Mullick

Nationalist Citizens’ Party of India thitherto an obscure outfit.

Koel is the daughter of Bengali actor Ranjit Mullick who has a number of Hindi films to his credit.

Though there was no report on what transpired from Thursday’s talks and though the Mullick household in Kolkata remained tightlipped about the actress’ future plan of

action talks were ripe that she could soon join the BJP. The Thursday’s development also comes on the heels of her three party colleagues Sukhendu Sekhar Roy, Susmita Dev and Prakash Chik Baraik quitting as the TMC Rajya Sabha MPs and joining the BJP to file fresh nomination for the Upper House for which elections will be held next week.

Koel’s quitting the TMC membership and her Rajya Sabha seat barely days ahead of the Monsoon Session. After Mullick’s departure TMC’s strength in the Upper House comes down to 9.

On Mallick’s resignation Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya said that TMC had become a thing of the past and there was no point talking about it. “Such things are common with the Trinamool Congress... they are finished... these things will keep on happening... so there is hardly any point dwelling on who is quitting and who is not,” he said adding “no law of political science would be able to save the beleaguered faction of TMC led by the former Chief Minister.”

Mamata on defections: I will bounce back

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Amid ongoing “betrayals” and with more of her vintage colleagues continuing to defect from her faction of the Trinamool Congress, former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday expressed rage and also betrayed signs of capitulation even as she said, the rebels might take away the name (of her party) or its symbol but the spirit inside her would never die down and that she would revive her outfit and stand up to her cause once again.

“I heard that one of our MPs have resigned today against this backdrop I ask all those who want to leave, leave now... I will start from scratch again,” a visibly livid Mamata Banerjee said. Enraged at “defections engineered by those in power with the help of the central agencies” but also sounding emotional Banerjee said, “those who have luggage and baggage and those who are afraid of persecution may



leave under pressure but I will continue to fight.”

Offering apology “for selecting wrong candidates who defect under pressure,” the former Chief Minister said, “I bounced back in 1998 and raised a new party... I bounced back in 2004 when we were reduced to a single MP status... I have bounced back on several occasions and remember I will bounce back once again and raise the outfit once again.

Banerjee also slammed the breakaway faction wondering why they were not going to express solidarity with fasting Sonam Wangchuk instead of “dancing to the tunes of the powers that are using ED, CBI to engineer defection in the TMC.”

India’s highest commercial lilium field launched in Leh at 3,265 metres

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

The development of India’s highest commercial Lilium cultivation field has commenced at Choglamsar in Leh, marking the launch of a first-of-its-kind floriculture initiative of this scale in Ladakh.

The project aims to create new livelihood opportunities for local communities through commercial floriculture.

Over the past three days, more than 50,000 premium Lilium bulbs have already been planted in the field, with the first blooms expected in the first week of September.

Lilium is one of the world’s most sought-after cut flowers, prized for its exceptional ornamental value and long shelf life. It is widely used in the floral industry and hospitality sector, with premium varieties currently priced between ₹150 and ₹200 per stem in domestic retail markets.

Spread across 93,000 square metres on the banks of the River Sindhu (Indus), the Choglamsar

Flower Field is being developed as one of the largest organised high-altitude floriculture parks in the country.

It is located at an altitude of nearly 3,265 metres, surpassing India’s current highest flower field at Mana in Uttarakhand, which sits at 3,200 metres.

The project is being implemented with scientific and technical support from the CSIR-Institute of Himalayan Bioresource Technology (CSIR-IHBT), Palampur.

Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena laid the foundation stone for the Choglamsar Flower Field on 22 June 2026.

The initiative seeks to produce premium Lilium flowers and buds that command high prices in both national and international markets, thereby creating a sustainable new source of income for Ladakh’s farming community through self-help groups (SHGs) and cooperatives.

This project aligns with the Union Minister of Home Affairs and



Cooperation, Amit Shah’s vision of “Sahkar se Samridhhi,” which focuses on strengthening cooperatives to generate sustainable local employment and enhance the income of local communities, especially women and farmers.

Conceived by Lieutenant Governor Saxena, the project aims

to position Ladakh as an emerging centre for premium floriculture while providing access to high-value domestic and international flower markets.

The flower field is also expected to become a new recreational destination for tourists. In the first year, the Agriculture Department will

develop the flower field and, at the time of blooming, hand it over to selected Self-Help Groups and cooperative societies. The department will continue to support the SHGs and cooperatives in marketing the flowers in national and international markets to ensure maximum returns. From the following year onwards, the cooperatives will independently undertake commercial cultivation, harvesting, and value addition of Lilium flowers.

Local farmers are already receiving structured training in scientific floriculture, modern cultivation practices, and business aspects of floriculture. Ladakh offers ideal agro-climatic conditions for Lilium cultivation. The bulbs thrive in cold conditions, between minus 4°C and 4°C, making them naturally suited to the region’s high-altitude environment. A major advantage is that the bulbs begin to multiply naturally after three years, significantly boosting future production and farmers’ returns without additional investment.

Captain Viridi murder trial stalled; family writes to PM Modi

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Nearly two decades after the brutal murder of retired Merchant Navy officer Captain Manmohan Singh Viridi, his family has written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking urgent intervention to expedite the extradition of prime accused Hussain Shattaf from the United Arab Emirates (UAE).

The prolonged delay has brought the trial to a virtual standstill, denying justice to the victim’s kin.

In a formal representation addressed to the Prime Minister’s Office, Captain Manjit Singh Viridi (Retd.), the victim’s brother and original complainant, highlighted the family’s continued suffering and urged the Centre to fast-track Shattaf’s return to India.

“I write this representation with utmost respect as the original complainant in a serious criminal case,” Capt. Viridi stated, referring to FIR number 46 of 2006 registered at Lonavala City Police Station.

The case is now registered as Sessions Case number 5 of 2024 before the Sessions Court at Wadgaon Maval.

The appeal comes months after the Union Government initiated extradition proceedings against Shattaf through diplomatic channels with the UAE.

The family’s frustration stems from repeated legal hurdles.

The Supreme Court, in its order dated May 18, 2023, in Criminal Appeal number 1399 of 2023, revived the murder trial by setting aside the Bombay High Court’s order that had discharged the accused.

Despite this, proceedings have remained frozen because Shattaf has



failed to appear before the trial court.

“Despite the pendency of a serious criminal trial, the accused has not appeared physically before the Trial Court and continues to evade the process of law. Due to this conduct, the family of the victim continues to suffer injustice since the murder of Captain Viridi,” the representation noted.

In a subsequent order dated November 20, 2025, the Bombay High Court recorded that the Maharashtra Home Department had forwarded an extradition proposal to the Ministry of Home Affairs on October 31, 2025, and that the matter was pending with the Centre.

Capt. Viridi pointed out that the continued absence of the accused has caused “grave prejudice” to the family. He noted that he is now a “super senior

citizen” yet remains committed to pursuing justice

The representation also drew attention to India’s successful extradition of several other fugitives from the UAE in recent times.

“More than five accused persons have recently been extradited from the UAE,” it stated, questioning why similar urgency has not been shown in Shattaf’s case despite multiple pending criminal proceedings against him, including charges of forgery and use of fake documents.

Hussain Shattaf faces charges of murder under the Indian Penal Code along with other serious offences registered by Mumbai Police.

He allegedly fled India after being charged in the 2006 case and has been residing in the UAE. Interpol has issued a Red Corner Notice against him.

Captain Manmohan Singh Viridi was murdered in Lonavala, Maharashtra, in 2006. According to the police, Shattaf and others were involved in the crime. The trial has seen multiple twists, including discharge orders that were later overturned by the Supreme Court.

The Ministry of External Affairs has confirmed that India has formally requested Shattaf’s extradition through diplomatic channels.

The victim’s family is now pinning hopes on Prime Minister Modi’s intervention to break the deadlock.

In their plea, the family has requested the Prime Minister’s Office to issue necessary directions to concerned ministries so that Hussain Shattaf can be extradited and produced before the competent court at the earliest, bringing an end to what they describe as a long denial of justice.

MP Waqf Board Chairman Sanwar Patel slams critics over appointments

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Bhopal

Madhya Pradesh Waqf Board Chairman Dr Sanwar Patel has broken his silence over the controversy surrounding the appointment of two non-Muslim members to the Board and the subsequent meeting with Bhopal’s Shahar Qazi and Shahar Mufti, dismissing criticism as politically motivated and aimed at misleading the community.

Speaking at a programme in Ujjain, Patel took a sharp swipe at his critics, saying those questioning the meeting on social media were individuals who ‘command no respect in public life’.

He clarified that he had personally invited the Shahar Qazi and Shahar Mufti as a mark of respect, adding that honouring religious elders was part of his upbringing.

According to Patel, the two religious leaders appreciated the Board’s recent initiatives and advised it to ensure transparent management of Waqf properties while continuing action against corruption.

He said those criticising the meeting should also seek guidance from senior reli-



gious leaders if they wished to work honestly in public life.

Responding to objections over the inclusion of two non-Muslim members in the Waqf Board, Patel said the appointments had been made strictly in accordance with the Waqf Act, 2025.

He stressed that non-Muslim members had been inducted only at the state board level in an expert capacity to contribute administrative and financial expertise.

He clarified that mosques, madrasas, dargahs and local Waqf management committees would continue to be managed exclusively by Muslims, as provided under the new law, rejecting allegations that the religious character of Waqf institu-

tions was being altered. Patel claimed the Board had taken strong action against illegal encroachments and financial irregularities over the past three to four years, resulting in a significant increase in revenue from Waqf properties. He said that in Bhopal alone, the Board had recovered nearly Rs 29 crore, compared to negligible income from Waqf assets in previous years.

He alleged that opposition to the new Board and the amended law was being fuelled by individuals whose “personal interests and illegal activities” had been affected by the Board’s anti-encroachment and anti-corruption measures.

Outlining the Board’s vision, Patel said Waqf properties belonged to the com-

munity and were meant for the welfare of economically weaker sections rather than any individual.

He said the Board had launched schemes to support the education of children from poor Muslim families and intended to utilise Waqf income for education and other welfare initiatives.

The controversy erupted after Bhopal’s Shahar Qazi Maulana Syed Mushtaq Ali Nadvi and Shahar Mufti Abdul Kalam Qasmi met Patel and presented him with a bouquet following the constitution of the new Waqf Board.

The meeting drew criticism from sections of the Muslim community and several clerics, with protests being held in Bhopal against the inclusion of two non-Muslim members in the Board.

Meanwhile, anticipating a legal challenge after Congress MLA Arif Masood announced plans to move the Supreme Court, the Madhya Pradesh Waqf Board has filed a caveat petition in the Madhya Pradesh High Court, seeking to ensure that no order is passed without first hearing the Board’s submissions.

LG Sinha reviews offerings system at Vaishno Devi Shrine amid fake silver row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Jammu

Amid “fake silver” offerings controversy at Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Ji Shrine, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Thursday chaired a high-level meeting with the Members of Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board and senior officials, and reviewed the Offerings and Donations Management System.

The meeting was convened after the Chief Judicial Magistrate’s Court in Jammu had directed the Crime

Branch Inquiry Officer on July 13 to produce records related to over ₹550 crore worth of “fake silver” offerings at the Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine on the next date of hearing, 29 July 2026.

The order was passed on an application filed by Advocate Deepak Sharma, who had lodged a detailed complaint on 9 May 2026 with the Inspector General of Police, Crime Branch, and SSP, Economic Offences Wing, demanding immediate registration of an FIR and a thorough probe.

The complaint accuses those responsible of serious cognizable offences, criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, misappropriation, record manipulation, and the possible use of cadmium-laden fake material in place of devotees’ silver offerings.

According to a statement issued by the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board, during the meeting a comprehensive review of the collection, counting, accounting, safeguarding and utilisation of devotees’ offerings was made to ensure



Lt Governor Manoj Sinha offers prayers at the Mata Vaishno Devi temple in Katra, Reasi district of Jammu and Kashmir on Thursday

PTI

complete transparency, accountability and adherence to established Standard Operating Procedures in the

management of offerings and donations received at the Holy Shrine.

A detailed presentation

was made by the officers of the board highlighting the robust systems and institutional mechanisms put in place for the secure and transparent handling of offerings received through donation boxes, donation counters, online platforms and offerings in the form of precious metals.

The Board, which met under the chairmanship of the Lieutenant Governor, was apprised of verification processes, surveillance mechanisms, banking safeguards and periodic audits that govern every stage of the process.

During the meeting, it was informed that all financial transactions related to offerings and donations are undertaken strictly in conformity with prescribed banking norms, statutory provisions and the guidelines issued by the Government of India from time to time.

The Board also noted the stringent security protocols adopted for handling and storage of the offerings received in the form of precious metal as well as its secure transportation, processing and refinery through reputed

Government-approved institutions including the Reserve Bank of India and India Government Mint, Hyderabad.

After a detailed review, the Board expressed satisfaction over the transparency, accountability and efficiency of the existing arrangements.

The Board also appreciated the comprehensive safeguards and monitoring mechanisms adopted to ensure that the sacred offerings made by devotees are managed with the highest standards of integrity, financial discipline and public trust.

Nation Focus



PM MODI SPEAKS TO QATAR AMIR, CONDOLES FATHER'S DEMISE

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday spoke to Amir of Qatar, Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, and conveyed his heartfelt condolences on the passing of the Father Amir, Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani.

The prime minister also said the departed leader’s enduring legacy will continue to guide the two countries for further strengthening the strategic partnership. The Father Amir died on July 12 at the age of 74. Following his death, the central Government had declared one-day national mourning on July 13 as a mark of respect, with the national flag flown at half-mast throughout the country.

“Spoke with HH Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, the Amir of Qatar and conveyed heartfelt condolences on the passing of HH the Father Amir, Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani. (PTI)



ANDHRA PRADESH ACHIEVES FULL DIGITISATION OF SIR FORMS: CEO

Andhra Pradesh Chief Electoral Officer Vivek Yadav on Thursday said the Election Commission has achieved ‘100 percent digitization’ of Enumeration Forms distributed to more than 4.16 crore electors across the state under the SIR of the electoral roll.

The enumeration period of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll began on June 15 in the southern state and was extended by 10 days until July 24. According to the latest daily bulletin on the SIR shared today, Yadav said enumeration forms were distributed to all the electors – 4.16 lakh in total.

Out of the total number of forms distributed, he said 4.16 lakh were digitised, indicating that 1,484 are still pending, though the CEO said 100 percent digitisation has been achieved. (PTI)

States Focus



J&K CM Omar Abdullah in conversation with PDP President Mehbooba Mufti during a condolence meeting of senior J&K National Conference leader and former J&K minister Sheikh Mustafa Kamal in Srinagar PTI

No change in July 20 Delhi protest: Omar Abdullah

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday asserted that the proposed protest plan of his party in Delhi on July 20 over the alleged delay in the restoration of statehood would not change, but said there can be changes in the venue or the mode of the protest.

He, however, refused to term the delay in getting permission for the protest as sabotage or diversion. "I will not go into whether it is a sabotage, diversion or anything else. You and I both understand it. Our programme will not change, the venue or the mode may change, but the programme to go to Delhi will not change," Abdullah told reporters here. The chief ministers said his party would not hold the protest by hiding in some corner. "Had that been the case, we would have held it in the lawns of our house. But we will go to Delhi and raise our voice there somehow. Then see what is to be done in the future," he added. (PTI)



Bihar CM launches live classes, free online JEE-NEET coaching

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday launched the 'Bihar School Live Classes' initiative and a free online coaching programme for JEE and NEET aspirants.

The chief minister inaugurated the 'Bihar School Live Classes' programme at Government Girls' Higher Secondary School in Shastri Nagar in Patna.

Under the initiative, schools will be connected through video conferencing to a central teaching hub, enabling students to attend live classes delivered by subject experts, officials said. Choudhary also launched the Bihar School Examination Board's (BSEB) free online coaching programme for the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) for admission to engineering colleges, and the medical entrance test NEET. (PTI)

BJP slams Telangana Government over alleged Islamic verse homework row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday criticised the Congress Government in Telangana over allegations that a private school in Hyderabad asked a class 2 Hindu student to learn an Islamic verse as part of his homework.

The BJP also accused the Congress of patronising a "conversion mafia" in the state and demanded action against the school management. A private school in Hyderabad has come under scrutiny after parents of a 6-year-old student alleged that their son was asked to learn an Islamic verse as part of his homework.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla claimed the school had terminated the teacher after the issue came to light, but said the action was inadequate.

"Too little, too late. The school in question, which was allowing the forcible recitation of the Kalma, an Islamic prayer, to Hindu children, has finally, after giving a series of excuses and saying it was a mistake, terminated the teacher.

"But that is not enough. Why did such a case take place in Hyderabad, under Revanth Reddy and (Asaduddin) Owaisi?" Poonawalla said in a video post on social media.

He demanded strict action



against the school and alleged that such incidents are the result of Congress and AIMIM patronising such elements.

"Now the question is — What action will the state Government and police take against the teacher, the school administration and the school itself, and why do Revanth Reddy, the Congress and others give patronage to such elements with their statement that Congress means Muslims?" he said.

Poonawalla alleged that the incident is "nothing short of a forcible conversion case, a forcible Kalma test".

"This is nothing short of a forcible conversion case, a forcible Kalma test. We have seen this in the Nashik TCS case, corporate jihad, and now this education jihad. Congress is allowing and enabling this through its ecosystem. Congress must answer. The Congress Government must answer," he added.

Another BJP national spokesperson, Pradeep

Border infrastructure indispensable in tech-driven future warfare: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Even as advanced weapons and platforms are being inducted into the armed forces to tackle the evolving nature of warfare, critical infrastructure such as ports, roads and tunnels will continue to play an indispensable role in the future, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Thursday.

In his address at Strategic Infrastructure Conclave hosted by the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) here, he also emphasised that while the outcome of war is largely determined by military prowess, precision capabilities and modern technologies, basic infrastructure is central to enabling military operations.

"Sometimes, the first front of a war is not at the border itself, but on the road that leads our soldiers to the frontline. Therefore, the person who builds that road is as vital a guardian of national security as the soldier who stands at the border," Singh said.

He commended the BRO for adopting niche technologies to establish robust infrastructure and carry forward



Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh with others during the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) Strategic Infrastructure Conclave in New Delhi PTI

the Government's resolve of building world-class infrastructure, continuously strengthening national security, and transforming India into a Viksit Bharat by 2047 as envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The defence minister asserted that border infrastructure will remain indispensable in technology-driven warfare in future.

Connectivity is an essential component of civilisational development, and the Government has "ensured that no resident of a remote area feels cut off from mainstream", he said. He further emphasised that innovation, research, and execution excellence are key to "future-ready strategic infrastructure".

"Even as state-of-the-art weapons and platforms are being inducted into the defence forces to address the challenges posed by the evolving nature of warfare, ports, airfields, roads and tunnels will continue to play an indispensable role in the future," Singh said.

The two-day conclave, which commenced on Wednesday, served as a platform for deliberations on emerging technologies, innovative engineering solutions, digital transformation in planning, project monitoring and execution to improve productivity, sustainable construction methodologies and best practices aimed at accelerating the development of strategic infrastructure in

India's border regions.

The event brought together senior military leadership, policymakers, infrastructure experts, BRO officers, industry leaders and technology partners to collectively deliberate upon the future of strategic infrastructure development, the defence ministry said.

Singh highlighted that over the past six-and-a-half decades, the BRO has transformed itself from a mere road construction agency to one of the world's most respected strategic infrastructure organisations.

He underlined achievements such as Atal Tunnel, Umling La Pass, and Sela Tunnel stand as "living testaments" to the BRO's capability and hard work, adding that its dedicated personnel have repeatedly proven that with a spirit of service to the nation, any challenge can be overcome even in the harshest of conditions.

Terming the BRO as a front-line organisation in adopting latest technologies, Singh made special mention of the tunnelling technology, which he said has brought about the revolution, from metro construction in cities to highway development in mountainous regions.

Indian Navy to host Operation Southern Readiness 26-2 in Kochi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Navy will host Operation Southern Readiness 26-2 at the Southern Naval Command, Kochi, from July 20 to 23. The four-day multinational training engagement will be conducted in partnership with the Combined Maritime Forces (CMF) under the aegis of the Indian Navy-led Combined Task Force 154 (CTF 154). CMF's dedicated Training Task Force, the defence ministry said here on Thursday.

The event will bring together personnel from CMF Partner Nations for professional maritime security training, practical experience, and exchange of best practices.

Through its association with the CMF, a multinational maritime partnership comprising over 40 nations, the Indian Navy continues

to contribute to regional capacity building and collective maritime security.

The training programme will combine classroom instruction, simulator-based training, and practical exposure. Sessions will cover areas including Maritime Law, Maritime Domain Awareness and Information Sharing, Counter-Narcotics, Force Protection, Asymmetric Threats, and maritime Uncrewed Systems. Participants will also be trained in Damage Control and Firefighting, maritime communications, Survival at Sea, Boarding procedures, and hands on training onboard Indian Naval ship.

Operation Southern Readiness 26-2 will showcase the Indian Navy's modern training infrastructure, state-of-the-art simulators, advanced instructional methodologies, and professional expertise.



Ganga cannot be kept clean by focusing only on riverbank cities: NMCG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Keeping the Ganga clean needs interventions not only in cities built along the river but also in those across its basin, as wastewater from these areas eventually flows into the river system, the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) said on Thursday. The mission cited the example of Meerut, where the Namami Gange programme is being implemented.

"Meerut is not located on the main course of the Ganga.

The Ganga cannot be seen from here.

Yet, the water from every drain and every sewer line here eventually flows into that very Ganga system. In the language of river science, this is called a basin, and the truth is that the Ganga can remain as clean as its entire basin remains clean," the mission said in a post on social media.

"If the cities on the banks get beautified but the cities in the basin remain overlooked, the pollution will circle back and reach the river anyway. That is why the Namami



Gange initiative reached Meerut," it added.

The mission said Meerut had for decades grappled with a limited sewage network amid rapid urbanisation, and its wastewater management struggled to keep pace with the expansion.

In 2020, a Rs 691-crore sewerage project was approved to address the challenge. Construction began in 2024 and is still underway, it said.

A total sewage treatment capacity of 220 million litres per day (MLD), modern sewage treatment plants (STPs), an extensive sewer

network and scientific wastewater management, reuse of treated water are its aims.

By connecting more and more areas of the city to the sewer network, it is ensured that Meerut's wastewater does not reach the Ganga system untreated, the NMCG said.

"When such a large city in the basin starts accounting for every drop, its impact will be visible far downstream in the main channel. The Ganga is not just a river; it is a system. And a system changes only when every city in it changes," it added.

US national lived illegally in India for 8 months, held

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

A 36-year-old American national, Jordan Brown, resided illegally in India for nearly eight months without possessing a valid passport or visa before being apprehended while attempting to cross into Nepal.

Brown, who asserts to be a former member of the United States Navy and Special Forces from California, entered India clandestinely in early November 2025 and navigated freely between Goa and Bengaluru without attracting the attention of authorities.

According to his statements to law enforcement officials, Brown lost his passport in Thailand and subsequently arrived in India via sea from Sri Lanka on November 2, 2025.

He initially settled in Goa, where he remained for several months. During this period, he operated without official documentation, seamlessly integrating into the tourist-frequent coastal region without raising suspicion.

Goa's significant expatriate and tourist populations, coupled with the limited, stringent checks on long-term foreign residents in many areas, facilitated his prolonged undocumented presence.



Officials said that after weeks in Goa, Brown travelled to Bengaluru, continuing his travels without a passport, relying on informal arrangements.

He later claimed that an acquaintance in Bengaluru possessed his passport; however, he provided no verifiable details regarding this individual.

From Bengaluru, he took a long-distance bus to Lucknow on July 8, 2026, proceeding to Gorakhpur, where he hired a taxi to reach the Sonauli border area in Uttar Pradesh's Maharajanj district.

On July 11, Brown's extended period of unobserved stay was abruptly terminated near border pillar number 516 in the Mainihwa area within Sonauli police station jurisdiction.

Sashastra Seema Bal

(SSB) personnel, during a routine patrol, discovered him attempting to cross into Nepal via an unauthorised foot trail away from official immigration checkpoints.

When instructed to stop for verification, Brown allegedly attempted to flee but was quickly subdued by SSB personnel and local villagers who assisted in his apprehension.

At the time of his arrest, Brown had no passport, visa, or any form of identification. Law enforcement officials recovered Rs 31,460 in cash, two mobile phones, religious texts, an artificial intelligence translation device, a diary, and a wristwatch.

A Chinese passport was also found among his possessions. He was subsequently charged under relevant provisions of the

Immigration and Foreigners Act for illegal entry into India and unauthorised border crossing into Nepal.

Brown's detention has raised significant questions regarding the possibility of a foreign national remaining within Indian territory for nearly eight months without proper documentation.

His journey from an illicit entry into Goa, through Bengaluru, to the porous India-Nepal border in Uttar Pradesh highlights potential deficiencies in monitoring long-term foreign visitors.

Intelligence agencies are now conducting an in-depth investigation into his movements, discrepancies in his statements regarding his entry and possession of a passport, and the purpose of his attempted exit to Nepal, where he claimed he intended to meet a Nepalese acquaintance.

The case has heightened security concerns regarding the movement of foreign nationals across India under suspicious circumstances for extended durations without detection.

Brown remains in judicial custody as investigations into his identity and motives continue, with the United States Embassy duly informed of the development.

ZPM SAYS ITS GOVT CURBED CORRUPTION IN MIZORAM IN LAST 2 YEARS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Aizawl

Mizoram's ruling Zoram People's Movement (ZPM) on Thursday claimed that corruption has been significantly curbed under its government and no minister or party MLA has been implicated in any graft case so far.

The party's executive committee meeting adopted resolutions commending the government's achievements in governance, infrastructure, healthcare and anti-corruption efforts, party leaders said.

Lauding the performance of Chief Minister Lalduhoma's government, it said key accomplishments included progress in the Vairengte-Sairang four-lane highway project, relocation of Assam Rifles bases from Aizawl to Zokhawasang, improvement in healthcare delivery, stricter enforcement of laws and regulations, reduction in smuggling, transparent recruitment in government services, and timely payment of salaries to Government employees.

The meeting praised the Government's efforts to strengthen unity among ethnic Zo communities across the world.

It acknowledged the work of the Mizo Diaspora Cell operating from the chief minister's office in assisting Zo people facing difficulties outside Mizoram and helping resolve issues affecting members of the community.

Reaffirming the party's commitment to its 'Kalphung Thar-Mipui Sawrkar' (new system-people's government) policy, the committee appreciated the dedication and hard work of the Government employees in implementing schemes.

It also urged officials to continue serving with commitment and integrity to support the State's development initiatives.

India's electoral system among most transparent, credible worldwide: CEC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Moradabad (UP)

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Thursday said India's electoral system is among the most transparent, impartial and credible in the world, asserting that free and fair elections backed by error-free electoral rolls form the foundation of a strong democracy.

Addressing booth-level officers (BLOs) and supervisors at an interaction pro-

gramme held at Teerthanker Mahaveer University here, Kumar said the role of BLOs is crucial in ensuring accuracy of electoral rolls.

"India's electoral system is among the most transparent, impartial and credible in the world," he said.

During the programme, he interacted with BLOs and supervisors and issued guidelines on purification of electoral rolls, transparency in the electoral process and conduct of free and fair elections, asserting that



an error-free voter list is foundational for a strong democracy.

Talking to reporters after the event, the CEC said he was pleased to interact with election officials during his visit to Moradabad and emphasised that he would hold similar interactions with BLOs during future official visits across the country.

He said India is chairing the International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (International IDEA) in 2026, describing it as

a recognition of the country's democratic institutions at the global level.

Kumar said the three key stages of the electoral process -- preparation of electoral rolls, polling and counting of votes -- are conducted under a transparent system.

He said political parties and contesting candidates continuously scrutinise these processes, which contributes to the credibility and transparency of India's election management system.



Editor's
TAKE

India's economy feels the heat of a distant war

The latest economic data suggest that geopolitics is once again becoming a decisive force shaping India's macroeconomic outlook

Four numbers landed within days of each other this month, and together they tell a sharper story than any one of them alone. The rupee has pushed back above 96 to the dollar. Retail inflation jumped to 4.38 per cent in June, breaching the RBI's 4 per cent target for the first time in 17 months. The trade deficit widened to a five-month high of \$30.4 billion. And the RBI, having just paused in June, is now facing market chatter about a rate hike as early as August. Individually, each is explainable.

Together, they describe an economy absorbing a shock it did not create. That shock has a name: the renewed war between the US-Israel coalition and Iran, and the periodic closure of the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of the world's oil moves. Brent crude, which had drifted back towards \$70 a barrel as an earlier ceasefire held, has jumped back above \$85 after fresh strikes and tanker attacks reopened the conflict. For an economy that imports roughly half its oil from the Gulf, that is not an abstract geopolitical headline-it is a direct hit to the import bill, the currency and the price of everything that moves on diesel.

The trade numbers show this plainly. Merchandise imports rose 31 per cent year on year in June to \$70.8 billion, with petroleum imports alone running well above pre-war norms. Exports grew too, a healthy 15.5 per cent, but could not keep pace, especially with shipping through Hormuz disrupted. The result is a current account under growing pressure, with economists now pencilling in a deficit near 1 per cent of GDP for the fiscal year.

The inflation print carries the same fingerprints. Fuel pass-through from May's petrol and diesel price revisions, layered on to a sharp run-up in vegetable prices, pushed food inflation to 5.32 per cent. Core inflation has stayed comparatively tame, which is the one genuinely reassuring detail in this data set-this looks more like an imported cost shock than demand-side overheating.

That distinction matters for the RBI, which now faces a harder version of the choice it ducked in June. Growth is still projected at around 6.6 per cent, and the central bank would rather not choke it off with a hike aimed at a price shock that may partly unwind if the ceasefire holds. But, having just missed its own target, and with economists split between an August pause and the start of a hiking cycle, the RBI has little room left to sound relaxed. None of this yet amounts to a crisis.

Reserves are substantial, the RBI has been intervening in both spot and forward markets, and corporate hedging has hit record levels. But the four indicators are correlated, not coincidental, and they share a single upstream cause that India does not control.

The honest reading is not panic, but vigilance: the next real test is not this month's data, but whether the Strait of Hormuz stays open long enough for these numbers to prove temporary.

Sardar Teja Singh Samundri: A colossus of Sikh awakening

A century after his martyrdom on July 17, 1926, remembering the man whose quiet courage and unwavering principles reshaped the Sikh panth



SARDAR
MANJINDER
SINGH SIRSA

When the name Sardar Teja Singh Samundri is spoken, it evokes not merely a political figure but a towering moral force whose life reshaped the spiritual and political landscape of the Sikh Panth. The Teja Singh Samundri Hall, at the heart of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) in Sri Amritsar Sahib, stands as a singular testament to his stature. He remains the only individual in the SGPC's hundred-plus-year history to have an institution named after him, a distinction earned not through wealth or political manoeuvring, but through the moral gravity of his character.

Early life

Born on February 20, 1882, in Rai Ka Burj village, Tarn Taran district, to Deva Singh and Nand Kaur, Teja Singh emerged from peasant roots in the heartland of Punjab. His formal schooling ended at the primary level, but he possessed profound mastery of Sikh religious texts and historical traditions. His three-and-a-half years of service in the British Indian Army, rising to the rank of Dafadar in the 22nd Cavalry Regiment, instilled in him the organisational discipline and tactical acumen that would later revolutionise Sikh political mobilisation.

Building the Sikh future

Long before "nation-building" became a common phrase, Teja Singh Samundri held to a simple truth: education is the foundation of spiritual and social emancipation. He established two institutions of Khalsa learning: Sri Guru Gobind Singh Khalsa High School in Sarhali, Amritsar district, and a Khalsa Middle School in his native village. Under his initiative, the Khalsa Diwan Bar, a federation of educational and social welfare societies, grew into a network of schools across the Sandal Bar region of Lyallpur district, educating generations of Sikh youth in both modern knowledge and Gurmata principles. He was also among the founding architects of the Akali daily newspaper, recognising that the Sikh renaissance required both institutional power and the power of the written word to awaken consciousness across Punjab.

Founding the SGPC

In 1920, Teja Singh Samundri became a founding member of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee, at a time when Sikh gurdwaras lay under the grip of corrupt mahants who had become collaborators with the British colonial power. He was renowned for spearheading the non-violent Gurdwara Reform Movement against mahant control of Sikh shrines under British rule. He consistently refused formal authority, believing that movements decay when individuals overshadow institutions. This principle of "Institutional Humility", the subordination of ego to organisational mission, became the philosophical foundation of his entire life's work. According to Master Tara



Singh, he was "a complete Gursikh", one who believed credibility began with personal restraint and leadership with moral example.

Teja Singh's commitment to equality was not rhetorical. In villages around Amritsar and Tarn Taran, he challenged caste barriers by inviting Dalits to draw water from common wells and serve him publicly, an act of quiet social revolution in early twentieth-century Punjab. In an era when such gestures could invite severe social ostracism, Teja Singh's direct action against caste discrimination demonstrated that Sikh theology was not merely spiritual poetry but a blueprint for radical social transformation.

Morchas and mass movements

Even before these movements, in 1914, when the British government attempted to demolish the boundary wall of Gurdwara Rakab Ganj Sahib in Delhi, Teja Singh Samundri led a hundred-member jatha in fearless, peaceful protest, compelling the colonial authorities to withdraw their desecration. His moral authority was such that even imperial power bent before it. When the British locked away the keys to the Golden Temple's treasury, he mobilised thousands of Sikhs in Chabian Da Morcha, the Keys Agitation of 1921-22, accepting imprisonment rather than submission. In the subsequent Guru Ka Bagh Morcha of 1922, as unnamed Sikhs faced the brutality of British lathis while chanting "Satnam Waheguru", Teja Singh Samundri stood as a philosophical and spiritual pillar, demonstrating that non-violence is not weakness but the ultimate expression of spiritual power. When the SGPC faced a financial crisis that threatened its legal appeal to the Privy Council, falling short by ₹ 75,000, Teja Singh mortgaged 50 acres of his own ancestral land to bridge the gap. When the case was won after his death, his family refused reimbursement. In an era when public life is often shadowed by private gain, this episode stands in stark moral contrast.

Imprisonment and martyrdom

On October 13, 1923, Teja Singh Samundri was arrested along with 58 other Akali and SGPC leaders by the British government on charges of "waging war against the King-Emperor". Imprisoned in Lahore Fort, he was offered con-

ditional release on multiple occasions but steadfastly refused to compromise on his core principles. By 1923, his stature was such that he was chosen as one of the Panj Piaras to initiate the kar sewa of the Golden Temple sarovar, the first such service since 1842. When he and eleven companions, including Master Tara Singh, refused conditional release, public outrage forced the unconditional release of the remaining prisoners. The British then attempted to divide Sikh unity through elections, a strategy that backfired when a wave of sympathy swept Punjab and Samundri's group secured an overwhelming popular mandate.

While imprisoned in Lahore Fort, Teja Singh Samundri, alongside Master Tara Singh, Bhag Singh, Gurcham Singh and Sohan Singh Josh, studied each clause of the Gurdwara Bill presented by Governor Malcolm Hailey. The Bill met all the Akali demands and was signed into law as the Sikh Gurdwaras Act on July 28, 1925, by the Viceroy of India, legislation that bears the fingerprints of Teja Singh Samundri's principled negotiation and intellectual leadership.

On July 17, 1926, while still imprisoned in Lahore Fort, Sardar Teja Singh Samundri attained martyrdom following a heart attack. Master Tara Singh later wrote that Samundri did not become a martyr in death; his entire life was one of martyrdom. He described a man marked by sewa, love, devotion, wisdom and fearlessness, one without enmity, who gave away what he possessed before keeping anything for himself. For him, sacrifice was not an event but a lifelong condition.

A century on

The Gurdwara Reform Movement of 1920-1926 stands as one of history's most successful non-violent mass mobilisations, and Teja Singh Samundri was arguably its philosophical and moral spine. He converted what could have been a sectarian dispute into a paradigm of democratic governance, showing that moral authority, disciplined organisation and unwavering principle could overcome imperial coercive power. In an age of performative politics and impatient leadership, Sardar Teja Singh Samundri reminds us that quiet courage, sustained integrity and institutional vision can leave a deeper imprint than public noise. His was not a life of spectacle, but of conscience, and that is why it still speaks.

The Teja Singh Samundri Hall stands as his monument, but his true memorial is written in the democratic institutions he helped create, the dignity he restored to millions of Sikhs, and the template he provided for how spiritual awakening can become a force for social and political transformation.

He remains, in the hearts of the faithful, an eternal beacon for all who believe that conscience is the highest authority, and principle is the truest power. Sat Sri Akal — Victory to Truth Eternal.

The writer is Minister of Industries, Food & Supplies, and Environment, Forest & Wildlife, Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi

PIC TALK



Monks perform rituals during the annual Rath Yatra in Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh. PHOTO: PTI

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SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

It is now more than twelve years since I stepped away from my techno-managerial career to pursue passions I had long postponed. It had been a professional journey of three decades, one that taught me many lessons which continue to shape the way I look at the world.

During my early years, I believed that I could accomplish much single-handedly. Fortunately for me, I soon realised the folly of that thinking. No individual is an island of excellence. Leading large teams meant learning that success comes from helping others take responsibility for their work.

Like many of my contemporaries, I often lamented what we saw as the erosion of ownership among younger professionals. Others, however, challenged that assumption. I still remember a senior colleague from my

The meaning of ownership

early years in Railways who had risen through the ranks. He would often remark that many of us in leadership had, in fact, contributed to this decline. During his years as a supervisor, he and his colleagues considered it a reflection on their own capabilities if a senior officer even felt the need to visit the site during a service disruption.

I did not recognise it then, but that lesson had quietly taken root, influencing many decisions I would make in the years that followed. A young engineer working with me had made an error in his calculations, costing us an important contract. I had two choices. I could reprimand him, or I could ask him to learn from the mistake and move on.

I chose the latter. A friend later remarked that I had allowed the young engineer to retain his confidence while accepting responsibility. A sense of ownership evolves when people are encouraged to accept the consequences of their decisions without fear of blame.

The years since have made me more observant of both people and myself. I no longer complain that people lack ownership. What concerns me today is that we may have changed the very meaning of the word. I find people spitting on roads and even on our society lawns. I recall a gentleman who felt my wife had overstepped her boundaries by suggesting that he carry a cloth bag from home instead of demanding a plastic bag from the neighbourhood shop.

I also encounter residents who believe that living in

a society for many years gives them the right to occupy common spaces with their household belongings. Each incident appears trivial in isolation. Together, they reveal how the meaning of ownership itself has begun to change.

Looking back, I realise that ownership meant something very different during my professional life. It meant accepting responsibility for one's actions and understanding how they affected the larger ecosystem. Ownership was measured by the willingness to ask, "How will my decision affect everyone else?"

Today, I feel we have replaced that understanding. Ownership is increasingly interpreted as entitlement—the right to conveniences, facilities, and privileges—without an equally strong sense of responsibility for how our actions affect those around us.

This quiet shift is no longer merely one of civic sense or courtesy. It is a deeper misunderstanding of what ownership truly means. Whether it is an organisation, a residential community, or the planet itself, every ecosystem flourishes only when people accept ownership of their responsibilities rather than merely assert their entitlements.

Perhaps it is never too late to rediscover that ownership begins not with what we claim as ours, but with what we willingly accept as our responsibility.

The writer is a founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

WANGCHUK'S HUNGER STRIKE INTENSIFIES PRESSURE ON THE CENTRE

Activist Sonam Wangchuk has rejected repeated appeals to end his indefinite hunger strike, asserting that he will continue his protest until the Centre initiates meaningful dialogue.

He also revealed that some supporters had approached the courts seeking directions to ensure that he resumed eating. While acknowledging that he was feeling physically weak, Wangchuk urged supporters to participate in large numbers in the proposed "Chalo Sansad" march to Parliament on July 20.

Appealing to schools, colleges and universities, he described the protest as an opportunity for students to witness democratic processes first-hand and better understand how peaceful public movements function in a democracy.

He expressed hope that young

people would actively participate and learn from the experience.

The Cockroach Janta Party has been protesting at Jantar Mantar, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination. The organisation has called for a march to Parliament on July 20, coinciding with the opening day of the Monsoon Session.

The proposed march is expected to intensify political attention on the issue and could place additional pressure on the Centre to respond to the protesters' demands. The coming days are likely to test the government's handling of the agitation.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

India's hydrogen rail leap

India is entering a new phase of development driven by technology, self-reliance, clean energy and public welfare. Indian Railways has become a symbol of this transformation, modernising its network while improving passenger experience and reducing its environmental footprint.

A major milestone in this journey is Haryana's Jind-Sonepat hydrogen train project, the country's first hydrogen-powered train on a broad-gauge route. Designed and manufactured entirely in India, the project demonstrates that the country is no longer merely adopting technology but also developing it.

Built at a cost of about ₹141 crore, the train will operate on the 89-km Jind-Sonepat section, offering a cleaner alternative to diesel-powered trains by significantly reducing carbon emissions. Supporters view it as a more economical step towards railway modernisation than high-speed rail, arguing that it upgrades transport infrastructure at a fraction of the cost while delivering tangible environmental benefits.

Critics, however, question its scale and pace of implementation. Nevertheless, the project reflects the broader national vision of Viksit Bharat, Atmanirbhar Bharat and Green India.

R S NARULA | PATIALA

Politics over farmers' lives

The ongoing Bidadi township controversy in Karnataka exposes a disturbing display of political opportunism. The Karnataka Government continues to push the proposed ₹18,133 crore township project, which threatens nearly 6,500 acres of fertile farmland and around 10 lakh thriving trees.

The project has drawn widespread criticism for treating the lives and livelihoods of nearly 3,500 agrarian families as mere collateral damage in a toxic political turf war. Both the ruling party and the Opposition have allegedly weaponised the 485-day-long protest for electoral advantage rather than addressing the genuine concerns of affected farmers. This is not urban planning; it is predatory land acquisition disguised as development. Reducing the livelihoods of thousands of dairy and coconut farmers to a legacy dispute between political dynasties is deeply disturbing. Development cannot come at the cost of destroying fertile agricultural land, livelihoods and ecological balance. The state government must immediately halt the proposed land acquisition, engage in meaningful dialogue with stakeholders, explore viable alternatives and ensure that people's welfare takes precedence over unchecked urban expansion and concrete jungles.

VIJAYKUMAR H K | HYDERABAD

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Clearing the justice backlog

One of the most glaring weaknesses of India's democracy is its painfully slow justice delivery system, reflected in the mounting pendency of cases. More than 5.8 crore cases are pending across courts, imposing an estimated economic cost exceeding 2 per cent of the country's GDP.

To address this challenge, Chief Justice Surya Kant has launched a focused initiative to dispose of long-pending matters through four special benches sitting on Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday, designated as "non-miscellaneous days".

In the Supreme Court's practice, Mondays and Fridays are reserved as "miscellaneous days" for fresh filings and preliminary hearings. By freeing these four benches from routine admissions, the court aims to devote uninterrupted judicial attention to its oldest pending cases.

Meanwhile, the Supreme Court has become increasingly accessible through e-filing and virtual hearings, leading to a steady rise in fresh cases, which now stand at an unprecedented 75,402. As Justice Kant observed, clearing old cases is essential to restoring public confidence in the justice delivery system and upholding the constitutional promise that justice should never be defeated by the passage of time. Reducing pendency remains central to ensuring timely and meaningful justice.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

From population explosion to population decline

With fertility falling below the replacement level and states like Andhra Pradesh offering cash incentives for a third child, India is confronting a very different reality — how to manage an ageing society, a shrinking workforce and a shifting political balance before it becomes old without becoming rich



GOVIND BHATTACHARJEE

At Independence, India had only 360 million people, and the population was multiplying fast, with a total fertility rate (TFR) of about 6. Today, the population has swelled to 1.45 billion, but the average TFR is down to only 1.9, below the replacement level of 2.1. The TFR also shows wide regional variations: from 1.2 in Delhi and 1.3 in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal to 3.0 in Bihar, 2.9 in Meghalaya, 2.4 in UP, and 2.3 in Jharkhand, the only states with a TFR above the replacement level. In these states too, fertility has been coming down, albeit slowly. With only 2.4 per cent of the world's landmass, India accounts for 18 per cent of its population. Only a few years back, states like Assam and UP were contemplating punitive measures against families with more than two children, and many states still have a two-child policy in force, including Telangana, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Odisha and Uttarakhand. They penalise members of families with more than two children in some way, sometimes debaring them from contesting local elections and sometimes denying them government benefits or employment. Now the clock is turning full circle—in May 2026, in Andhra Pradesh, Chandrababu Naidu announced a payout of ₹30,000 to couples who have a third child. Evidence from across the world suggests that such incentives barely work in encouraging couples to opt for more children.

According to most estimates, India's population will peak around 2050 at about 1.6 billion and then fall as fast as it grew, to only 1 billion by the end of this century. Given our labour force participation rate of about 43 per cent and our median age of 29, it means our labour force will continue to grow for another 30 years or so, after which the demographic dividend will taper away. Thus, there may not be enough time for India to become a rich country unless growth remains steady at 8 per cent for the next three decades, a near impossibility. Just as China, South Korea and Japan are now trying to arrest their fast-declining populations, which are causing them anxiety, India is also getting worried that it will become old before it can become rich.

The worries are visible among the southern states, which have the lowest TFRs. Kerala has a little less than a fifth of its population covered under some form of pension against the national average of 12 per cent; it has now opened a "Department for Ageing". It is already closing schools and importing workers from outside. Other states are also catching up. Demographic theories teach that low fertility starts only when a country reaches a per capita income of around \$7,000 in purchasing power parity (PPP), and women become educated and join the labour force, when they have a decisive voice in the family and want to balance work with childbearing and child-rearing. India's PPP per capita is almost double this threshold, and the falling fertility may reflect a surge in girls' enrolment in school since the 1990s. But 90 per cent of Indian women get married and only 33 per cent work, yet the TFR has been falling. Gen Z clearly seems to prefer dogs over kids.

Parents today prefer quality over quantity—the proportion of children in fee-paying schools rose from 31.7 per cent in 2015 to 38.8 per cent in 2025, and even in poorer states like Bihar and UP, this trend is visible. Also, about 70 per cent of Indians live in nuclear families due to urbanisation and labour market demands, which disincentivise larger family sizes. Further, Indian parents' obsession with a boy child also seems to be weakening, and many parents are now content with having only a girl. The Economist points out that parents' thinking is also reinforced by culture, which in turn is shaped by changes in technology and access to information through the deep penetration of smartphones in rural India. The combined impact is that "having fewer children has become aspirational". Contraction in population is now beyond any dispute; the only question is how to manage it.

The declining TFR is already causing social, economic and political strains. Southern states have always relied on labour from the northern and eastern states like Assam, UP, Odisha and Bihar, traditionally in hotels and restaurants. Now migrants are increasingly providing workers for factories, construction, care-



ACCORDING TO MOST ESTIMATES, INDIA'S POPULATION WILL PEAK AROUND 2050 AT ABOUT 1.6 BILLION AND THEN FALL AS FAST AS IT GREW, TO ONLY 1 BILLION BY THE END OF THIS CENTURY. GIVEN OUR LABOUR FORCE PARTICIPATION RATE OF ABOUT 43 PER CENT AND OUR MEDIAN AGE OF 29, IT MEANS OUR LABOUR FORCE WILL CONTINUE TO GROW FOR ANOTHER 30 YEARS OR SO, AFTER WHICH THE DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND WILL TAPER AWAY

The writer, a former Director General at the CAG of India, is currently a Visiting Professor at IIM Calcutta

giving, nursing, warehousing and logistics, food delivery, e-commerce, domestic work and security jobs. Southern states cannot possibly survive without migrants, but higher migration has the potential to create resentment among the local population; there are already complaints in some states about the influx of outsiders who cannot speak the local language, as seen in demands in Karnataka for greater use of Kannada in workplaces and on public signage. Rapid population growth in cities such as Bengaluru, Chennai, Hyderabad, Kochi and Coimbatore is also creating pressure on urban infrastructure, affecting the quality of public service delivery. Ten per cent of Kerala's population are migrants, and there are growing demands for low-cost housing and primary health-care, which has forced the Kerala government to launch a special health insurance scheme for migrants. Bengaluru has grown from about 6 million people in 2001 to around 15 million today, and the strain on urban infrastructure is visible in water scarcity, interminable traffic congestion, rising rents, and increased pressure on sewage and public transport systems. It is the same tale with other southern cities.

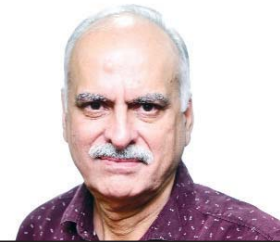
The strains are also visible in public finance: the last two Finance Commissions have used the 2011 population instead of the 1971 population as one of the parameters for determining the states' share, and the southern states have been the losers, while the Hindi-belt states have gained on this account. This has caused significant resentment among the southern states, which feel they have been penalised for controlling their populations.

Now the impending exercise of delimitation has turned into one of the most politically sensitive issues, with the southern states suspecting that they would be penalised for implementing national family-planning goals, while the northern states argue that democracy requires equal representation. Both have valid logic: the current distribution of Lok Sabha seats is still largely based on the 1971 Census, even though India's population has more than doubled since then. The five southern states, with about 20 per cent of the population today, account for 24 per cent of Lok Sabha seats while contributing more than a third of the country's GDP and a disproportionately large share of its tax revenues.

A population-based delimitation would inevitably increase the representation of the faster-growing Hindi-speaking states while reducing the South's share of seats, giving it a much-diminished voice and influence in central policymaking. To resolve this imbroglio, the BJP came up with a formula for a substantial expansion of the total number of Lok Sabha seats so that every state would gain seats and none would lose in absolute terms, but it could not be carried through for want of the requisite parliamentary support.

The task before the government now is to balance the need for equal representation with federal fairness through consensus, so that no state feels left out. The stakes are enormous, but India's federal compact has weathered difficult tests before. There is no reason why a solution cannot be found through consensus again.

Wangchuk brings Ladakh to national centre stage



ANIL ANAND

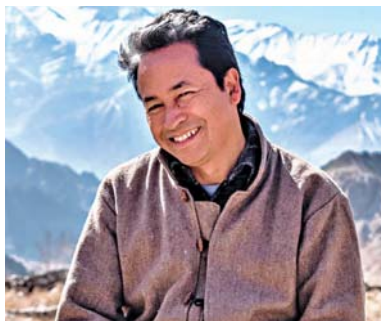
In the midst of the short-lived joy of the Ladakhis, with the Union government reneging on some crucial clauses of the agreement accepted in principle after the May 22, 2026, agreement, educationist and climate activist Sonam Wangchuk has given a new twist to the Ladakh issue while adding grist to the Cockroach Janata Party's (CJP's) youth-related issues. He has embarked on an indefinite hunger strike at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, along with six youth activists, to take the CJP's protest against repeated leaks of NEET and other examination papers to the next level. Their sole demand is the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. It is a repeat of what he did a few months back when he sat on an indefinite hunger strike in the cold environs of Leh. His action not only rattled the administration from Delhi to Leh but also added a new dimension to the Ladakhis' agitation for their political empowerment and the protection of their all-encompassing identity. The outcome was his arrest under the draconian National Security Act and his being confined to the hot environment of a Rajasthan jail, only to be unconditionally released after six months of incarceration, with the clear implication that the tag of being "anti-national" did not stick to him. Wangchuk is brave and astute and carefully chooses his words. He has shown remarkable determination not only in pursuing the Ladakh cause, in the face of attempts by the state machinery to defame him, but also in joining the bigger cause of Gen Z's sufferings due to the malfunctioning of the education system and the government of the day simply looking the other way around. Notwithstanding the opposition by some of his fellow Ladakhi leaders, though they are few in number, and the state machinery being busy plotting moves to corner him, Wangchuk seems to have crossed all hurdles with aplomb. There is no doubt that Wangchuk's presence in the CJP stir and his reiteration that education is central to the development of a society and a nation has given strength to the movement, which has entered its second stage. The people of Ladakh (Leh and Kargil divisions) have been fighting for their rights for quite some time, the issue has caught the imagination of the national and international media only sparsely. This is despite the strategic and geopolitical location of Ladakh, bordering China and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, with Central Asia not far away. Their nationalist credentials have been reflected repeatedly in both peace and war. No one can question their role as the second line of defence in every situation. Sitting at Jantar Mantar, Wangchuk has been mostly speaking about the concerns of students and youth in line with the CJP's narrative, but his very presence on a forum in the national capital, with the eyes of the world riveted on the youth agitation, brings the Ladakh issue—knowingly or unknowingly—into the limelight. Perhaps he chose the CJP route to silently present the issue on the national platform.

By merging the student-led examination protest with the long-standing campaign for Ladakh's Sixth Schedule inclusion and statehood, he has turned a regional matter, albeit one of international significance, into a mainstream issue. After all, the two issues have a common thread in the future of both students and Ladakhis, with education being the vital link. And who better than the renowned educationist and environmentalist Wangchuk, who landed at the Jantar Mantar dharna after participating in an international environmental meet in Switzerland? As more than a week has elapsed since the CJP started its second leg of agitation at the same place following the Centre's (read Prime Minister Modi's) reluctance to remove the Education Minister, the administration has been handling the situation in a cool and calculated manner, barring the disconnection of electricity and power supply and depriving the protesters of toilet facilities.

Earlier, the agreement with the Centre had raised hopes of Ladakh getting a mechanism to usher in people's rule with an elected assembly spearheaded by a chief minister-like mechanism. Presently, it is a centrally administered Union Territory, which came into being on August 5, 2019, after the then state of Jammu and Kashmir was demoted and divided into two UTs—Ladakh and Jammu & Kashmir. However, the hopes were short-lived and belied after the Centre allegedly backtracked on the most important part of the May 22 decisions. Nearly a month after their meeting with the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), representative groups from Ladakh—the Apex Body Leh (ABL) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA)—upped the ante by observing a complete shutdown on June 23 to protest against the failure to incorporate key points agreed upon during last month's meeting on the Union Territory's political future.

What has triggered the crisis again within such a short span, after hope had been generated for lasting peace? And why? During the sub-committee meeting with the MHA, the Centre reportedly agreed in principle to consider constitutional safeguards for Ladakh under the provisions of Article 371. The proposal had the following key ingredients, among other things: "A democratic structure for Ladakh featuring legislative, executive and financial powers." "The bureaucracy, including the Chief Secretary, functioning under an executive led by the people of Ladakh." These provisions went missing from the official minutes released by the government after some delay. Ladakhi leaders asserted that, by omitting these points, the Centre is employing delaying tactics and reneging on its promises. In this backdrop, Wangchuk's arrival at Jantar Mantar to share the platform with CJP activists has also silently given a new dimension to the Ladakh issue, besides raising the profile of the agitation. In his interviews after starting his protest fast, he gave clear indications that he was prepared for a long haul and that he was undeterred by pressure coming from any side. There is no doubt that his commitment both to the Ladakh cause and now to the cause of students and youth, with a thrust on rights and education, is unflinching. His discourse, both in Ladakh and now in New Delhi, is devoid of any political grandstanding, despite the fact that his detractors have been accusing him of being guided by political ambitions. The fact of the matter is that he unsuccessfully contested elections in the past and may be inclined to do so again in future. He is well within his constitutional rights to do so. No issue in a vibrant democracy such as India can be devoid of politics, and more so if the government or the ruling dispensation themselves are inclined to politicise issues in pursuit of electoral benefits, whatever the cost may be, or to sit on false prestige. As Wangchuk has rightly said, the prestige of a government is enhanced if it admits its faults and is prepared to rectify the course in the larger public interest. This is the 'mool mantra' that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his government should follow on Ladakh, the CJP and other issues concerning the people's welfare. No matter that a lot of time has already been lost in dithering and clinging to false prestige.

The writer is a political analyst



ASHWANI MAHAJAN

Following the peace agreement between the US and Iran after the roughly three-and-a-half-month-long Gulf conflict, the Strait of Hormuz—a vital conduit for massive crude oil shipments—has reopened. It is worth noting that the closure of the Strait of Hormuz not only disrupted oil transit but also caused a drastic surge in oil prices. Crude oil prices, which hovered around US \$70-80 per barrel before the war, spiked to as high as US \$126 per barrel during the conflict. Although prices fluctuated, they largely remained in the vicinity of US \$100 per barrel. The public was affected not only by shortages resulting from supply disruptions but also by rising inflation worldwide, driven by soaring oil prices. Even though the US is self-sufficient in petroleum supplies, it was also not immune to the impact of these high prices. Against this backdrop, a global conversation—including within India—began regarding the need to reduce dependence on imported crude oil. The primary question that arose was: Is fuel self-reliance achievable?

Currently, India relies on foreign sources for approximately 88 per cent of its crude oil and imports 50 per cent of its gas requirements. The

sudden shortage of these commodities following the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz impacted not only prices but also businesses ranging from small restaurants and roadside tea vendors to gas-dependent industrial establishments. Consequently, the country began deliberating on how to achieve self-reliance in fuel and energy.

The seven appeals Prime Minister Narendra Modi made to the nation to conserve foreign exchange—such as using public transport, carpooling and working from home—directly pointed towards reducing the country's dependence on petroleum products. However, it must be understood that while we can save foreign exchange in the short term by consuming less energy, energy self-reliance is the only viable option for the long term. Biogas can emerge as a significant alternative to petroleum gases. India possesses abundant resources—such as cattle dung, agricultural residues and household waste—that can be used to produce biogas, yet we are currently utilising only about 5 per cent of this potential. Naturally, with concerted efforts, biogas plants could be established at the village or village-cluster level. This would not only meet local fuel needs and reduce reliance on imported gas but also significantly lower fuel costs. Moreover, with minor modifications, vehicles can also be made to run on biogas.

While petrol and diesel have long been considered indispensable for vehicles in the country, we must recall that just a decade ago, India was facing power shortages. Today, however, the entire



nation enjoys 24-hour electricity supply, and a surplus of power is being recorded, especially during off-peak hours. Concurrently, there has been a massive expansion in renewable energy generation capacity.

Renewable energy capacity, which stood at a mere 35 gigawatts in 2014, has now surpassed 200 gigawatts, with an additional 25 to 30 gigawatts of capacity being added annually. Although rising energy prices had previously motivated us to strive for energy self-reliance, the further price hikes and supply disruptions caused by the war have accelerated these efforts. Thanks to the establishment of substantial power generation capacity, India has become virtually self-reliant in the energy sector; in fact, we even generate surplus electricity during off-peak hours. Increased incentives in the form of subsidies for residential solar installations have started boosting power generation capaci-

ty even more. The government is striving to ramp up domestic production of solar and wind energy equipment, which will further enhance the potential for expanding power generation capacity. Therefore, the time has come to shift from petrol- and diesel-powered vehicles to electric vehicles. We can readily adopt electric buses, trucks, cars and scooters. This could lead to substantial savings in petrol and diesel, thereby reducing dependence on overseas sources and conserving valuable foreign exchange. Traditionally in India, automobiles used to run on either petrol or diesel and later on CNG. In the last few years, the use of hybrid cars has also increased, where fuel consumption is lower, as vehicles run partially on petrol and partially on batteries. In more recent times, the use of electric vehicles has started increasing. The popularity of EVs can be seen from the fact that, in June 2026, the share of EVs in the scooter segment increased to more than 10 per cent, while electric cars constituted nearly 8 per cent of total car sales, and this has continuously been increasing over time. Before the war, in January 2026, the share of electric cars in total automobile purchases was hardly 3.6 per cent. Beyond transportation, we can also make greater use of electric cooking appliances, such as induction cooktops. New developments in research on nuclear power generation in the country could further strengthen our energy security. The government is giving a major push to biogas production; furthermore, research and

development are facilitating the compression of biogas, making its use in vehicles feasible. Such experiments are already proving successful. Overall, it can be said that while efforts towards energy self-reliance were already underway, the conflict between the US and Iran—and the resulting surge in oil prices and supply disruptions—has provided a significant impetus to this goal. We must not allow this momentum to slow down. The country needs to undertake comprehensive and organised efforts to eliminate its dependence on imported crude oil. Simultaneously, a shift in the mindset of the general public is essential. Entrepreneurs must be encouraged to invest in the energy sector, and the active participation of young people in research and development (R&D) activities must be ensured.

Developing an extensive charging infrastructure is also imperative to popularise electric cars and other electric vehicles across the country. Although there is adequate electricity generation, power supply is frequently interrupted in many areas due to deficiencies in the grid system. The government needs to make concerted efforts to resolve this issue. Despite these challenges, none of them are insurmountable. With well-planned policies, strong willpower and coordinated efforts, India can drastically reduce its dependence on foreign crude oil over the next decade. This is the need of the hour.

The writer is the National Co-convenor of the Swadeshi Jagaran Manch and a former Professor at PGDAV College, University of Delhi



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SC declines bulldozer demolition contempt pleas

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to consider a batch of contempt petitions alleging that demolitions were carried out in violation of its 2024 judgment and asked aggrieved parties to approach the concerned high courts.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana noted that there are multiple questions that require consideration on basis of facts.

The top court said it would transfer the records of these proceedings to the concerned high courts, also asking them to call for relevant records and, if necessary, obtain evidence through district courts to determine all factual issues.

Clarifying that it has not expressed any opinion on the merits of the allegations, the apex court directed that the interim protection granted by it would continue during the pendency of the proceedings before the high courts. "However, the parties would be free to seek modification of the interim orders before the high courts, which would decide such applications independently," the bench said while requesting the high courts to decide the matter preferably within four months.

During the hearing, senior advocate Huzefa Ahmadi, appearing in a case pertaining to razing of mosques in Somnath, submitted that there was no encroachment of public land in this instance.

He alleged "egregious violations" of the apex court's orders, saying authorities acted in teeth of the court directions.

(PTI)

Allahabad HC fines UP Govt ₹50,000 over bail delay

The Allahabad High Court has imposed a cost of ₹50,000 on the Uttar Pradesh Government for negligence by police officials of Bijnor which delayed the disposal of a bail application in a case by more than 10 days.

However, the State Government may recover the amount from the erring officers after conducting an enquiry, the court said.

A bench of Justice Arun Kumar Singh Deshwali, which was hearing a bail application filed by Yaseen and another accused in a dowry death case, said the plea could have been disposed of on July 3 but could not be done as despite repeated reminders and oral intimation, the requisite instructions were not supplied to the court. "... It remained pending for more than 10 days due to the laxity on the part of the police," Justice Deshwali said. The court on July 3 allowed the bail plea filed by both the in-laws of the deceased woman after finding that there was no sufficient material against the applicants to show that they harassed her for non-fulfilment of the demand of dowry prior to her death or subjected her to cruelty.

The court also noted that the independent witnesses pointed to a petty household dispute between the husband and wife. It said that although the Office of the Joint Director (Prosecution), Allahabad High Court had supplied a copy of the bail application to the police pairokra on June 17 and an alert was also given to the Superintendent of Police on June 19 with a reminder on June 29, the police failed to provide the necessary instructions.

During the hearing on July 3, the court directed the prosecution to obtain the PDF of the case diary from the CCTNS portal. Instead of complying, the police officials concerned sent only the applicants' case history, not the actual case diary. This prompted the court to summon the Station House Officer (SHO) concerned to appear in person. The court accepted the SHO's explanation that he was on leave and handling law-and-order duties for the Kanwar procession.

(PTI)

Delhi court rejects bail plea of PFI chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has rejected the bail plea of Popular Front of India's (PFI) founding chairman E Abubacker, arrested for his alleged involvement in a conspiracy to overthrow the Indian Government and establish an Islamic caliphate by 2047. Special NIA Judge Prashant Sharma was hearing the application by the accused seeking regular bail on the grounds that his health is deteriorating and there is no concrete case against him.

In an order dated July 15, the court said, "In view of the aforesaid appreciation and facts and circumstances of this case, I do not find any ground to grant bail to the applicant. Accordingly, the present bail application of applicant/accused E Abubacker stands dismissed."



Popular Front of India's founding chairman E Abubacker

Abubacker's lawyer told the court that charges have already been framed against his client and his health is also deteriorating. He contended that there has been a delay in the judicial proceedings in the matter.

"Those circumstances include the gravity of the offence, the workload on this court, the number of accused persons involved, the number



Monitor Wangchuk's health: Delhi HC tells authorities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday directed authorities to monitor daily the health of activist Sonam Wangchuk, who is on an indefinite fast at Jantar Mantar here over alleged irregularities in the NEET exam, and extend medical aid if his condition deteriorates.

Asserting that a citizen's life was precious and all medical efforts ought to be made by authorities to save it, a bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said Wangchuk's condition should be regularly checked by Government doctors.

Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta, who appeared for the Centre as well as the Delhi Government, submitted that life of every individual

was precious and there was no objection to undertaking Wangchuk's regular medical checkup. "We observe that life of any citizen is precious and all medical efforts ought to be made by Government authorities to save the same," the court said.

"We appreciate the stance taken by the learned Solicitor General and accordingly direct that the medical condition of Wangchuk shall be clinically and otherwise regularly monitored on daily basis, and depending on the opinion of the doctors, whatever medical intervention is required to check his deteriorating health condition shall also be taken," it ordered, as it closed the proceedings on a PIL raising concern over Wangchuk's health. The Cockroach Janta Party has been holding a protest for



over 25 days demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination.

Wangchuk joined the agitation on June 28 and has been on an indefinite fast since then. During the hearing, the court asked SG

Mehta if there was a mechanism to check the fasting activist's health condition and if the authorities had such reports.

SG Mehta responded that a health checkup was done on a daily basis and Wangchuk and others were informed of his parameters.

HC asks Maharashtra DGP to take stock of CCTV cameras at police stations, report on data storage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has directed the Maharashtra Director General of Police to launch a state-wide fact-finding exercise to take an overall view of CCTV cameras installed across all police stations and submit a report about the duration for which their data is preserved.

A division bench comprising Acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad issued the directive to the DGP on Wednesday after expressing concern over the submission by Mumbai's Ghatkopar police station that CCTV footage older than six months was unavailable.

The HC noted the state chief secretary had given an undertaking to the court in the past committing to expand capacity and ensure footage recorded by CCTV cameras at police stations was preserved for 18



months. The court was hearing a criminal writ petition filed by one Prashant Satyawar Kokane, who argued his case in person.

Kokane told the court he had submitted an application to the senior Inspector of the Ghatkopar police station on April 15, 2025, less than a month after an incident which occurred between March 17-20, 2025, specifically requesting for preservation of its CCTV footage. However, the

state Government had informed the court that the footage demanded by the applicant was unavailable as the police station preserves CCTV data only for a period of six months and that duration had lapsed when the video tapes were sought.

The bench noted that the police's stand was in contrast to the Supreme Court guidelines and explicit undertakings previously given by the state Government to upgrade backup capacities to 18 months. It was referring to a landmark Supreme Court judgment in Paramvir Singh Saini v.

Baljit Singh case, which mandated comprehensive CCTV coverage across all entry and exit points, cells, corridors, and lounges of police stations. Further, the bench cited a March 2022 HC order where the state chief secretary had given an undertaking

to the court committing to expand and "top up" the systems, ensuring that data backups are kept for 18 months and that generators are supplied to handle irregular power supply.

"We call upon the Director General of Police to initiate a fact-finding exercise to take an overall view of all police stations in Maharashtra, in the light of the Paramvir Singh's judgment, and submit a report as regards the functionality of CCTV cameras and the period of preservation of the data in the hard disks connected with all CCTVs," the high court said.

The bench asserted that the report should also mention why the Ghatkopar Police Station submitted that CCTV footage cannot be preserved beyond six months.

The police have been asked to submit the report by August 10, when the matter will be heard again.

Liquor policy case: HC gives 2 weeks to Kejriwal, Sisodia to respond to CBI's plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday granted a final opportunity to AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak, asking them to respond within two weeks to the CBI's plea against a trial court order discharging them in the liquor policy case.

Justice Manoj Jain deferred hearing on CBI's revision petition after none appeared for the discharged accused persons due to work abstention by high court lawyers, and listed the case for hearing arguments on behalf of the investigating agency on August 17 and 18.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the CBI, said the three AAP leaders were earlier given several opportunities by the high court to file their replies, and the case has been "sufficiently delayed."

"In any case if I am giving a date, we will make it clear that they would be at liberty to file a reply," Justice Jain responded. The judge added that a time frame shall be fixed for hearing submissions on behalf of the dis-



charged accused persons. "The report of the registry would indicate that so far no reply has been received from respondent nos. 8, 18 & 19. Although opportunity was granted to them earlier on several occasions, in view of interest of justice, one last and final opportunity is granted to them to file replies within 2 weeks from today," ordered the court. "Matter would be taken up on 17 & 18th of August at 2:30 for hearing from the side of the revisionist," it added.

The senior law officer urged the court to set an earlier date in July or early August, remarking that the date fixed was "a little too long."

Justice Jain, however, said there were other cases pertaining to MP/MLAs pending in his

court and it was not possible to accommodate the CBI's request. The judge nonetheless assured SG Mehta that he would re-assess the possibility of having the case on an earlier date. The court also asked the parties to file their written submissions. On May 25, the court had deferred the hearing till July 16 on CBI's petition to await the presence of counsel on behalf of the unrepresented AAP leaders, who had earlier boycotted the hearing before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma.

High court lawyers are abstaining from work since July 14 to protest against a possible enhancement in the pecuniary jurisdiction of district courts here from ₹2 crore to ₹10 crore.

SC seeks Centre's stand on rail ticket relief for acid attack survivors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought the views of the Centre on a plea seeking concessional air-conditioned class rail fare for acid attack survivors to enable them to travel to well-equipped hospitals in cities for periodic treatment.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana asked Additional Solicitor General Archana Pathak Dave to take requisite instructions from the Ministry of Railways on the issue. At the outset, Dave said that there are 21 categories of persons with disabilities (PwDs) and the railways is already providing travel concessions to them. She said the railways is also contemplating providing an emergency travel quota for all categories of PwDs.

The counsel, appearing for PIL petitioner Atijeevan Society, which has sought railway reservations for acid attack victims, said that such survivors have to undertake



multiple visits to super-specialty hospitals for treatment for almost four to five years. He said that persons who have been forced to ingest acid face difficulty in getting medical certificates to seek a railway reservation. Moreover, they are asked to get such certificates from the treating hospitals to claim reservation and which is difficult, he added.

The bench asked the law officer to see whether acid attack victims can be included in the category of patients like Thalassaemia and cancer to ensure that they can also avail the concession in rail tickets to get treatment.

The bench asked the law officer to take instructions



conduct the exercise by the poll panel. It had said the exercise "breathes life" into the constitutional mandate for fair elections and advanced the "constitutional imperative of free and fair elections". It also said the poll panel was empowered under Article 324 of the Constitution and Section 21(3) of the Representation of the People Act (RPA) to carry out special revisions.

On November 3 last year, the DMK had moved the top court against the SIR, calling the exercise "unconstitutional, arbitrary, and a threat to democratic rights".

Ajay, Ashish Mishra not involved in Lakhimpur Kheri witness intimidation: UP Police tells SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Uttar Pradesh Police on Thursday told the Supreme Court that former minister Ajay Mishra and his son Ashish, accused in the killing of four people in Lakhimpur Kheri in 2021, were not involved in the alleged intimidation of witnesses and not chargesheeted for it.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was also informed that the trial in the case is likely to conclude within the next three months.

The bench adjourned the hearing on Ashish Mishra's bail plea after taking note of progress of the trial and the



fresh status report filed before it. The matter has now been listed for hearing next month.

"The chargesheet has been filed against one Amandeep Singh. Cognizance has been taken. As regards the role of Ajay Mishra, Ashish Mishra andãu! the investigation reveals that they were not involved in the alleged offence," the bench noted.

On October 3, 2021, eight

people, including four farmers, were killed in Tikunia in Uttar Pradesh's Lakhimpur Kheri district during a protest by farmers against Deputy Chief Minister Keshav Prasad Maurya's visit to the area.

Four farmers were mowed down by a sports utility vehicle. A driver and two BJP workers were then allegedly lynched by angry farmers. A journalist also died in the violence. The Mishras and others were accused of intimidating witnesses of the main violence incident.

On Thursday, senior advocate Siddharth Dave, appearing for Ashish Mishra, submitted before the apex court that the latest status report showed that investigation in the separate FIR on alleged witness intimidation had

been completed and neither of the Mishras were found to be involved. "Now that the chargesheet has been filed, we have been absolved. If anyone has any grievance, they have remedies before the magistrate. It cannot be kept alive here."

The bench also took note of the updated status of the ongoing trial in the main Lakhimpur Kheri violence case, which indicated that 62 witnesses remain to be examined. Dave said the trial was expected to conclude within approximately three months.

On May 8 this year, the apex court had expressed dissatisfaction over the slow pace of proceedings after noting that no witness had been examined for two months.

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AI fuels ‘K’-shaped global economy, says Moody’s



The global economy is witnessing ‘K’ shaped growth where the artificial intelligence boom pushes some countries and industries ahead, leaving others behind, Moody’s Analytics said on Thursday.

In its Global Economy Outlook, Moody’s Analytics said it expects global growth to slow to 2.5 per cent in 2026 and pick up to just 2.8 per cent in 2027.

It said that booming demand for artificial intelligence has saved the global economy from a sharper slowdown, but geopolitical risks, stretched asset valuations, and volatility in financial markets could easily flip the outlook from slow growth to recession.

“The global economy is running at two different speeds. In some segments, growth is holding up better than expected, courtesy of the AI boom. ... But economies and industries less plugged into the AI boom have struggled,” Moody’s Analytics said.

The agency said AI boom has driven a surge in data centre investment, exports in Asia’s tech-heavy economies, and stock market valuations across the world. Geopolitical upheaval and trade disruptions, from the Middle East conflict to friction between the US and its trading partners, have driven up prices and the cost of doing business. (PTI)

India key EU chip partner: European Commission VP



India is a very important partner for the European Union in the semiconductor sector as the bloc seeks to work with trusted partners to strengthen its chip supply chains and build its own capacity, a senior European Commission leader said.

Speaking at a joint press conference after the third India-EU Trade and Technology Council (TTC) meeting in Brussels, European Commission Executive Vice-President for Tech Sovereignty, Security and Democracy Henna Virkkunen said India is an important partner for semiconductor research and development because of its vast pool of highly skilled talent.

“With semiconductors, we see that India is a very important partner for the European Union. Our Chips 2.0 was adopted in June. We are especially focusing on improving the resilience of our supply chains. We want to build up our own capacity in the European Union, but we also want to work with our trusted partners,” she said. (PTI)

Stock markets close flat amid uncertainties

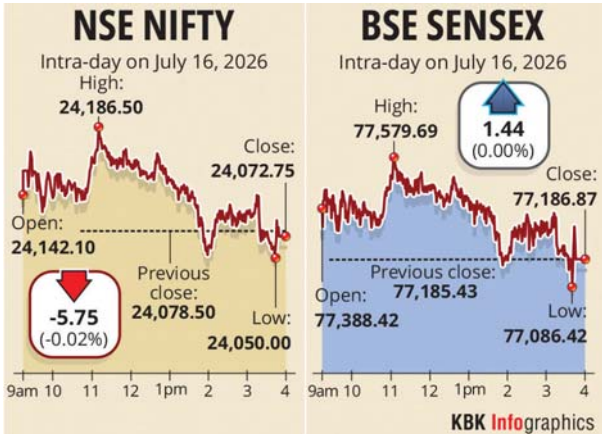
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty closed almost unchanged on Thursday, as profit-taking in blue-chip stocks such as HDFC Bank and Reliance Industries offset gains in IT shares amid geopolitical tensions.

The 30-share BSE Sensex edged up 1.44 points to settle at 77,186.87. During the day, it climbed 394.26 points, or 0.51 per cent, to 77,579.69 but pared gains towards the end of the session. The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 5.75 points, or 0.02 per cent, to end at 24,072.75.

Fluctuating oil prices and weak Asian market trends also weighed on domestic equities, according to an expert. Among Sensex shares, InterGlobe Aviation, HCL Technologies, Bajaj Finance, Maruti, Mahindra & Mahindra and Tech Mahindra were the major winners. Eterna, Bharat Electronics, Bajaj Finserv, HDFC Bank and Axis Bank were among the laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dipped 0.39 per cent to \$84.62 per barrel.

In Asian markets, South Korea’s Kospi tanked 6.37 per cent. Japan’s Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai’s SSE Composite index also settled



lower, while Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index ended higher. “Indian equities concluded largely subdued as investors remained cautious amid geopolitical uncertainties, fluctuating oil prices, and weak Asian market trends,” said Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited.

Meanwhile, cooling US inflation eased rate concerns and offered downside support, he added. The BSE SmallCap Select index declined 0.21 per cent and MidCap Select index dipped 0.07 per cent.

Among sectors, Consumer Durables jumped 1.13 per cent, followed by Focused IT (0.58 per cent), IT (0.58 per cent), Auto (0.30 per cent),

Petrol, diesel sales surge in first half of July

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Petrol and diesel sales by India’s three state-run fuel retailers rose sharply in the first half of July, helped by below-normal monsoon rainfall that boosted fuel demand from farmers and motorists, preliminary sales data showed on Thursday.

Petrol sales by Indian Oil Corp (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corp Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corp Ltd (HPCL) climbed 22.9 per cent to 1.63 million tonnes during July 1-15, compared with 1.33 million tonnes in the corresponding period a year earlier.

The volume was also 26.7 per cent higher than 1.29 million tonnes sold during



the first half of July 2024 and 38.6 per cent above the level recorded in the same period of 2023. Compared with the

first half of June, however, petrol sales fell 4.4 per cent from 1.71 million tonnes.

Diesel sales, a key indica-

tor of economic activity in India, rose 20.9 per cent year-on-year to 3.46 million tonnes in the first fortnight

NITI Aayog charts 2047 roadmap to expand India’s bioeconomy to \$2.6 trillion by 2047

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India can scale its bioeconomy to \$691 billion by 2035 and \$2.6 trillion by 2047 with decisive, mission-mode execution, according to a report by the NITI Aayog. Bioeconomy is an economic model that uses renewable biological materials to produce food, energy, and industrial goods.

In a bid to realise India’s \$2.6 trillion BioEconomy vision by 2047, the country must move from fragmented initiatives to a coordinated national execution architecture, the Aayog in a report titled “Roadmap for Building India as a Leading BioEconomy Powerhouse by 2035” said.

“With decisive, mission-mode execution, India can scale its BioEconomy to \$691 billion by 2035 and \$2.6 trillion by 2047, creating over 30 million high-value jobs and positioning the country among the world’s top three biotechnology powers,” it said.

The Aayog stressed that mission-mode national BioMissions to scale priority sectors will be necessary to realise



India’s \$2.6 trillion BioEconomy vision by 2047.

Moreover, empowered committees to drive cross-ministerial coordination; regulatory reforms to accelerate approvals while ensuring safety and trust; and a strengthened bioscience leadership and talent pipeline; and a ₹50,000 crore BioEconomy Growth Fund to support innovation, scale-up,

infrastructure and biomanufacturing are also needed to scale the country’s bioeconomy to \$691 billion, the Aayog added.

The report also set out a strategic proposition for India to transition from traditional biological R&D to AI-enabled biotechnology and next-generation biomanufacturing, driven by deeper collaboration across ministries, departments, academia, industry and startups.

“Early action would allow India not merely to participate in this transformation, but to shape the global rules, markets and platforms of the biological age—an upheaval likely to rival, and perhaps surpass, the disruption unleashed by artificial intelligence,” it noted.

The report noted that, globally, major powers are already moving at speed.

“The United States has adopted a whole-of-government approach to biomanufacturing; the European Union is tying biotechnology to climate and industrial competitiveness; China is deploying five-year plans to industrialise at scale,” it said.

India aims for FMD-free status in nine States within two years, eyes Europe’s dairy market

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India is targeting foot-and-mouth disease (FMD) free status in at least nine states over the next two years, a step the government hopes will finally open the door to Europe’s dairy market that has remained largely out of reach for the world’s biggest milk producer.

Speaking at the 98th foundation day of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) on Thursday, Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh said sustained indigenous vaccination has already sharply reduced FMD outbreaks from 105 in 2021 to just 40 last year.

Nine states with consistently low outbreak numbers and



completed vaccination cycles have now been identified as the first candidates for FMD-free certification, he said.

“Despite leading the world in milk production, we have struggled to export dairy

products, largely because developed countries, especially in Europe, require FMD-free certification,” Singh said.

“The Prime Minister has set a goal of making India FMD-free by 2030.”

Once certified by the World Organisation for Animal Health, the nine states would effectively give India its first real foothold to begin dairy exports to markets that have long insisted on disease-free status as a precondition for trade, he said.

The disease control was achieved through a wider vaccination and traceability drive, he said, adding that the government has issued 13-digit digital identity tags to 38 crore animals and, this year, rolled out an OTP-based verification system — farmers now get a one-time password on their phones to confirm a vaccination actually took place, after several states flagged instances of vaccinations being logged without being administered.

Social protection covers 100 crore Indians: Mandaviya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India’s social protection coverage increased to over 100 crore citizens in 2026, up from 25 crore in 2015, according to Union Labour and Employment Minister Mansukh Mandaviya.

The minister, in a post on social media platform X on Wednesday, highlighted the landmark validation of the country’s social security landscape by the International Labour Organisation (ILO).

“India breaches 1 billion mark in Social Protection

Coverage!” Mandaviya wrote on X, thanking ILO Director-General Gilbert F Houngbo “for acknowledging India’s efforts towards expanding social protection coverage”.

In the same post, the minister laid out the scale of the shift: “Under the leadership of PM Shri @narendramodiji, India’s social protection coverage has grown from 25 crore citizens (19 per cent) in 2015 to over 100 crore citizens (68.4 per cent) in 2026, reflecting the Modi government’s commitment to Sabka Saath Sabka Vikas.

The numbers mark one of



the steepest expansions of social security coverage recorded anywhere, taking India from covering less than a fifth of its population a little

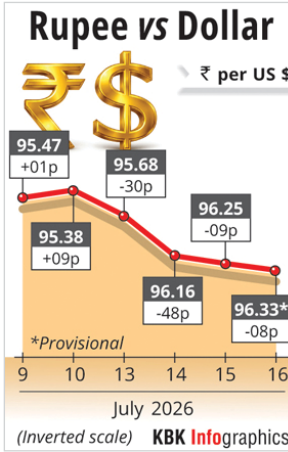
over a decade ago, to covering more than two-thirds of it today.

India was conferred with the prestigious International

Social Security Association (ISSA) Award 2025 for ‘Outstanding Achievement in Social Security’ in Malaysia in October 2025, for the expansion of social security coverage from 19 per cent in 2015 to 64.3 per cent in 2025, reaching over 940 million citizens as of last year, as noted by the ILO.

The new milestone was formally recognised by the ILO’s Director-General in a video message to the 12th BRICS Labour and Employment Ministers’ Meeting in Hyderabad on Wednesday, held under India’s BRICS Chairship 2026.

Barclays sees FCNR inflows falling short of lofty expectations



Foreign currency non-resident (FCNR) deposit inflows are likely to fall short of lofty market expectations despite gaining momentum in the coming weeks, according to the report.

The rupee is expected to depreciate gradually amid higher oil prices and strong importer demand for dollars, Barclays Research said on Thursday.

“The RBI recently met with commercial banks and

assessed the progress of the FCNR deposit scheme. Inflows have been lower than expected so far. Banks have noted that inflows will pick up momentum, but we highlight a number of factors that could mean overall flows fall short of lofty market expectations,” the global broker-kage said in a report.

It can be noted that the RBI and the government had announced a series of measures in early June to increase the capital flows into the country, including the measures on FCNR (B),

under which a non-resident can open a foreign currency fixed deposit with an Indian bank. The announcement was met with expectations of the flows topping at least \$50 billion, and some analysts also pegged the number at \$70 billion. The rupee, which had seen sharp depreciation, also reacted positively.

On Thursday, Barclays said the rupee has come under renewed pressure following the rebound in crude oil prices and increased dollar buying by importers, adding

“we see further gradual depreciation ahead”.

The brokerage said it continues to believe that the RBI’s recent measures have taken out the tail risk from the rupee and will help turn India’s balance of payments into a healthy surplus, but cautioned that FCNR inflows have so far disappointed and that downside risks to the currency remain linked to oil prices. However, it warned that importer demand for dollars continues to outweigh these inflows, keeping pressure on the rupee.



GAIL observes Swachhata Pakhwada 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As part of the nationwide observance of Swachhata Pakhwada 2026 (1-15 July), GAIL (India) Limited, a Maharatna Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas, has undertaken a series of cleanliness, hygiene and community engagement initiatives across its offices, plants, project sites and operational locations throughout the country.

The fortnight-long campaign reflects GAIL’s continued commitment towards promoting environmental responsibility, public participation and sustainable practices in alignment with the vision of Swachh Bharat Mission.

During the observance, GAIL organised a wide range of activities designed to encourage cleanliness as a collective responsibility while creating lasting awareness across communities.

These initiatives included cleanliness drives, Swachhata Pledge ceremonies, awareness rallies, tree plantation programmes, waste segregation campaigns, health check-up camps, painting competitions, Waste-to-Wealth competitions, distribution of dustbins at public institutions, hygiene awareness programmes in schools and community outreach activities across multiple locations. Deepak Gupta,

CMD, GAIL, and Ayush Gupta, Director (HR), GAIL, along with GAIL employees, participated in a cleanliness drive at Bhikaji Cama Place, New Delhi, as part of the Swachhata Pakhwada initiative.

The participation of the CMD reflects GAIL’s strong commitment to cleanliness, hygiene, and the upkeep of its facilities and surrounding areas. Swachhata Pakhwada is being observed with great enthusiasm across GAIL’s offices and operating units, reinforcing the organisation’s dedication to fostering a clean, healthy, and sustainable work environment.

A significant focus of this year’s observance was on engaging young minds through schools and educational institutions.

Students actively participated in painting competitions, cleanliness awareness rallies, tree plantation drives, street plays and creative sustainability activities that promoted responsible waste management and environmental stewardship. Through these initiatives, GAIL sought to encourage behavioural change and foster a deeper understanding of cleanliness and conservation among the next generation.

Recognising that cleanliness and well-being go hand in hand, GAIL also organized dedicated health check-up camps for contractual workers engaged in housekeeping and essential support services.

FROM THE
WORLD

PAKISTAN

Four TTP

militants killed

Four TTP militants were killed on Thursday after law enforcement officials thwarted a vehicle-borne suicide attack on a security post in Pakistan's restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, police said. Security personnel intercepted the explosives-laden vehicle before it could reach its target in the Wana town.

Following the failed suicide bombing attempt at the Kari Kot post, an exchange of fire took place between security forces and the attackers, during which four militants, including the suicide bomber, were killed. The militants were affiliated with 'Fitna al-Khawarij', police said, referring to the term the State uses for the outlawed Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and its affiliates. No casualties were reported among security forces during the operation, according to officials. Security officials said a search and clearance operation is underway in the area to trace and eliminate any remaining militants. (AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public that I have never executed, signed or registered any General Power of Attorney, Special Power of Attorney or any other authority document in favour of any person, including my children, namely;

1. Shri Ashok Kumar Jaggi.
2. Shri Anil Kumar Jaggi.
3. Shri Romil Kumar Jaggi.
4. Shri Vijay Kumar Jaggi.
5. Smt. Shashi Bhardwaj.

With respect to any movable or immovable property, Accordingly, if any person claims to be acting or has acted on my behalf on the basis of any alleged Power of Attorney purportedly executed by me in favor of any of the above-named persons or any other person, such document is false, fabricated, forged, unauthorized, illegal and not binding upon me.

The General public, banks, financial institutions, government authorities, Sub-Registrars and all other concerned persons are hereby cautioned not to rely upon or act on any such purported Power of Attorney or Authority document. Any person dealing with any such document shall do so entirely at his/her own risk, cost and consequences.

Place: New Delhi.
Dated: 14.7.2026.

(Smt. Saroj Rani Jaggi).
Add: A-263, New Colony,
New Delhi - 110023.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Gund Govind, Father of-

No.23005671L Sep Sharad Govind Gund, R/o- At Hasalgan TQ Ausa, Dist- Latur, Maharashtra- 413520, have changed my name from Gund Govind to Govind Vishvnath Gund, vide dated 16/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(182)C

I, Anita, Mother of-

No.23005671L Sep Sharad Govind Gund, R/o- At Hasalgan TQ Ausa, Dist- Latur, Maharashtra- 413520, have changed my name from Anita to Anita Govind Gund, vide dated 16/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(183)C

I, Kailsawari, W/o-

No.14357561H Ex-Nk Late K Samuthirakani, R/o- 1/135/2, Kkssn Nagar, PO- Pandian Nagar, Teh/Dist- Virudhunagar, Tamilnadu- 626001, have changed my name from Kailsawari to Kaleswari, & in my husband's service record my date of birth is wrongly written as 06/04/1968 whereas my correct date of birth is 01/01/1968 vide affidavit dated 16.07.2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(184)C

Syria seizes rocket cargo intended for Hezbollah

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Damascus

Syrian authorities thwarted an attempted weapons smuggling on its border with Iraq, reportedly heading to the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon, State media said on Thursday.

The truck that was seized was carrying advanced weapons and rockets, Syria's State-run SANA news agency quoted an unnamed Interior Ministry official saying. A preliminary investigation concluded that its intended destination was Hezbollah in Lebanon, which since early March has been at war with Israel, the official said. The new



leadership in Syria, which toppled former President Bashar Assad in 2024, has cracked down on smuggling of weapons and illicit drugs along its borders,

especially with Iraq and Lebanon, that for decades have served as strategic routes for supplying Hezbollah and other groups backed by Iran.

US President Donald Trump has insisted Syria take military action against Hezbollah, as Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa has been trying to prevent his country from

IT SHOT DOWN IRANIAN MISSILES, SAYS JORDAN

Dubai: Jordan's military said Thursday it shot down eight missiles launched by Iran targeting the kingdom. The military made the announcement via the kingdom's state-run Petra news agency. The United States has intensified its strikes targeting Iran, hitting targets further north. American forces also fired into a ship it accused of trying to break its naval blockade on the Islamic Republic. Tehran retaliated

early on Thursday with missile and drone fire also targeting Bahrain and Kuwait before dawn. Days of back-and-forth strikes by the US and Iran across the Middle East, and renewed threats to the Strait of Hormuz, have shredded the interim deal to end the Iran war and the region could tip back into all-out war. Iranian officials say US strikes have already killed more than 35 people and wounded over 300 others. (AP)

being sucked into a wider regional conflict. Hezbollah did not comment on the allegations. Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi earlier this week

travelled to Washington to meet with Trump, who has been pushing Baghdad to disarm Tehran-backed militias. (AP)

Houthi threatens escalation with Saudi

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Cairo

The leader of Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen said Thursday that his group was ready to escalate its conflict with Saudi Arabia, after the two sides exchanged strikes on each other's airports.

In the most significant confrontation since a 2022 truce, Saudi warplanes struck Sanaa International Airport on Sunday. In response, the Houthis launched missiles and drones at Saudi Arabia's Abha International Airport on Monday. There were no casualties reported.

Tensions flared earlier this month when the Houthis accused Saudi Arabia of trying to prevent the return of an Iranian plane carrying a Houthi delegation to Tehran for the funeral of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. The plane was diverted after the Sanaa airport was bombed



and landed safely in the city of Hodeida. Saudi officials did not respond to a request for comment about the airstrikes in Yemen.

Houthi leader Abdul Malik al-Houthi said the group's response to the strike on Sanaa airport was "modest" and that the "real equation would be Sanaa airport for Riyadh airport. The equation is airports for airports, ports for ports, and siege for siege." He also threatened oil facilities in Saudi Arabia.

Pak urges US, Iran to end hostilities, resume talks

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Pakistan on Thursday urged the US and Iran to end hostilities and resume negotiations, as renewed military strikes between the two sides threatened to derail their interim peace arrangement and further destabilise the region.

Addressing the weekly media briefing, Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi acknowledged the challenges facing the interim peace deal. The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), signed last month, had led to the launch of technical-level talks aimed at reaching a permanent peace agreement within 60 days. However, the process stalled after the US and Iran resumed attacks last week. Andrabi said as hostilities



have continued over the past week, "Pakistan reiterates its call on all parties to exercise maximum restraint and refrain from any actions that would further undermine peace and stability". "Pakistan will continue to encourage all sides to end violence and resume technical-level talks in accordance. We hope all parties will remain committed to the path of dialogue and diplomacy in resolving their outstanding issues," he said.

Reiterating Islamabad's position, Andrabi said that there was no alternative to sustained engagement, dialogue, and diplomacy in pursuit of lasting peace, stability, and progress.

The latest round of attacks came after the US expanded its military strikes on Iran, while Tehran responded with missile and drone attacks targeting Bahrain, Jordan and Kuwait, raising fears of a wider regional conflict.

The renewed hostilities have cast uncertainty over the interim agreement reached last month to pave the way for a permanent settlement. Andrabi said all conflicts should be resolved through dialogue. (PTI)

No radiation leak in South Africa nuclear plant, says regulator

GERALD IMRAY
Cape Town

South Africa's nuclear regulator said Thursday that no radioactive material leaked into the environment during three recent "contamination" events inside Africa's only nuclear power station.

The incidents involved "elevated airborne radioactive contamination" inside the Koeberg Power Station, on South Africa's west coast, when there was a loss of power to ventilation units during maintenance work, the National Nuclear



Regulator said, adding there was no danger to the public.

It said the three separate contamination events on June 30, July 2 and July 7 were contained inside the station. Workers inside the

power station who may have been exposed were screened and recorded radioactive contamination below the radioactivity a person is exposed to when they have a dental X-ray, the NNR said.

The regulator said that while it was conducting further inspections the recent events "did not meet the criteria for classification as a nuclear or radiological incident or emergency and did not result in any off-site radiological consequences." The Koeberg

plant is located around 40 km north of South Africa's second biggest city, Cape Town. It is Africa's only commercial nuclear power station and was commissioned in the 1980s during apartheid. It has two reactors which generate around 5 per cent of South Africa's electricity, and is operated by the national electricity company, Eskom.

Its reactors were recently granted 20-year life extensions, clearing them to be operational until after 2040. South Africa has

plans to expend its commercial nuclear capability with new stations to support its unreliable and polluting energy supply, which is struggling to provide for a growing population and heavily based on burning coal.

Other countries are also turning more towards nuclear power to meet skyrocketing energy demands despite long-held safety fears from opponents of nuclear power citing disasters like Chernobyl and, more recently, Fukushima in Japan. (AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform to all concern that Dr. B.B.L. Aggrawal S/o Sh. R.N. Aggrawal R/o A-16, South Extension, Part-II, New Delhi-110049 who is the original allottee of property Residential Plot No. B-151, Sector-36, Noida (U.P.) had sold the said property on General Power of Attorney basis to the following person(s).

General Power of Attorney was executed on Vahi No. 1490, Page 344 to 759, A.D. Book No. 4, Jild 1556, Pages 421/426 dated 08/03/1991 in Sub Registrar Noida in favour of Sh. R.L. Kaul S/o Sh. D.N. Kaul R/o A-24, Sector-30, Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.), which is registered, and the Agreement to Sell also registered. So it is informed to all concern that the said property, Residential Plot No. B-151, Sector-36, Noida (U.P.), is going to be transferred in favour of Mrs. Deepthi Rana W/o Dr. Malay Bajpai R/o C5/265, C-Block, Near Indus Road Sector-31, Noida, P.O.: Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.)-201301.

If anyone has/have any objection, he/she may file his/her objection along with the sufficient proof in the Residential Department of the Society Office/Noida Authority within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Mrs. Deepthi Rana

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Priya Gupta is the owner of the Property No. 44, New no. 28, area measuring 114 Sq. Yds, Situated at Jagdish Nagar (Mukand Nagar), Ghaziabad, Tehsil & District Ghaziabad through Sale Deed dated 06.09.2024 doc. no. 11305 executed by (1) Mrs. Neeru Khurana (2) Mr. Kavya Khurana (3) Mr. Rakshit Khurana (Seller) and Mrs. Mamta Chopra and Mr. Dheeraj Malhotra (Confirming Party) in favour of Mrs. Priya Gupta in respect of Residential old House No. 44, New no. 28-A (29), area measuring 114 Sq. Yds, i.e. 95.315 Sq. Mtrs. Mrs. Priya Gupta is in the process of mortgaging the said plots with KFC Bank Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. (Landline): +91012-04495711, e-mail: accounts@northin

Be it known to all through this Public Notice that our Client Smt. Jagwati W/O Late Sh. Surender Pal R/O Gali No.4, M-Block, Gujar Wali Gali, Vijay Enclave, Thana Dabri, Delhi-110045, deeded their sons & their Daughter in laws namely Deepak, Bharti, Ankit & Deepika, All are resident of Gali No.4, M-Block, Gujar Wali Gali, Vijay Enclave, Thana Dabri, Delhi-110045, from her moveable & immovable property and official perks due to their misconduct, unfamiliar act & cruel activities, after the Publication of this Notice they will have no right & entitlement in our client's moveable & immovable property, her official perks in any manner.

D&K ASSOCIATES ADVOCATES, Mangreet Kaur & Shashi Prakash Dismasse, Ch. No. 38, Western Wing, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054

STATUTORY COMPLIANCE PUBLICATION

The Gurugram Marketing Cooperative Society Ltd., Gurugram (under liquidation), through its duly appointed liquidator under the control of The Assistant Registrar, Cooperative Societies, Gurugram, hereby invites applications for leasing of land measuring approximately 2000 sq. yards "on as is where is basis" comprised in Khewat No. 422/331, Khatoni No. 630, Kharsa No. 7161/1975-1977, situated at Atul Kataria Chowk, Gurugram, adjoining the restricted zone of the Air Force Station. The lease is proposed under Section 89 of The Haryana Cooperative Societies, Act 1984 for a period of 33 years in respect of land at Atul Kataria Chowk, Gurugram, falling within the restricted 900 meter no construction zone adjoining Defense establishments. The expected rent is 2,83,727/- per month, with 5% escalation every three years, payable in advance each two months, together with a security deposit of Rs. 5,00,000/- The property lies in a sensitive belt where permanent construction is prohibited, and use shall remain subject to Defense and Municipal restrictions. Interested parties may submit their applications/objections/offers in writing to the office of The Assistant Registrar, Cooperative Societies, Gurugram within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice.

1. Applications must include,
 2. Full particulars of the applicant,
 3. Proposed terms and offer,
- Supporting documents establishing eligibility. Failure to submit within the stipulated period shall be deemed waiver of rights. and the lease process shall proceed accordingly.

Issued by: Liquidator, The Gurugram Marketing Cooperative Society Ltd., Gurugram
Under control of Assistant Registrar, Cooperative Societies, Civil Lines, Gurugram

CHANGE OF NAME

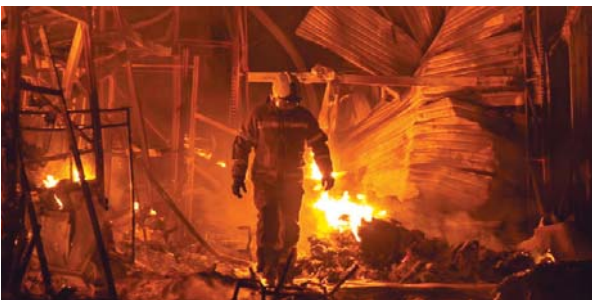
I, Sanjay Saxena S/o Shesh Saxena, R/o Flat No.-1610, SS Benefit Society, Gopindpuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201013 declare that my minor son Naivedhya father and mother name have been wrongly written as Sanjay and Neha in his school record. The actual name of Naivedhya father and mother are Sanjay Saxena and Neha Saxena, which may be amended accordingly.

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Rati Devi who is owner of Plot of land area measuring 221 sq. yds., out of Khewat/Khata No. 650/777, Mu. No. 128, Kila No. 84-101, 97-71, 107-71, Registered as Document No. 3255 in Book No. 1, Volume No. 196/1478, on Pages 109-25/99 to 101, on dated 27.03.2019, SR- Pataudi, District Gurugram, Haryana vide Sale Deed dated 08.01.2020 (vide Document No.3011) at Sub-Registrar, Pataudi, Haryana; and intend to mortgage against the financial assistance from SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd., That Sale Deed executed by Mr. Devendra Kataria in favour of Mrs. Rajbati in respect of Plot of land area measuring 221 sq. yds., out of Khewat/Khata No. 650/777, Mu. 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Protests erupt in Kyiv over Zelenskyy’s Cabinet reshuffle

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Hundreds of protesters gathered in downtown Kyiv on Thursday after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy moved to dismiss his defense minister, as parliament appointed a new prime minister as part of a major Government reshuffle. The shake-up could become a test of Zelenskyy’s political authority as Ukraine’s fight against Russia’s full-scale invasion approaches 4½ years. Ukraine’s parliament approved Serhii Koretskyi, the head of state energy company Naftogaz, as the country’s new prime minister. Zelenskyy nominated Koretskyi, citing his record in



Emergency services personnel work to extinguish a fire following a Russian air attack in Kyiv, Ukraine

the energy sector and arguing that he was best placed to help prepare Ukraine for another wartime winter. He was voted in with 289 votes in favour. Outgoing Defence Minister Mykhailo Fedorov, 35, is considered to be a moderniser

whose technological expertise is credited in part with a significant improvement in Ukraine’s military performance in recent months against Russia’s bigger army. He was expected to leave the Government after just six months in the post.

Zelenskyy didn’t publicly give a reason for Fedorov’s anticipated exit. Unconfirmed Ukrainian media reports said that Fedorov had a strained relationship with Gen. Oleksandr Syrskiy, the commander of Ukraine’s armed forces. Syrskiy, 60, is credited with initially organizing the defense of Kyiv in February 2022, and seven months later masterminded a successful counteroffensive in the Kharkiv region. He was born in 1965 in the Soviet Union and attended Moscow Higher Military Command School before serving in the Soviet Artillery Corps. The mostly young protesters shouted Fedorov’s name and made crude remarks

about Skryskiy. They chanted, “Syrskyy go away!” and “A European army for a European country!” Bohdan Huryak, a Kyiv resident at the protest, said that he was “deeply outraged” by Fedorov’s exit. “I’m not deeply invested in the internal political debates, but this is a person who shows results on the battlefield, we see results, we feel the fighting spirit and confidence in victory rising,” Huryak told The Associated Press. “And then, six months later, he is removed from office? Come on.” Demonstrations were also held in other cities across Ukraine, including Dnipro in the center of the country and the southern port city of

Odesa. Zelenskyy swiftly reversed course in July last year when large street protests broke out over a new law that would have curbed the independence of the country’s anti-corruption watchdogs. The outcry threatened the stability of his leadership for the first time since Russia’s all-out invasion, which began on Feb. 24, 2022. Before he became defense minister last January, Fedorov was the head of Ukraine’s digital transformation policies and seen as a modernizer. He won public popularity by spearheading Ukraine’s speedy development and deployment of drone technology and introducing several successful e-Government platforms.

Six family members killed in house fire in Pakistan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

A massive fire swept through a house in Pakistan’s northwestern Province Khyber Pakhtunkhwa on Thursday, killing a family of six people, including four minors, rescue officials said. The tragic incident occurred in the Tehkal Payan area of Peshawar. According to Rescue 1122, the blaze erupted in a residential house and spread rapidly, trapping the occupants inside. After bringing the fire under control, rescue teams launched a search operation and recovered the bodies of all six people from a room of the house. Officials said the fire apparently started in a section of the house where

furniture, foam materials and other household items were stored, causing the flames and thick smoke to spread quickly throughout the building. Preliminary findings suggest that the victims died from suffocation caused by dense smoke and the intense heat generated by the fire, rescue authorities said. The cause of the fire could not immediately be determined. Authorities have launched an investigation, while forensic experts and other relevant agencies are collecting evidence to establish the exact circumstances behind the incident. Officials identified the deceased as 55-year-old Siraj, his 40-year-old wife, and their four children.

Talks for release of 3 ships held by Somali pirates in advanced stage: Sources

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

Ransom negotiations for the release of three merchant vessels and their 44 crew members held by Somali pirates are at an advanced stage, shipping industry sources with direct knowledge of the talks said on Thursday. The talks involve countries where the vessels are registered, ship owners and insurance companies, and are being conducted confidentially due to concerns over the safety of the crew, the sources here said. They said the talks are being coordinated with insurers that provided cover for the vessels, as any ransom payment has to be vetted to ensure compliance with international sanctions. The identity of the recipient is verified against sanctions lists maintained by the United Nations, the US, the UK and the European Union to avoid legal complications, they said. “Ransoms are paid on humanitarian grounds, but international laws on sanctions should not be flouted,” one of the sources said. The three vessels — oil tankers Honour 25 and Eureka, and cargo ship Sward — comprising 44 crew members, were hijacked in separate incidents between April and May off the coast of Somalia and in the Gulf of Aden, according to recent reports by the International Maritime Organisation. Shipping industry sources said many compa-



nies are avoiding piracy-prone waters and the Strait of Hormuz, resulting in a sharp rise in freight rates and higher remuneration for seafarers willing to transit the region. Separately, a regional maritime security agency highlighted the shipping industry’s concerns over the resurgence of piracy in the Western Indian Ocean. “There have been a series of piracy attacks against merchant vessels and tankers in the Western Indian Ocean since the beginning of the ongoing conflict in the Straits of Hormuz,” said Vijay D Chafekar, executive director of the ReCAAP (Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia) Information Sharing Centre. “On several occasions, onboard security personnel had to open fire to deter approaching skiffs and attempts at unauthorised boarding. In some cases, pirates succeeded in boarding and hijacking. It is understood that at least three vessels are held captive off the Somali coast,” he said. (PTI)

Indian stabbed in US in hate crime: Reports

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

An Indian man was allegedly stabbed 15 times inside a shopping mall near Salt Lake City in the US state of Utah because of his religion, media reports said. Syed Sohailuddin, a worker in the Valley City Mall in West Valley City, Utah, was allegedly stabbed on Monday afternoon by Peter Michael Larsen, who asked the victim his religion, Fox 13 News reported. The suspect, Larsen, was arrested on suspicion of attempted murder and carrying a prohibited dangerous weapon. He told police he targeted the employee over his religious beliefs,



according to the court records, ABC News reported. Sohailuddin was transported to the hospital, where he underwent surgery. Larsen was also hospitalised with injuries suffered after he was punched in the head by those who stepped in to stop the alleged assault. The Consulate General of India in San Francisco said it was deeply saddened by the tragic stabbing incident involving an Indian national in Utah. “The Consulate is in close contact with the friends and family and stands ready to provide all possible consular assistance. We remain engaged with local authorities and will continue to monitor the matter closely,” the Consulate said in a post on X. Larsen told the aw enforcement officials that “he believes he is a catalyst and he intends to kill Muslims.” An affidavit filed by the authorities in court said that releasing Larsen from jail would be dangerous, “based on his violent actions today” and his ideologies. A witness told FOX 13 News that he was inside a nearby store where he worked when he heard shouting and people running away from a scene where the alleged stabbing had taken place. (PTI)

Have taken note of reports: China on India’s bid for non-permanent UNSC seat

KUM VARMA ■ Beijing

China on Thursday said it has “taken note of relevant reports” about India’s bid for a non-permanent seat at the UN Security Council for the 2028-29 period. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar launched India’s official campaign for the non-permanent seat at the UNSC on Monday at an event at the UN headquarters, attended by ambassadors, diplomats and officials. In his address, Jaishankar said that India’s approach to the UN is rooted in ‘SHANTI: Securing Holistic Advancement through Norms, Trust and Integrity’, as he outlined in detail New Delhi’s priorities for the UNSC term. “China has taken note of relevant reports,” Chinese Foreign Ministry



Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian

spokesperson Lin Jian told a media briefing here when asked about China’s view on India’s announcement

to contest for a non-permanent seat at the UNSC. China, one of the five veto-wielding permanent members of the UNSC, has yet to back India’s bid. In comparison, the other four P5 members - the US, UK, Russia and France — have explicitly supported India’s permanent membership in the reformed UN Security Council. Elections for the 2028-29 term will be conducted in June next year, when India and Tajikistan will compete for the sole seat in the Asia-Pacific Group category. India last sat at the UNSC horse-shoe high table in 2021-22, its eighth time in the powerful 15-nation UN body after tenures in 1950-1951, 1967-1968, 1972-1973, 1977-1978, 1984-1985, 1991-1992 and 2011-2012. (PTI)

EU forces Google to share search data, open Android to rival AI companies

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Brussels

The European Union(EU) issued two new rules for Google on Thursday to force it to share search data and open up its Android operating system to rival AI companies. In the latest attempt to rein in tech behemoths’ deep control of the digital economy, the EU said it will support innovation and diversity in the field by enabling fair access to AI features on Android devices and search engines. “Thanks to these measures, we hope to see emerging alternatives to Google Search and Google’s AI services, such as Gemini, and that users in the EU can enjoy



greater choice of services,” Henna Virkkunen, an executive vice president at the European Commission overseeing tech, said. The measure is the latest advancement of Brussels’ growing rules and regulations that have given the 27-nation bloc a global leadership position in checking the power of tech juggernauts or

“gatekeepers” like TikTok, which are largely based in China and the US. Recently, Brussels has pushed through efforts to ensure Google gives access to Gemini AI services to rival AI companies and search engines; forced Apple to add interoperability features to its devices to connect to non-Apple products; and demanded Meta dismantle “key additive features” like infinite scrolling. Kent Walker, president of global affairs for both Google, said the new rules could backfire by removing safeguards that the company had built to protect user privacy like the vetting of third-party AI assistants.

Imran Khan’s party to hold protest rallies across Pak to mark his three years in jail

M ZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

Incarcerated former Pakistan prime minister Imran Khan’s party on Thursday gave a country-wide protest call on August 5 to mark the day their leader completes three years in jail. Khan’s Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party said the protest movement will begin on August 5 and continue till their leader is released. Currently lodged in solitary confinement at the Adiala Jail, Rawalpindi, the 73-year-old international cricketer turned politician was arrested on August 5, 2023 after an Islamabad



trial court found him guilty of corrupt practices in the Tosha Khana (national treasury) case. He has been subsequently arrested and convicted in some cases leading to continued incarceration. “August 5 will mark the completion of three years of the PTI founder’s imprisonment and rallies will be held across the country to mark the occasion,” PTI General Secretary Salman Akram Raja told reporters outside the Adiala Jail. He

also warned the Government to not launch a crackdown against the party workers. “Imran Khan has been kept in solitary confinement for months. No one from his family or lawyers has been allowed to meet him since December last year. He is not given proper medical care nor is he getting justice from the courts. The oppression and injustice in the country must come to an end,” Raja lambasted. Every week, Khan’s sisters, lawyers and some party workers gather outside the Adiala Jail to press the Government to allow the family to meet him. (PTI)

Bangladeshi diplomat appointed head of UN mission in Afghanistan



Rabab Fatima
YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

A senior Bangladeshi diplomat has been appointed as head of the United Nations mission in Afghanistan. Rabab Fatima, the former Ambassador and Permanent Representative of Bangladesh to the United Nations, has been appointed by UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres as his new Special Representative for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA). Fatima, who currently serves as Under-Secretary-General and High Representative for the Least Developed Countries, Landlocked Developing Countries and Small Island Developing States (UN-OHRLS), succeeds Roza Otunbayeva of Kyrgyzstan, the Office of the Spokesperson for the Secretary-General said in a statement on Wednesday. (PTI)

Over 500 feared dead as officials investigate reports of boats capsizing with Rohingya refugees

KRISTEN GELINEAU ■ Sydney

More than 500 people are feared dead after reports that two boats carrying members of Myanmar’s persecuted Rohingya minority have capsized in the Bay of Bengal, officials said on Thursday. According to preliminary information, the two boats left Myanmar’s western state of Rakhine in late June carrying mostly Rohingya passengers, including some who had travelled from refugee camps across the border in Bangladesh, according to a statement from the International Organisation for Migration and the United Nations High Commissioner



for Refugees. One boat, believed to have been carrying around 250 people, lost contact shortly after departure. A second boat, reportedly carrying 280 people, is

believed to have sunk off Myanmar’s Ayeyarwady coast on July 8. “While the incidents and casualty figures have yet to be officially confirmed,

UNHCR and IOM are gravely concerned by the potentially devastating loss of life,” the agencies said. The Rohingya, who have in recent years fled both

Myanmar and Bangladesh’s squalid refugee camps by the thousands, typically avoid such boat journeys at this time of year, when monsoons are frequent and conditions at sea are particularly dangerous. The UNHCR and IOM noted this in their statement, saying that recent torrential rain and flooding across the region would have made such journeys especially risky. Around 1.2 million stateless, predominantly Muslim Rohingya remain trapped in overcrowded refugee camps in Bangladesh after fleeing waves of violence by Myanmar’s security forces. The refugees have no way to safely return to Myanmar,

where the military that killed thousands of Rohingya in 2017 during what the United States declared a genocide remains in charge of their homeland. The Rohingya still living in Myanmar face severe restrictions and many are confined to internment camps. Steep cuts to foreign aid by the US and other countries have led to ration cuts in Bangladesh’s refugee camps, while the ruling military and an ethnic armed organisation in Rakhine have fought for control of the region. The unrest has led to an increasing number of Rohingya attempting to make the dangerous ocean crossing to Malaysia on

rickety boats. Thousands have died in the process, including babies, children and pregnant women. Local maritime authorities have frequently abandoned the Rohingya at sea, often ignoring reports of boats in distress. The IOM and UNHCR said on Thursday that the latest potential tragedy at sea underscores the continued lack of sustainable solutions for the Rohingya, and urged the international community to support those trapped in Bangladesh’s camps. “Stronger regional and international efforts are needed to prevent further loss of life along one of the world’s deadliest maritime routes,” the agencies said. (AP)

PROSPECT

Indian Army spreads smiles for specially-abled children

The Red Shield Gunners under the aegis of Spear Corps organised an educational and recreational visit to the Golden Pagoda, located at Namsai in Arunachal Pradesh, on 16 July 2026 for 15 specially abled children and eight staff members from Navarupantar Children Home, Rupai. The Golden Pagoda, one of Northeast India's prominent Buddhist landmarks, is renowned for its peaceful surroundings, striking golden architecture and cultural significance. The initiative aimed to provide the children with a memorable experience beyond their daily routine while promoting learning, inclusion and social interaction. During the visit, the children toured the magnificent Golden Pagoda complex, admired its unique architecture and learnt about its history, Buddhist traditions and the values of peace, compassion and harmony associated with the shrine. They spent time exploring the beautifully landscaped Pagoda, interacted enthusiastically with Indian Army personnel, participated in informal recreational activities, clicked photographs and enjoyed the tranquil surroundings. The visit offered a refreshing and enriching experience, encouraging curiosity, confidence and joyful learning. The Indian Army ensured the comfort, safety and well-being of all participants throughout the visit. The initiative fostered confidence, strengthened social bonds and created lasting memories for the children, reflecting the Army's unwavering commitment to the welfare and holistic development of specially abled children. Such community outreach initiatives reaffirm the Indian Army's dedication to inclusive development and its continued efforts to strengthen bond with local community. (PNS)



Army, Youth club celebrates World Youth Skills Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Shi-Yomi District, Arunachal Pradesh

To commemorate World Youth Skills Day 2026, Spearhead Division of Spearcorps in association with the Youth Club of Menchuka, organised a Marathon and an interactive motivational programme for the youth and students of Menchuka. The initiative reflected the shared commitment of the Indian Army and the local community towards empowering youth through fitness, education and skill development.

The marathon witnessed enthusiastic participation from nearly 200 boys, girls and local residents alongside Indian Army personnel. The event was graced by the Additional Deputy Commissioner (ADC),



Menchuka Tana Yaho, Army officers and two distinguished sporting personalities from Arunachal Pradesh who served as Race Ambassadors—Jyoti Mane, the first athlete from the State to win a medal at the National Games, and Tajum Dere, the first cyclist from Arunachal Pradesh to qualify for the National Games 2025. Cash prizes of ₹15,000, ₹10,000 and ₹5,000 were awarded to the winners securing the first, second and third positions respectively in both the boys' and girls' categories.

Teja Singh Samundri: The forgotten nation builder

YUVRAJ MALIK

A hundred years ago today, on July 17, 1926, Sardar Teja Singh Samundri, a social leader, reformer and visionary, breathed his last in Lahore Central Jail at the age of 44, succumbing to the harsh repression of the British Raj. While his untimely death marked the loss of an extraordinary leader, his life's work left behind a legacy that continues to shape India's history and inspire generations.

As discussions about the broader narrative of Indian nationalism regain prominence, there is renewed value in revisiting Samundri's remarkable journey. The only individual outside the Sikh Gurus to have a building within the sacred Golden Temple complex named in his honour, he occupies a singular place in Sikh history.

Foremost was his leadership of the Gurdwara Reform Movement (GRM), which reclaimed Sikh religious institutions and restored them to the egalitarian and democratic ideals envisioned by the Sikh Gurus. Equally significant was his ability to weave the cause of religious reform into the larger struggle for India's independence, inspiring an entire generation of leaders, including the iconic Master Tara Singh. Despite having only limited formal education, Samundri remained a passionate advocate of learning and worked tirelessly to promote educational advancement within the community. Throughout his public life, Samundri placed

the interests of his faith and nation above personal gain. He sacrificed his livelihood, pledged his property, and ultimately gave his life in unwavering commitment to principles he believed.

Until the early twentieth century, Sikh gurdwaras were administered by colonial-appointed nominees. Many later claimed hereditary control over shrines and their wealthy endowments. Backed by British authorities, several abandoned Sikh ideals of humility and service, instead treating gurdwaras as personal estates for privilege and material gain.

It was against this backdrop that the Sikh community launched the Gurdwara Reform Movement (GRM), a mass campaign inspired by the teachings of Gurbani as enshrined in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji. Standing in opposition were the British-backed nominees and a section of the Sikh aristocracy that chose to align itself with the colonial administration. Amid this defining struggle, Teja Singh Samundri emerged as one of the movement's most steadfast and influential leaders.

Born into a Sandhu Jat Sikh family in Rai Burj Ka (Sarhali) village of present-day Tarn Taran district, Samundri inherited not only a strong religious tradition but also a deep sense of public duty. His family owned agricultural land in Samundri Tehsil of Lyallpur district in undivided Punjab, from which the family adopted its surname. Like his father, Sardar Dewa Singh, and



Sardar Teja Singh Samundri

many of his forefathers, Samundri initially served in the British Indian Army. However, his profound faith and commitment to Sikh ideals soon drew him towards the Gurdwara Reform Movement, whose earliest spark had been lit at Gurdwara Rakab Ganj in Delhi. The demolition of Gurdwara Rakab Ganj's boundary wall in 1911 by British to built New Delhi sparked Sikh protests led by Samundri, forcing the British to restore it. The victory inspired the Gurdwara Reform Movement, where Samundri emerged as a key organiser, mobilising volunteers and strengthening its institutional foundation.

Samundri's leadership was defined not merely by words but by personal sacrifice. During the Nankana Sahib agitation of 1921, following the massacre of unarmed protesters on the orders of the local mahant, the Akali newspaper published reports that shook the colonial administration. The British imposed a punitive fine of ₹40,000

on the publication. Without hesitation, Samundri assured its publishers that he would personally stand guarantee for the amount, even if it meant auctioning his own agricultural lands.

Samundri supported families of imprisoned volunteers by founding the Sikh Desh Bhagat Parivar Sahaik Committee. Beyond leading protests, he emerged as the movement's chief organiser and institution-builder. His selection among the Panj Pyare for the 1923 Harmandir Sahib karsewa reflected the Sikh community's highest recognition of his service.

Samundri viewed Sikh religious reforms and India's freedom movement as interconnected. His participation in the 1923 Indian National Congress Subjects Committee reflected his commitment to justice, Swaraj, and national unity.

Alarmed by the growing strength of the Gurdwara Reform Movement, the British government arrested several of its foremost leaders, including Samundri. Yet imprisonment could not derail the movement. Its sustained and disciplined campaign ultimately compelled the colonial administration to enact the Sikh Gurdwaras Act of 1925, transferring the management of Sikh shrines to the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC). The government, however, attached a condition to this concession: before being released, the imprisoned leaders were required to provide a written undertaking that they would neither resume agi-

tation nor challenge any provision of the new legislation.

The demand divided the 31 senior Akali leaders imprisoned at the time. A majority agreed to accept the government's terms in exchange for their release. However, eleven leaders, among them Teja Singh Samundri and Master Tara Singh, refused to compromise.

It was during this continued imprisonment in Lahore that tragedy struck. On July 17, 1926, Teja Singh Samundri died in jail under circumstances that have never been satisfactorily explained, at the age of 44. His death transformed him from a movement leader into a movement himself.

His legacy was carried forward not only through the institutions he founded but also through the achievements of his family. His son, Bishan Singh Samundri, after receiving higher education from USA and after returning to India, has served as Principal of Khalsa College, Amritsar, before becoming the founding Vice-Chancellor of Guru Nanak Dev University. Whereas his grandson Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu has served the country in various capacities ranging from an efficient diplomat to the present Lieutenant Governor of Delhi.

A century after his death, Teja Singh Samundri remains a symbol of principled leadership, courage, and selfless service.

The Writer is the Director of National Book Trust, New Delhi and CEO of New Delhi World Book Fair

UPSIDA undertakes projects worth over ₹115 crore in Sandila Industrial Area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh State Industrial Development Authority (UPSIDA) is implementing various development projects worth over ₹115 crore in the Sandila Industrial Area of Hardoi district. These initiatives aim to strengthen, modernise, and make the industrial infrastructure more investor-friendly. Under the able leadership and guidance of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, UPSIDA is continuously expanding and upgrading industrial infrastructure to achieve the goal of making UP a \$1 trillion economy.

As part of this initiative to develop the Sandila Industrial Area into a world-class industrial hub, works worth approximately ₹6 crore have already been completed.



These include annual maintenance of the industrial area; desilting of the Raso, Jaraha, Loni, and master drains; construction of a 12-meter-wide RCC box culvert; development of truck lay-bys for heavy vehicles; and culvert construction on the internal road of Phase-1. Additionally, beautification of the entrance road and field hostel premises, resurfacing of Road No. 1, and installation of modern signboards and guide maps have been completed.

Currently, several key projects worth over ₹10 crore are being executed at a rapid pace. These include construction of the main entrance

gate; development of primary drainage systems in Phases 1, 2, 3, and 4; upgradation of various roads through CC pavement; installation of overhead retro-reflective signage; construction of retaining walls; maintenance of old culverts; strengthening of the road network across different phases; and development of an external drainage system in Phase-4. Upon completion, these projects will significantly improve connectivity, traffic management, and drainage systems within the industrial area. Enhanced infrastructure will also boost production capacity and operational efficiency for industries, while creating a more conducive environment for investors. UPSIDA aims to accelerate industrial development by providing high-quality infrastructure in every industrial area across state.

Haryana IFS Officer selected as UNESCO World Heritage reviewer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Dr Vivek Saxena, the senior-most Indian Forest Service officer of the Haryana cadre from the 1991 batch and a regular contributor of the pioneer, has been selected by the International Union for Conservation of Nature as a desk reviewer for UNESCO World Heritage nominations for the 2027 World Heritage Committee session. The recognition that comes as he prepares to retire on July 31, 2026, after a 34-year career with Haryana Forest Department.

IUCN is the official Advisory Body for natural heritage under UNESCO's World Heritage Convention and provides technical and scientific advice to the World Heritage Committee on nominations for natural and mixed heritage properties across the world.



Dr Vivek Saxena

Reviewers are selected on the basis of scientific expertise, professional standing, and sound judgement on the global importance and ecological integrity of nominated sites. Saxena is active member of three IUCN commissions: Species Survival Commission, Commission on Environmental Law, and Commission on Ecosystem Management.

He served as India's United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification National Coordinator and India's Scientific Correspondent between 2007 and 2012, during which period he chaired the

Asia-Pacific Group at UNCCD COP10 held in Changwon, South Korea, in 2011. Saxena was a Lead Author of the Intergovernmental Science-Policy Platform on Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services Global Assessment of Land Degradation and Restoration in 2018, described as authoritative intergovernmental science-policy assessment on ecosystem degradation. He was also shortlisted for an interview for position of Executive Secretary of United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification, a recognition independently accorded by a United Nations Selection Committee. Saxena will evaluate nominations submitted for consideration at 2027 World Heritage Committee session, assessing claims made by nominating countries about integrity, authenticity of sites proposed for World Heritage status.

DAILY SUDOKU

1		8	2			4		
9				7		2	8	
			3	8			7	
						6		7
6			8		4			2
5		2						
	4			3	8			
	2	9		4				1
		1			2	7		4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (16.7.26)								
9	4	6	7	3	5	1	8	2
7	3	2	1	6	8	9	4	5
1	5	8	9	2	4	3	7	6
8	6	3	2	5	7	4	1	9
4	2	7	6	9	1	5	3	8
5	9	1	4	8	3	6	2	7
6	8	4	3	7	9	2	5	1
3	7	9	5	1	2	8	6	4
2	1	5	8	4	6	7	9	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD FRIDAY | JULY 17, 2026

1			2		3		4			5		6		7
8			9							10				
	11				12									
13					14					15			16	
				18						19				
20		21												
										23				
22														
26	27									29				30
31										32				33
36														

ACROSS

- Raise one amid many (5)
- Rose and dressed (3,2)
- Should be a bit of a rough time (5)
- He may well be suspended (3)
- One heartens a poet to become an inventor (5)
- Move coal out of a mine to somewhere important (7)
- Terry may describe it (5)
- Retiring to copy a piece of poetry out (3)
- This villain is angry, on the quiet! (6)
- Immediately present, but without a place (7)

DOWN

- Not yet having taken a knock (2,3)
- If you polish up a dud coin, it's the point of no return! (7)
- Where to egg on the Surrey team (4)
- The kind, that is, for outgoing soldiers (6)
- Historic tour roaming around the capital of Denmark (5)
- These may be used to make paper (5)
- To finish up best (3)
- You've had it, man! (7)
- Pull a shirt tail with a loud cry (3)
- Woolly headed friend, nominally? (5)
- At extremities, money one doesn't borrow! (5)
- Leaps and capers wildly around a pole

- Do evening work at the laundry (4)
- Make steady progress with an old composition for piano (4)
- Properly suited to audio use? (7)
- Boxed up and carted around (6)
- A sound line from the prompter (3)
- Hellish exclamation by little Desmond (5)
- Carries around for sale (on a bike?) (7)
- Capital place to get plastered? (5)
- Augustinian's familiar name (3)
- Figures out points of material significance (5)
- Some doctors consume it (5)
- The look of an old Indian Army man? (5)

- The dog breeder's complaint? (5)
- Person of no fixed address (5)
- Left with uncle, as promised (7)
- For me, wild seas can have magic significance (6)
- It's no good turning up another time (3)
- Can you win them if you have the right cards? (5)
- Warm as the water when the tide changes around Peterhead (5)
- With which to start brushing some scattered leaves? (5)
- Sort of gin with which to fix a cocktail! (3)
- Courtly lord (3)

135th IndianOil Durand Cup Trophy Tour reaches Guwahati

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Trophy Tour of the 135th IndianOil Durand Cup arrived in Guwahati on Thursday, with the city hosting the Trophy Display, Tour and Press Conference at Hotel Vivanta ahead of the tournament's fifth consecutive edition in Assam.

The event was graced by Biswajit Daimary, Minister for Sports and Youth Welfare, Government of Assam; Kausar Jamil Hilaly IAS (Retd.), Special Secretary, Sports and Youth Welfare Department; Maj Gen Dinesh Kumar Singh, SM, VSM, GOC, Bengal Sub Area and Vice Chairman, Durand Cup Organising Committee; Maj Gen Amit Dhir, VSM, Chief of Staff, Gajraj Corps; Brig Anupam Sharma, Commander, Invictus Brigade; Ankur Bhalari, ACS, Director, Sports & Youth Welfare Department, Government of Assam; and Parthib Gogoi, forward of defending champions NorthEast United FC.

Addressing the gathering, Biswajit Daimary reiterated Assam's commitment to strengthening football at the grassroots while highlighting the significance of hosting the prestigious tournament. "Football is deeply rooted in Assam's sporting culture, and hosting the Durand Cup is both a matter of pride and an opportunity to inspire the next generation. We must move beyond simply identifying talent to creating it through structured grassroots development, quality infrastructure and sustained institutional commitment. Along with world-class stadiums, we need playgrounds and competitive opportunities that allow children to develop from an early age. If we continue to invest in our youth and work together with organisations like the Indian Army, I am confident that India can emerge as a stronger footballing nation."

Speaking on the occasion, Maj Gen Dinesh Kumar Singh, SM, VSM, said "The Durand Cup is not just about competition; it is about inspiring young footballers across the North-East and strengthening India's football ecosystem. Together with the Government of Assam and our partners, we remain committed to taking the game to every aspiring player, creating opportunities for local talent and nurturing the dream of seeing India compete on football's biggest stage." Representing defending champions NorthEast United FC, Parthib



Gogoi reflected on the club's journey and looked ahead to another campaign. "Winning the Durand Cup taught us that success comes through resilience, hard work and belief. As defending champions, we know every season begins from zero, and we're excited to return to Guwahati, where the incredible support of our fans gives us the strength to keep striving for greater success." Following the ceremony, the iconic Durand Cup, President's Cup and Simla Trophy embarked on a two-day tour across Guwahati, visiting prominent landmarks including the Assam Legislative Assembly, Bir Lachit Borphukan Statue, IIT Guwahati and City Centre Mall, allowing football enthusiasts to witness the three historic trophies up close ahead of tournament.

Maj Gen Amit Dhir, VSM, Chief of Staff, Gajraj Corps, underlined the enduring legacy of the tournament and its impact on Indian football, "For more than 135 years, the Durand Cup has represented excellence in Indian football. Its continued success reflects the strong partnership between the Armed Forces, the Government of Assam and the football community, while providing young players with a national platform to pursue their dreams and showcase their talent." Assam continues to play a pivotal role in the Durand Cup's modern journey, hosting the tournament since 2023. Guwahati will stage six Group F matches in this year's edition featuring NorthEast United FC, Karbi Anglong Morning Star FC, Bodoland FC and FC 1, with three clubs from the state underlining Assam's growing contribution to Indian football.

The 135th IndianOil Durand Cup will be played from July 25 to August 23, 2026, across five cities — Kolkata, Shillong, Imphal, Guwahati and Ranchi, with the Jharkhand capital making its debut as a host venue.

Doorvery achieves ₹51.12 Cr ARR in first quarter of 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Doorvery, an emerging B2B grocery delivery platform on Wednesday announced impressive growth milestones in first quarter of 2026-27. The revenue growth was 30-40% month on month with profitability from day one, Doorvery continues to redefine B2B grocery procurement sector. **Highlights:** Profitable from day one of operations. Serving a diverse client base including retailers, wholesalers, hotels, and restaurants. G Surya Nayayan Patro, Director of Doorvery, said, "Crossing ₹51.12 Crore ARR within the first quarter of 2026 reflects the trust our customers have placed in us and the dedication of our team to building a sustainable busi-



G Surya Nayayan Patro

ness. While rapid growth is encouraging, our focus remains on creating long-term value through operational excellence, technology-led innovation, and customer-centric solutions. We believe the B2B grocery sector is entering a new phase of digital transformation, and Doorvery is well-positioned to lead this evolution by delivering smarter, faster, and more reliable procurement experiences for businesses across India."

BRIEFLY

Rumbunctious crowd makes Argentina feel at home



Argentina fans are well known for their rabid, boisterous support of their national soccer squad, and that fevered passion made their beloved team feel right at home in Atlanta at the World Cup.

This wasn't Buenos Aires, but the rumbunctious pro-Argentina crowd made their voices heard: Serenading the team with songs, chants and screaming at the top of their lungs throughout Wednesday's semifinal match.

And when Enzo Fernandez scored the equalising goal for Argentina off an assist from Lionel Messi in the 85th minute, water splashed from the top floor to the bottom at Mercedes-Benz Stadium.

Cups and water bottles followed. Shirts were removed and swung in the air. Long after Lautaro Martinez scored the winning goal in the 2-1 victory over England, Argentina fans cheered as if it had transpired only seconds earlier.

Messi, Fernandez and others paraded around the field with their shirts off, soaking in the atmosphere as fans cheered the players on — none of them wanting the moment to end.

"No words, no words. A joy for our country, for our people," Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said. "We are unique, truly, and it's not arrogance, it's from the heart. We are unique. These people today carried us to win the match, so I'm grateful."

(AP)

Easy to say that it was wrong, says English Coach Tuchel



England desperately wanted to protect its lead as time was winding down in its World Cup semifinal against Argentina. Coach Thomas Tuchel made lineup and strategy changes to build a wall in front of the goal. Argentina and Lionel Messi simply kicked it down. England led 1-0 late in the second half before Messi assisted on goals by Enzo Fernandez in the 85th minute and Lautaro Martinez in the second minute of stoppage time to give Argentina a wild 2-1 victory Wednesday and a spot in the World Cup final against Spain.

Tuchel's tactical choices in one of the biggest matchups in one of soccer's biggest rivalries will likely be scrutinised and criticised for years. England missed its chance to return to the World Cup final for the first time since 1966.

"They won every header. They kept crossing and crossing. So we went to a back five to close the gaps inside and be stronger in the air," Tuchel said.

"Straight after our goal, with no substitutions, we just conceded way too many crosses and way too many chances. So we tried to help," Tuchel said. "But of course the responsibility is on the coach. And if it doesn't go well, it's easy to say that it was wrong."

Tuchel's chess moves couldn't contain Messi, the maestro of Argentina's attacks. In the 38 minutes between England's goal and Argentina's winner, Argentina held a whopping 88 per cent of the possession, according to Opta.

It was only the second time this century that a team scored first in a World Cup semifinal and failed to reach the final, according to Opta. The other blown lead was also by England, in 2018 against Croatia.

(AP)

Tens of thousands of Argentine fans celebrate victory

ISABEL DEBRE
■ Buenos Aires (Argentina)

Tens of thousands of soccer fans flooded the streets of Argentina's capital on Wednesday evening in a collective eruption of ecstasy over their national team's 2-1 victory over England to reach the World Cup final.

Some screamed, others cried — and the most frenzied sprinted shirtless in pouring winter rain through the streets of Buenos Aires, their bodies painted in blue and white national colors. Young men and women scaled lamp posts and traffic lights, waving Argentine flags. Many sobbed, completely overwhelmed by the moment.

The celebrations — likely to last long into the night — followed Lautaro Martinez's winning goal two minutes into injury time in the game in Atlanta. Defending champions Argentina will now play Spain in the World Cup final on Sunday.

"Look around at all these strangers, jumping and dancing



together," said Rosana Beto Cruz, a 48-year-old Catholic nun caught in the sea of Argentine fans streaming toward the Obelisk, the city's soaring downtown monument, chanting songs, blaring car horns and setting off fireworks.

"The World Cup, our national team, it makes this happen," she added.

Argentina now seeks another trophy: The public joy, many fans said, wasn't so much about advancing to the finals or defending the title they won four years ago in Qatar as it was about crushing their nation's historical adversary.

Wednesday's semifinal was the latest chapter in a long-running feud that has transcended the pitch to

encompass British control over the disputed Falkland Islands, which Argentina calls the Malvinas and claims as its sovereign territory.

"This is not just about football, it's about beating the country that broke our hearts," Maria Bertero, 40, said, referring to the disastrous 10-week war in 1982. "My heart still aches for all the young boys who

Defending champion Argentina reaches World Cup final



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Atlanta

No "Hand of God" this time. Argentina didn't need it.

Instead it was the hallowed feet of Lionel Messi and the unbreakable spirit of a team that has repeatedly fought back at this year's World Cup that is now one step away from back-to-back titles.

Trailing 1-0 going into the 85th minute, Argentina rallied for a 2-1 victory over England on Wednesday with goals from Enzo Fernandez and substitute Lautaro Martinez.

"I dreamed it, I swear. I told Alexis (Mac Allister) that I was going to score. I told him that I was going to come on and I was going to win it," Martinez said. "I can tell you this team keeps showing what it's made of."

At the final whistle, Messi fell to his knees in celebration while England players collapsed in disbelief — again.

Add 2026 to 1986 and 1998 on the list of games when Argentina has extinguished English hopes at the World Cup.

"I'm gutted for the team,



the staff, the fans," England captain Harry Kane said. "We worked so hard to be here. The lads have given every bit of blood, sweat and tears. To fall short like we did is just gutting."

The defending champions will take on European champion Spain in the final on Sunday in East Rutherford, New Jersey. The best that South America has to offer against the best of Europe.

The loss for England will hurt a new generation of fans in a similar way to Diego Maradona's infamous handball goal in the 1986 World Cup quarter-

finals and the penalty shootout loss in 1998 when David Beckham was sent off for kicking Diego Simeone.

The difference is there can be no sense of injustice this time, even if England had victory in its sights after Anthony Gordon scored the opening goal in the 55th minute.

The English were hanging on as the game wore on. England goalkeeper Jordan Pickford made vital saves while Mac Allister sent a header off the post as wave after wave of Argentina attacks came.

Messi had largely been kept quiet.

WC final is set, with Argentina facing Spain for the title

TIM REYNOLDSAP ■ New York

The best offense. The best defense.

The World Cup final is set, and fittingly, a clash of styles awaits. Lionel Messi — the most prolific goal scorer in the tournament's history — and defending champion Argentina will take on Spain's defensive juggernaut on Sunday in East Rutherford, New Jersey.

Spain beat France in one semifinal on Tuesday; Argentina, the comeback king of this tournament, rallied to beat England 2-1 in the other semifinal on Wednesday.

Argentina is seeking its fourth title and is looking to become the first back-to-back World Cup champion since Brazil pulled off the feat in 1958 and 1962. Spain is looking for its second title, after winning in 2010.

Argentina leads the tournament in goals scored — 19.

Spain leads the tournament in fewest goals allowed — one.

Something will have to



give on Sunday, when the biggest World Cup ever — a 48-team, 104-match extravaganza spread out over the US, Canada and Mexico — comes to an end. It's not Finalissima. It's going to be better.

South American champion Argentina and European champion Spain were supposed to meet in Doha, Qatar, in late March in Finalissima, a showdown between the teams led by Messi and Lamine Yamal in a

prequel of the World Cup. That game never happened. Security became an issue because of unrest in the Middle East, with Iran intensifying its attacks on neighboring countries at that time in retaliation to the aerial attacks by United States and Israel in a war that is still ongoing. The game was called off.

So, instead of playing at Lusail Stadium, the site of the epic 2022 World Cup final where Messi and Argentina won on penalty kicks over France and Kylian Mbappe, they'll play just outside of New York in soccer's biggest game.

(AP)

Late-game heroics by Messi and Argentina



TIM REYNOLDSAP ■ Atlanta

In this World Cup, Lionel Messi and Argentina have owned the final minutes.

Wednesday's rally past England in the World Cup semifinals — Argentina trailed 1-0 late before winning 2-1 — only added another entry on the long list of late-game dramas by the defending champions, who will now play Spain in Sunday's final. **Among them:** A pair of rallies from late-game deficits in the knockout stage, coming back from 2-0 down to beat Egypt and then 1-0 down to beat England.

A breakdown of Argentina saving its best for last in this World Cup:

June 22: Messi to seal a group stage win: Minute: 90+5

Final: Argentina 2, Austria 0 In the second match of the group stage, the outcome wasn't necessarily in doubt. Argentina led 1-0 in second-half stoppage time, when Lionel Messi got his own rebound and threaded a blast between three defenders for an insurance goal that sealed the victory.

June 27: Messi comes through late once again: Minute: 80th

Final: Argentina 3, Jordan 1 Argentina led 2-1 in the group finale, and Lionel Messi — who had just entered the game as a sub — had a free kick from about 25 yards out. He saw a gap in the wall of Jordan defenders, sending a low shot that skipped once and went into the back of the net for the clincher.

July 3: Martinez and an own

goal vs. Cape Verde: Minute: 92nd, then 111th

Final: Argentina 3, Cape Verde 2

The first match of the knockout stage was wild, with Argentina getting two extra-time goals and needing both to hold off the Cinderella story that was Cape Verde. Lisandro Martinez scored in the 92nd minute for a 2-1 lead, and Messi served up a perfect ball off a corner kick that became an own goal in the 111th minute — the one that gave Argentina a 3-2 win.

July 7: The three-goal rally vs Egypt:

Minute: 79th, 83rd, then 90+2

Final: Argentina 3, Egypt 2

The champions looked done in the round of 16, with Egypt up 2-0 with 11 minutes left before second-half stoppage time. And then the comeback of the tournament happened, with Cristian Romero scoring in the 79th minute, Messi connecting four minutes later and Enzo Fernandez getting the game-winner two minutes into stoppage time.

July 11: A pair of late goals to beat Switzerland: Minute: 112th, then 120+1

Final: Argentina 3, Switzerland 1

Switzerland was down to 10 men, but sent its quarterfinal with Argentina to extra time anyway. And eventually, Argentina got the breakthrough: Julian Alvarez scored the go-ahead goal in the 112th minute, then Lautaro Martinez scored in the final moments as the champions moved into the semifinals with a 3-1 victory.

(AP)

Cheteshwar Pujara bats for more sporting tracks in India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former cricketer Cheteshwar Pujara has called for more bowler-friendly pitches in India as he believes playing on flat decks at home is adversely impacting the Indian batters' ability to adapt to seaming conditions in countries like England.

Indian batters struggled against bounce and movement, losing a T20I series to England 0-4 after being whitewashed 0-2 by lower-ranked Ireland in Belfast. The Indian batters were not lacking in form, having landed in the UK after an IPL season dominated by high-scoring matches, but struggled to adapt to a change of conditions.

Pujara believes it can be avoided by simply ensuring a better balance between bat and ball in the pitches on offer here.

"Even in the IPL, you don't want matches where teams can easily chase 260. There has to be something for the bowlers,"



Pujara said on 'JioStar'. "In T20 cricket, the margin for error is already very small, especially on flat pitches with short boundaries, while batters continue to get stronger and more innovative.

"That's why it's important to have pitches that offer bowlers a little assistance, whether through some turn or a bit of movement in the first two or three overs."

Pujara also pointed out that

the Indian T20 batting group has very little white-ball experience in English conditions despite their IPL exploits.



Changes to WC formats make sense but associate teams need more: Ashwin



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian spin great R Ashwin on Thursday said the structural changes made to the ODI and T20 World Cup formats to include more teams make sense but for the game to become truly global, the ICC needs to add the lower rung sides into every bilateral series.

Following the revamp announced by the ICC on Wednesday, the 2027 ODI World Cup will be a three-stage competition and the 2028 T20 World Cup's Super 8 phase will be expanded to accommodate 10 teams to achieve "greater context and consequence".

Ashwin said the world body is planning in the right direction but needs to do more.

"The ICC's changes to the fixture format for the 2027 ODI World Cup and 2028 T20 World Cup make sense from a competitiveness standpoint. But if the final goal is to grow the game, there needs to be a stronger pathway for emerging nations," Ashwin posted on 'X'.

"Teams like the Netherlands, Scotland, Nepal, USA and Ireland need more meaningful matches (FOR EXAMPLE: getting added as the third team into every bilateral series), not just qualification tournaments.

"Let's not forget, that collective growth will make this sport a spectacle at the Olympics," he added.

His views align with the demand for more meaningful games by teams like Nepal and Scotland who showed spark in the T20 World Cup earlier this year.

The 2027 ODI World Cup in South Africa will feature 14 teams as planned before, up from the 10 in the previous edition, but the governing body has added a Super Series round prior to the 'Group round' and a Super 7 stage before the semifinals in its bid to spice up the competition.

The teams that would qualify 12th to 14th for the tournament will play the Super Series round and the top finisher will progress to round two of the competition that will see six teams divided into two groups.

Sindhu stuns Han Ye to enter Japan Open quarterfinals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tokyo

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu produced one of her best performances of the season to outclass world Number 5 Han Yue of China in straight games and storm into the quarterfinals of the Japan Open Super 750 badminton tournament on Thursday.

The world Number 10 Indian needed just 35 minutes to register a commanding 21-16, 21-14 win over the higher-ranked Chinese shuttler in their second-round contest.

After a sluggish start, the unseeded Sindhu found her rhythm midway through the opening game, striking the shuttle cleanly and dictating the rallies to take the lead.

The former world champion then completely dominated the second game, racing to an 8-0 advantage before comfortably sealing the



contest. With the victory, Sindhu improved her head-to-head record against Han to 8-1. The 31-year-old will next face familiar rival Nozomi Okuhara of Japan, who received a walkover after top seed An Se-young of

South Korea withdrew from their second-round match.

Sindhu is now India's lone survivor in the tournament after the mixed doubles pair of Tanisha Crasto and Dhruv Kapila bowed out in the pre-quarterfinals.

Brar handed warning, demerit point for breaching ICC Code of Conduct

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

India pacer Gurnoor Brar has been handed a warning and a demerit point for throwing the ball in an "inappropriate and dangerous" manner during the first ODI against England in Birmingham.

Gurnoor Brar was found guilty of breaching Article 2.9 of the ICC Code of Conduct for Players and Player Support Personnel, which is a Level 1 offence.

"In addition to this, one

demerit point has been added to Brar's disciplinary record, for whom it was a first offence in a 24-month period," an ICC statement read.

The incident occurred in the eighth over of England's innings, when Brar picked up the ball while fielding and threw it towards the batter in an "inappropriate and dangerous manner."

India won the match by six wickets to take a 1-0 lead in the three-match series.

Brar admitted the offence and accepted the sanction proposed by match referee, Richie Richardson of the Emirates ICC Elite Panel of Match Referees and, as such, there was no need for a formal hearing.

British open distance debate shifts to ground roll

DOUG FERGUSONAP
■ Southport (England)

How far the golf ball goes has been debated for the last 20 years and distance is likely to be a big concern this week at Royal Birkdale for the British Open, with one twist.

It's not how far shots are going in the air. It's what happens when they get on the ground. And with links golf, that's not always easy to control, especially this week.

"You can't judge every single bounce perfectly," Justin Rose said. "But you have to accept the nature of a links golf course. There's going to be some good bounces, bad bounces. Just keep playing with a big of freedom and creativity, especially this



week. "You're going to get a few funny bounces here or there," he said. "That's all part of it."

The 154th Open begins Thursday with a mixture of excitement and curiosity. For those who love links golf, there's no greater colors than brown and yellow that indicate crispy conditions in which the fairways can run faster than some of the greens. Rarely has the forecast been filled with warm sunshine — slightly cooler on the weekend — with a cloudless sky that will be a challenge to keep the turf from getting too fast.

Rory McIlroy came to Royal Birkdale a few weeks ago and saw what seemed to be a different course. It was greener. The rough was more lush. It's no longer like that. (AP)

British Open trying to get ahead of fan behaviour with published conduct code

STEVE DOUGLAS/
DOUG FERGUSONAP
■ Southport (England)

More than 300,000 fans will attend the British Open at Royal Birkdale this week, making it a record crowd for golf's oldest major championship. They'll need to bring sun cream and some manners.

For the first time, the R&A has felt it necessary to publish a fan code of conduct, at a time when some of golf's biggest events have been marred by unsavory and even abusive behavior by spectators.

Titled "The Open Commitment," the code boils down to these five basic requirements of fans: respect the players, respect



the links, respect each other, be aware, enjoy responsibly.

Essentially, just be a nice person. If not, the R&A says it can punish "serious or repeated breaches" by removing the guilty parties from the property "without

refund." "I'm all for an atmosphere," said Matt Fitzpatrick, one of the 21 English players in the field who are most likely to be cheered rather than heckled. "Obviously I don't want it to cross a line." (AP)

WC glory needs collective effort: Sardar

HIMANK NEGI
■ New Delhi

Former India captain Sardar Singh believes the national men's hockey team has gained confidence at just the right time but success at next month's World Cup and the Asian Games after that will depend on consistent team effort instead of individual brilliance.

India head into the World Cup, beginning August 14, after an encouraging finish in the FIH Pro League, which was otherwise shaping up to be quite disappointing. Craig Fulton's side recovered from a poor start to beat reigning world champions Germany and Olympic champions the Netherlands during the



European leg before stretching England in closely-fought contests, prompting the coach to declare that India can beat any team if they stick to their game plan. Sardar echoed that optimism while underlin-

ing the importance of squad depth, saying the Pro League had served its purpose by allowing the coaching staff to assess the entire core group before the season's biggest assignments.

Rifle shooter Sonam Maskar ready for Asian Games test

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

For Kolhapur's Sonam Uttam Maskar, shooting was just a hobby when she first took interest in the sport but having successfully turned that into a career choice, the rifle shooter is now gearing up for her biggest test so far — a maiden Asian Games appearance in September.

The 23-year-old 10m air rifle shooter announced herself on the international stage in 2024 with three silver medals, including a standout finish at the ISSF World Cup Final in New Delhi, cementing her place among India's brightest shooting talents.

With the ISSF World Cup in Hangzhou starting July 20 coming up before the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, in September-October, Sonam will look to carry that momentum onto the multi-sport showpiece.

Remarkably, it all began as a hobby. "I was always interested in sports and even played chess. I wanted to try something different, so I took up shooting as a hobby.



But it soon became something I wanted to build my career around," she said.

Sonam first picked up a rifle in 2018 while studying commerce in Mumbai. Her journey, however, was disrupted by the COVID-19 pandemic and the financial strain it placed on her family. She resumed training seriously at the Kolhapur shooting range in 2021. "There was

a time when we were facing financial difficulties, especially during the lockdown. When it became clear that I needed my own equipment, my father sold a property so we could buy it.

It was a huge decision, but my family has always backed me," she said. Her father, Uttam Maruti Maskar, sold a family property to keep her dream alive.

Wimbledon women's final sets ESPN viewership record



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Helped by some mid-match drama, the Wimbledon final between Linda Noskova and Karolina Muchova over the weekend was ESPN's most-watched women's championship match at the grass-court Grand Slam.

The all-Czech final, during which Noskova wasted five match points and a 5-2 lead in the second set before eventually winning 6-2, 5-7, 6-3 on Saturday, averaged 1.9 million viewers. That was an increase of 48% compared to last year's women's final: Iga Swiatek's

6-0, 6-0 rout of Amanda Anisimova in 57 minutes.

ESPN began its coverage of Wimbledon in 2003 and has had exclusive rights since 2012. Jannik Sinner's four-set victory over Alexander Zverev in the men's final on Sunday averaged 2.4 million viewers, down 16 per cent from 2025, when Sinner defeated Carlos Alcaraz in four sets. Overall, it ranked as ESPN's second most-viewed Wimbledon, with an 18 per cent year-over-year increase, averaging 853,000 viewers per day, the network said.